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Sub-inspector dies after shooting himself

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A sub-inspector posted at Madhu Vihar police station in East Delhi shot himself with his service pistol on Monday and died of the injury. Police said the initial information indicates he had been suffering from depression for several days as senior officers and a forensic team reached the station to examine the scene and collect evidence.

The deceased has been identified as Somesh Meena, a Sub-Inspector of the 2019 batch. He shot himself on the upper floor of the Madhu Vihar police station.

Personnel present at the station heard the gunshot and rushed to the spot, where they found him injured. He was rushed to the hospital, where doctors declared him dead on arrival. Senior police officers and the forensic team arrived shortly after being informed, examined the site, and collected evidence. The family of the deceased has been notified.

A police investigation into the circumstances and reasons behind the suicide is currently underway. Investigators are examining the case in detail and collect-



ing evidence from the scene. The exact reasons for the act are yet to be officially established, and police are conducting a thorough inquiry.

Two incidents involving Delhi Police personnel and firearms occurred in a single morning on Monday, one an alleged murder and one a suicide, raising broader questions about the welfare and mental health of police personnel in the capital.

The incident at Madhu Vihar police station occurs against the backdrop of growing research and institutional awareness in India about mental health stress among police personnel.

Law enforcement officers routinely face high operational pressure, irregular working hours, prolonged exposure to traumatic incidents, and limited access to

structured psychological support. The police force as an institution has historically stigmatised mental health discussions, which can leave officers suffering from depression, anxiety, or occupational stress without adequate recourse before a crisis point is reached.

Sub-Inspector Meena was of the 2019 batch, meaning he had been in service for approximately seven years at the time of his death. At that career stage, officers typically handle heavy operational workloads while also navigating the personal and professional pressures that build up in the middle years of a police career. The use of a service weapon in a police station adds a dimension that distinguishes such incidents from civilian suicides. Service weapons are issued to protect officers and the public.

PWD plans revamp of ITO pump house

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The PWD is planning to take upgradation work of the ITO pump house, which caters to several areas around the area, officials said on Monday. The ITO pump house is responsible for areas along the Vikas Marg, near Supreme Court metro station, and Tilak Bridge underpass, all of which remain on the watchlist of waterlogging hotspots for the Public Works Department (PWD).

“We plan to install an all-weather sub station at ITO pump house, so that the power supply to the pumping systems remains uninterrupted even during heavy rains and winds. Automatic digital alarm systems will also be installed,” a senior PWD official said.

As part of monsoon preparation, last year, the PWD remodelled drain number 5, which runs from Azad Bhawan to the IP Estate area. This area, which has several government offices,

connected to the ITO pumping station having four permanent pumps.

According to officials, conventionally oil cooled transformers were being used for electrical sub-station but in this case the systems have been changed. At the cost of ₹1.3 crore the revamp work will be carried out which has to be completed in three months time.

“However due to presence of oil for cooling of transformers, an inherent fire risk is involved in the use of oil cooled transformers.

After repeated fire accidents due to burning of oil in those transformers, rules have been amended to provide for use of only dry type transformers,” the tender states.

For the past few years ITO and Ring Road stretch near Indraprastha have been witnessing repeated water-logging episodes. To further strengthen its response to flooding in low-lying areas, the PWD has increased the number of permanent pump houses equipped with automatic pumps.

Factory worker found dead in Begumpur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 19-year-old factory worker was found dead with stab injuries in a forested area in Delhi's Begumpur on Monday, police sources said.

Preliminary inquiry suggests the assailants were known to the victim and the killing may have stemmed from a personal dispute, the source added.

The victim, Chandan, a native of Sitamarhi district in Bihar, was living with his brother in a rented accommodation in Budh Vihar and worked at a factory in the city.

He went missing on Sunday, they said.

The police said they received information on Monday afternoon about a blood-soaked body lying in a forested stretch in Sector 23. A team rushed to the spot and found multiple stab injuries on the victim's body.

The body was shifted to a mortuary for a post-mortem, while the crime team and forensic experts inspected the scene and collected evidence.

“During the investigation, the deceased was identified as Chandan, who had been missing since Sunday. His brother had been searching for him after he failed to return home,” the source said.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I Nirmala Devi Singhal W/o Vinod Singhal R/o C-30 UG Floor Prithviraj Road, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi-110033 have changed my name to Nirmal Singhal.

PD(145)C I, Rghav Juneja S/o Arun Juneja R/o H No. 619 West Bhai Parmanand Colony, Delhi-110009 have changed my name to Raghav Juneja.

PD(146)C I, P Ambaiah, Father of No. 14847137P Nk/SHT Pavuluri Venkateswarlu, R/o- H No.1-118 Regumani Palli (Vi) Vaddimadugu (PO) Konakanamitla (TS) Prakasam (DT) Andhra Pradesh - 523241 have changed my name from P. Ambaiah to Pavuluri Ambaiah, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Meena, Mother of No. 14856787K Sep/MT Ravi Kumar M, R/o- Vill- Keelkudi, PO - Thinayathoor, Teh- Thiruvadanai, Dist- Ramanathapuram Tamilnadu - 623407 have changed my name from Meena to Meena Mari, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.22054703W Sep Dhole Amar Pradipraoji, Serving at- Army Hospital R&R, Delhi Cantt-110010, have changed my father's name in my service record from Pradip Ramkrushna Dhole to Pradip Ramkrushn Dhole, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(153)C I, Jagram Singh, Father of- JC-783143H Nb Sub Ravindra Singh Rathaur, R/o- Vill- Nijampur, PO- Gora Rathore, Dist- Jalaun, U.P.- 285125, have changed my name from Jagram Singh to Jagram, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.22054703W Sep Dhole Amar Pradipraoji, Serving at- Army Hospital R&R, Delhi Cantt-110010, have changed my mother's name in my service record from Sunita to Sunita Pradiprao Dhole, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(154)C I, No.15411528X Hav Sameni Mohan Murali, R/o- AT/PO- Golabandha, Dist- Ganjam, Odisha- 761052, declare that in my service documents my mother's name is wrongly written as Suriya Khantha whereas her correct name is Sameni Suryakanta, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(161)C I, Priya V W/o No. 17018081M CFN Chidambaram D, R/o- 2/173-3 Beerapalayam (Vill), Shoolagiri (Po & Teh), Krishnagiri (Dist), Tamil Nadu - 635117 have changed my name from Priya V to Priya Vijayan, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before SDM Delhi Cantt.

PD(147)C Haritsinh Harshadsinh, R/o- Vill & PO- Jamnagar, Teh- Jamnagar, Dist- Jamnagar, Gujarat, have changed my Daughter's name from Shiyanshiba to Jadeja Shiyanshiba Haritsinh, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(162)C I, Babulal Anuragi, Father of- No.8378227W WO Devendra Kumar Anuragi, R/o- W.No. 18, Amanganji Mohalla, Foola Devi Colony, Chhatrapur, M.P.- 471001, have changed my name from Babulal Anuragi to Babu Lal Anuragi, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(148)C I, P Rajayam, Mother of No. 14847137P Nk/SHT Pavuluri Venkateswarlu, R/o- H No.1-118 Regumani Palli (Vi) Vaddimadugu (PO) Konakanamitla (TS) Prakasam (DT) Andhra Pradesh - 523241 have changed my name from P. Rajayam to Pavuluri Rajayam, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(163)C I, JC-678004A Nb Sub (PA) B Raghupathi Rao Kukkala R/o- Vill- Patakaluva, Satravupalem, Post & Mondal- Mogaltur, Dist- West Godavari, Andhra Pradesh - 534281 have changed my name from B Raghupathi Rao Kukkala to Kukkala Bhanu Raghupathi Rao, vide affidavit dated 07/07/2026 before Notary Public Dimapur, Nagaland.

PD(150)C I, No.14847137P Nk/SHT Pavuluri Venkateswarlu, R/o- H No.1-118 Regumani Palli (Vi) Vaddimadugu (PO) Konakanamitla (TS) Prakasam (DT) Andhra Pradesh - 523241 have changed my daughter's name from Yasaswi to Pavuluri Yasaswi, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(156)C I, Deepmala, W/o JC-782638H Nb/Sub Rama Shankar Kumar, R/o- Vill- Bahuaara Chhapra, PO- Dhanchauha, Dist- Bhojpur, Bihar- 802208, have changed my name from Deepmala to Deep Mala Kumari, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(149)C I, Shashi Prabha Devi, W/o- No.4293666L Nk Kaushal Kumar, R/o- Vill- Nagla Premi, PO- Achalpur, Dist- Etah, U.P.- 207125, have changed my name from Shashi Prabha Devi to Shashi Prabha, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(164)C I, Rohit S/O Vijay Kumar, R/O, Rz - 150 B Dabri. Extension New Delhi - 110045 That My Mother's Name Wrongly Written as Nirmala in Aadhar Card, Actual Name is Nirmal, That Nirmala and Nirmal is One and the Same Person.

PD(152)C I, Mari, Father of No. 14856787K Sep/MT Ravi Kumar M, R/o- Vill- Keelkudi, PO - Thinayathoor, Teh- Thiruvadanai, Dist- Ramanathapuram Tamilnadu-623407 have changed my name from Mari to Mari Arumugam, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(158)C I, Shashi Rathaur, W/o- JC-783143H Nb Sub Ravindra Singh Rathaur, R/o- Vill- Nijampur, PO- Gora Rathore, Dist- Jalaun, U.P.- 285125, have changed my name from Shashi Rathaur to Shashi Rathore, vide affidavit dated 13/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE
My client, Sher Singh S/O Late Nathu Ram R/o H. No. 41, Khizrabad, near New Friends Colony, New Delhi-110025), has disowned his son, Vishal Kumar, and his daughter-in-law, Vanshika, from all his movable and immovable property as well as all family ties due to their misconduct. They alone shall be held responsible for any of their future actions or financial dealings.
Waseem Akram (Advocate)

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is to inform to the public at large that Rajan Gupta who is purchasing the A Vacant Plot bearing No. RZ-232-1/A, land area measuring 101 sq. yds., out of Khassa No. 64/82, Situated at in the abadi of known as Raj Nagar Palam Colony, in the area of Village Palam, Delhi State New Delhi. from 1. Mr. Anuraag Kumar Singh 2. Mr. Raja Bhayya Shukla and same to be financed by ADITYA BIRLA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED That, Original GPA, ATS, and Receipt No. 3553 dated 04.06.1979 executed by Mr. Kishan in favour of Daya Wati in respect of Above Property, have been lost/or not available, if any Person having any type of claim/right/ title/interest over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, liens etc. Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Salira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-4006316 & 41657327

PUBLIC NOTICE
Be it known to the general public that in certain documents, name of Mr. Satpal Gupta, S/o Late Kewal Krishan, aged about 81 years, R/o House No.38, Third Floor, Road No. 58, West Purnagar, Bagli, New Delhi-110026, has been recorded as "Satnarin Singh" alias "Satnarin" or "Satpal Gupta". It is hereby declared that the names refer to one and the same person. The actual name is "Satpal Gupta", and he shall hereafter be known and identified by the name "Satpal Gupta" bearing Aadhar number 886754392437 for all legal and official purposes. This notice is issued for the information of general public.
Through Counsel Adv. Shimpy Arman Sharma En.No.D/1761A/2003 Office: 303 & 404, Silver Arch Apartments, 22, Firoz Shah Road, New Delhi-110001 Ph.: 9971550603

सार्वजनिक सूचना
सर्व साधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि कार्यालय उप निवर्तक सदर द्वितीय माजियाबाद में एक वकील नारायण विनय हुंग श्रीय प्रसाद पुत्री श्री सुधीर प्रसाद, निवासी, New Delhi-110026, has been recorded as "Satnarin Singh" alias "Satnarin" or "Satpal Gupta". It is hereby declared that the names refer to one and the same person. The actual name is "Satpal Gupta", and he shall hereafter be known and identified by the name "Satpal Gupta" bearing Aadhar number 886754392437 for all legal and official purposes. This notice is issued for the information of general public.
मुख्यम सिंह रजिस्ट्रार/अधिकारी कार्यालय उप निवर्तक सदर द्वितीय माजियाबाद

TO WHOMSOEVER IT MAY CONCERN
SHRI SHIRDI SAI PRACHAR SAMITI (Regd.), SAI BABA MANDIR, MASUDA, (INDRA PARK) NAJAFGARH, DELHI-110043
(Brief Information)
PUBLIC NOTICE
ELECTION OF MANAGEMENT COMMITTEE
Notice is hereby given that elections to the Governing Body (President, Vice President, General Secretary, Joint Secretary and Treasurer) of Shri Shirdi Sai Prachar Samiti Temple, Sai Baba Mandir, Masudabad (Indra Park), Najafgarh, Delhi-110043 will be held on Sunday, 26th July 2026, between 9:00 AM and 4:00 PM at the Temple premises.
Key Dates
Event / Date & Time
Publication of Voters List 14.07.2026
Filing of Nominations 18.07.2026 to 20.07.2026 (up to 4:00 PM)
Withdrawal of Candidature 21.07.2026 (10:00 AM to 3:00 PM)
Polling 26.07.2026 (9:00 AM to 4:00 PM)
Counting & Declaration of Results 26.07.2026 (5 PM onwards)
Eligible members may contact the Election / CRO Office at the Temple premises for further details, nomination forms, and the Voters List.
Issued by: Election Committee / Chief Returning Officer
Advocate Vinod Pant Ch-501-501, Western Wing, M.Com, CWA, MBA, LL.B, Tis Hazari, New Delhi - 54

STATE BANK OF INDIA

Home Loan Centre (HLC) C-59
Community Centre, Naraina Industrial Area Phase - 1, New Delhi-110028

DEMAND NOTICE

NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SECURITIZATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 (No. 3 of 2002).

A notice is hereby given that the below mentioned Borrower/s have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest of the loans facility obtained by them from the Bank and the loans have been classified as Non - Performing Assets (NPA). The notices were issued to them under Section 13(2) of Securitization and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 on their last known addresses, but they have been returned unreserved and as such they are hereby informed by way of this public notice.

DESCRIPTION OF HYPOTHECATION OF MOVABLE ASSETS

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower	Details of Properties / Address of Secured Assets to be Enforced	Date of Demand Notice	Amount Outstanding (as on the date of notice)
1.	MR. NITESH JINDAL S/O RAJ KUMAR H. No.75, Upper Ground Floor, Nangloi Extension, C-1, Nangloi, West Delhi-110041. Also At: C/o Infinity Sales and Services, Flat No.751, 1st Floor Weavers Colony, Ashok Vihar, New Delhi-110052. Also At: H. No.90-A, Rajendra Park Extension, Nangloi, Delhi-110041. Also At: C/o JM Sales Corporation, Plot No.92, Rajendra Park Extension, Nangloi, Delhi-41. Car Loan A/c. No.44642377640	Make & Model: TATA SAFARI TS A BS6 D ADV X + DK Vehicle No.: DL9CLB5104 Engine No.: 46354451-4371330 Chassis No.: MAT6318955WJ28998	09/07/2026 Date of N.P.A. 13/04/2026	Rs.26,04,300/- (Rupees Twenty Six Lakh Four Thousand Three Hundred Only) as on 09/07/2026 with further interest and incidental expenses, costs and charges etc. thereon

We invite your attention to the provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act which speaks about the time available to the borrower/guarantor to redeem the secured assets.

The steps are being taken for substituted service of notice. The above Borrower(s) and/or their Guarantor(s) (whenever applicable) are hereby called upon to make payment of outstanding amount within 60 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which further steps will be taken after expiry of 60 days from the date of this notice under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

"This notice is without prejudice to the Bank's right to initiate such other actions or legal proceedings, as it deems necessary under any other applicable provisions of Law".

DATE: 13.07.2026
PLACE: NEW DELHI
Sd/- Authorized Officer & (Chief Manager)
State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, Naraina New Delhi

सेंट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया
Central Bank of India

Regional Office (Gurugram)
1398, First Floor, Chandni Chowk,
Delhi-110006. Tel: 011-41028985

E-AUCTION
SALE NOTICE
(Under SARFAESI Act 2002)

1911 से आपके लिए "सेन्ट्रल" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISIO TO RULE 8(6) & 9(1)] SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) & 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the secured creditor, the **Physical / Symbolic Possession** of which have been taken by the Authorized officer of **Central Bank of India**, secured creditors, will be sold on **06.08.2026 "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis** for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties. For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in: www.centralbank.bank.in or (<https://BAANKNET.com>)

DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTIES TO BE AUCTIONED ON 06.08.2026 (15 DAYS NOTICE)

S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer/B.M.	Name of the Account	Description of Property & Owner Name	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (Rs. in Lakhs)	Date & Time of Possession	Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase
1.	Naraina New Delhi	Ms. Swati Rani Mobile: 8800013528	Satish Kumar Singh and Poonam Singh	Residential Property bearing No. B-1/5 and 6, First Floor Back Side Portion, Without Roof/ Terrace Rights, Area measuring 50 Sq Yards, Situated in the area of Village- Palam, Colony known as Rajapuri, Gali No.- 5, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi- 110059, Owner- Mrs. Poonam Singh W/o Mr. Satish Kumar Singh and Mr. Satish Kumar Singh S/o Mr. Tej Bahadur Singh	Rs. 11,26,590.45 as on 18.12.2025 + + Interest + Other Charges	28.06.2025 (Physical)	₹ 14,40,000.00 ₹ 1,44,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
2.	Delhi Cantonment New Delhi	Mr. Suraj Kumar Mobile: 8957330934	Rajesh Tiwari and Rakesh Tiwari	Flat No- E- 100 (Old No- WZ 346), Flat on Third Floor Without Roof/Terrace Rights, Area measuring 80 Sq Yards, out of Khassa No. 95/22, situated in the area of Village- Palam, Delhi State, Gali No. 17-B, Colony known as Sadh Nagar, New Delhi- 110045, Owner- Mr. Rajesh Tiwari and Mr. Rakesh Tiwari	Rs.25,07,504.42 as on 15.05.2024 + Interest + Other Charges	11.02.2025 (Physical Possession)	₹ 20,70,000.00 ₹ 2,07,000.00 ₹ 20,000.00
3.	Jonapur New Delhi	Mr. Bhushan Kumar Mobile: 9617493179	Mr. Ishwar Singh	EWS Residential Flat No. F-430*1-BHK, Ground Floor Nand Nikunj, Nand Gham, Ghaziabad-201003 Measuring area 19.53 SQ. MTRS in the Name of Mr.Ishwar Singh	Rs.8,00,095.00 on 05.05.2026 + Interest + Other Charges	03.12.2024 (Physical)	₹ 6,84,000.00 ₹ 68,400.00 ₹ 10,000.00
4.	Jonapur New Delhi	Mr. Bhushan Kumar Mobile: 9617493179	Mrs. Kajal Verma & Mr. Sonu Sharma	Residential Flat at Flat No.319-A1-BHK, 1st Floor, Nyay Khand-III, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad-201014, Measuring Area 209.89 Sq.Ft.in the Name of Mr. Sonu Sharma & Mrs. Kajal Verma	Rs.11,98,020.00 on 24.07.2023 + Interest + Other Charges	03.12.2024 (Physical)	₹ 7,92,000.00 ₹ 79,200.00 ₹ 10,000.00

E-AUCTION DATE: 06.08.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 4:00 PM WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES

Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: **06.08.2026 Upto 3:30 PM**. Bidder will register on website: (<https://BAANKNET.com>) and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in Global EMD Wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer (after generation of challan from (<https://BAANKNET.com>)).

The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider "<https://BAANKNET.com>" E-auction will be held on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis. (All other charges/dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser).

For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in www.centralbank.bank.in Secured Creditor or Auction Platform (<https://BAANKNET.com>) **BAANKNET** Helpdesk: (+91)8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com

NOTICE FOR SUB STATUARY 15 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) & 9(1) OF SARFAESI ACT 2002

The borrowers/guarantors/ mortgagors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.

DATE: 13.07.2026
PLACE: DELHI
Authorised Officer, CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA,
Regional Office (Gurugram) Chandni Chowk, Delhi

CM Rekha launches AI Dust Portal 2.0

All construction sites over 500 sq yards to be monitored in real time through cameras and sensors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday launched Dust Portal 2.0, an AI-powered web portal and mobile application developed by the Delhi Pollution Control Committee.

The portal will monitor dust control measures at all construction sites measuring 500 square yards or more in real time using 360-degree PTZ cameras, PM10 and PM2.5 sensors, GIS mapping, and AI-based analytics, with automatic Yellow, Orange, and Red pollution alerts issued as pollution levels rise and compliance certificates and enforcement notices generated automatically without manual intervention.

The Chief Minister said Delhi's fight against air pollution will not rely solely on stricter regulations but also on smart administrative systems. She said Dust Portal 2.0 will change the way dust at construction sites is monitored and managed, and that work is also underway to make the challan process completely digital so that



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Environment Minister Sardar Manjinder Singh Sirsa during the launch of the DPCC 2.0 portal at Delhi Secretariat in New Delhi

PANKAJ KUMAR

notices can be issued directly through the portal, eliminating possibilities of irregularity or inconvenience.

She said AI and digital technology are being used to simplify compliance, strengthen monitoring, and make enforcement more transparent.

The data context for the portal is significant. According to Delhi Government figures, dust from roads, soil, and construction activities accounts for nearly 27 per cent of total air pollution in summer and aroper centpercent in winter. It contributes 66 percent of

PM10 emissions and nearly 38 percent of PM2.5 emissions. Dust Portal 2.0 is specifically designed to address this major pollution source through technology-enabled monitoring.

The portal will automatically assess five key dust control parameters at each registered construction site.

It will identify the nearest Air Quality Monitoring Station to each site and analyse site-level data. When pollution thresholds are crossed, the system will automatically trigger alerts to the concerned agencies. In

case of violations, enforcement notices will be issued digitally through the portal itself, and where sites are compliant, compliance certificates will be generated automatically.

This eliminates the paperwork and manual processing that have historically slowed enforcement.

Dust Portal 2.0 includes comprehensive dashboards for district-wise monitoring, pollution trend tracking, and hotspot analysis, enabling data-driven decision-making by DPCC and Government departments. The portal is available as both an Android and an iOS application, allowing DPCC officials, urban local bodies, and project proponents to monitor compliance remotely using live camera feeds and sensor data. A single platform will bring together information on ongoing and completed construction projects across Delhi, combining audit reports, sensor readings, and compliance status in one place.

Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said the portal has been under development for one year and marks the first time all construction sites above the specified threshold will be monitored through AI rather than manual processes, which he said had significant shortcomings.

Sirsa added that the advanced system will ensure immediate alerts in case of violations and strict action against repeat offenders, making the entire enforcement process more transparent and accountable. He said the portal sets a new benchmark for dust pollution control in Delhi.

Construction site dust has historically been one of the more difficult pollution sources to monitor and control in Delhi, given the large number of sites, the variable scale of activity, and the dependence on physical inspection by a limited number of enforcement personnel. By automating monitoring through continuous sensor data and camera feeds, the portal is designed to extend effective oversight to every registered site simultaneously rather than relying on periodic manual checks.

DERC allows BRPL and BYPL PPAC hike for July; TPDDL gets full requested rate

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC) approved the Power Purchase Adjustment Cost (PPAC) for the month of July 2026 for all three private distribution companies through its order dated July 10.

The order allowed Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) the full 12.21 per cent it requested, while partially approving BSES Rajdhani Power Limited's (BRPL) request of 25.07 per cent at 17.94 per cent and BSES Yamuna Power Limited's (BYPL) request of 19.91 per cent at 17.43 per cent, leaving BRPL with 7.13 per cent and BYPL with 2.48 per cent still to be recovered in future months.

The July PPAC approved by DERC on July 10 is valid for one month. The comparison with June figures shows TPDDL has received a reduction from 15.99 per cent in June to 12.21 per cent in July, which is favourable for consumers in its service area.

BRPL's approved rate remains unchanged at 17.94 per cent from June to July,



while BYPL's approved rate also remains unchanged at 17.43 per cent from the previous month.

PPAC is a charge passed through to electricity consumers to cover the difference between the actual cost of power purchase by distribution companies and the cost assumed in the base tariff. When power purchase costs rise above the base tariff assumption, the gap is recovered from consumers through PPAC. When costs fall, the PPAC charge decreases or turns negative, providing relief to consumers.

The partial approval in BRPL's and BYPL's cases means the distribution companies will need to seek recovery of the balance amounts in subsequent months.

In a separate development,

Delhi Metro Rail Corporation has announced that its 12th Online Customer Satisfaction Survey will run from July 15 to August 14, 2026, seeking feedback from commuters on seven areas of Metro functioning through a comprehensive questionnaire available in both Hindi and English on DMRC's official website at delhimetrorail.com.

The survey links will be available on the DMRC homepage for the full one-month period. Commuters can submit their responses by clicking the links provided.

The survey covers seven topics: availability and accessibility, facilities offered to customers, information systems, quality of services, customer services, the area outside Metro stations, and security, safety, and comfort.

DU UG admissions 2026-27: Tentative schedule, venues of physical trials for ECA quota announced

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University has announced the tentative schedule and venues for physical trials under the Extra-Curricular Activities (ECA) quota for undergraduate admissions, with trials across most categories set to begin from July 16.

This comes amidst the ongoing undergraduate admission through the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) portal.

According to the university, the detailed schedule indicating the date and time slot allotted to individual candidates will be published by July 14 after the correction window for applications closes. No separate communication will be sent to candidates, who have been asked to check the university website for their allotted schedule, it said.

The university said candidates from outside Delhi should book their travel tickets for any date within the notified trial period for their respective ECA category instead of waiting for the



individual schedules, in view of possible difficulties in securing reservations closer to the trial dates.

It also advised such candidates to plan accommodation near the designated trial venue.

The advisory said candidates whose allotted trial date clashes with their confirmed travel itinerary may request a rescheduling by writing to the university, which would accommodate such requests, subject to feasibility within the notified trial period.

According to the tentative schedule, physical trials for dance, debate, music (vocal), and theatre will com-

mence on July 16 and are expected to continue for around a week, excluding Sunday. Yoga trials will begin on July 17 and continue for around two days.

Dance trials, according to the schedule, are expected to be conducted at Bharati College, while debate trials are set to take place in Ramjas College. Quiz trials are scheduled for July 20 at Zakir Hussain Delhi College (evening), while Fine Arts trials will start the same day and continue for three to four days. Creative writing and instrumental music trials, along with digital media and divinity categories, will begin on July 21.

DU SIGNS PACT WITH I4C TO BOOST CYBERSAFETY

New Delhi: Concerned over women students, particularly those from economically weaker sections, falling victim to digital bullying and online fraud, the Delhi University on Monday signed an agreement with the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) to strengthen cyber awareness and safety on campus.

"We have come across instances where female students, particularly those from weaker sections, fall victim to digital bullying and digital fraud. A minor mistake can lead to significant harm. We have entered into this MoU with these issues in mind," University Registrar Vikas Gupta said.

The MoU was signed by Gupta and Nishant Kumar, the director of I4C under the Ministry of Home Affairs, to promote cybercrime prevention, cyber hygiene, cyber awareness, capacity building, academic collaboration, research, internships and student participation, officials said.

18-year-old stabbed to death in Ambedkar Nagar



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An 18-year-old food delivery partner was stabbed to death following an alleged dispute over an order in south Delhi's Ambedkar Nagar area, with police arresting two accused and recovering the weapon used in the crime, an officer said on Monday.

The incident took place on the night of July 10, when police received a PCR call around 9.30 pm reporting a stabbing in the area, the officer said.

A police team rushed to the spot and shifted the injured Krishna Roshan (18) to the AIIMS Trauma Centre. The victim died during treatment, he said. During investigation,

police examined CCTV footage from the area, questioned locals and analysed technical evidence, leading to the identification of the accused, the officer said.

The probe revealed that the murder stemmed from a dispute over non-delivery of certain food items, following which the accused confronted Roshan, triggering an argument. The altercation turned violent and the teen was allegedly stabbed multiple times, police said.

The accused, identified as Rahul alias Dhobi and Rahul Tomar alias Mota, both residents of Subhash Camp in Dakshinpuri, were arrested from Jahanpanah City Forest. Further investigation into the matter is underway.

4 minors feared drowned in Yamuna River; search enters second day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Four minors are feared drowned after they were swept away by the strong current of the Yamuna river while bathing near Hiranki village in outernorth Delhi's Alipur area, with multiple rescue agencies continuing an intensive search operation for the second consecutive day on Monday, officials said.

Police said a PCR call regarding the incident was received at around 7.30 pm on Sunday.

According to the preliminary inquiry, five minors had gone to the Yamuna Ghat near Hiranki village on Sunday evening.

Lucky, who had accompanied the group, told PTI that the five boys had reached the river around 5 pm.

"The road leading to the ghat was muddy. We had gone there together and initially were only washing our hands and feet. Then Saurav decided to take a bath, and Rahul, Amandeep and Anshu followed him," he said. Lucky said he warned his friends against entering the river after noticing the current.

"I told them not to go because the current was very strong. They were holding each other's hands while bathing. Suddenly, the current pulled them away. I started shouting for help," he said.



While they were at the riverbank, four of them entered the water and were swept away by the strong current. The fifth boy managed to escape and alerted nearby people, following which the police and rescue teams were informed.

Teams from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA), Delhi Fire Services and Delhi Police have been carrying out a search operation since Sunday evening.

The operation extended into Monday, but no bodies had been recovered till the filing of this report.

Police said the search operation was being conducted with boats and trained rescue personnel amid a strong river current.

He said three locals rushed to the spot after hearing his cries and helped contact his family members, who later informed the police and the families of the missing boys.

As rescue teams continued to scan the river on Monday, anxious family members remained gathered on the riverbank, refusing to leave despite the passing hours. Every movement of the rescue boats drew their attention, only to be followed by silence as the teams returned without finding the missing boys.

The clothes and slippers the teenagers had left on the rocks before entering the river remained untouched, watched over by relatives who clung to hope that the search would bring some news.

DSEU partners with MAAC to launch creative arts degree programmes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Skill and Entrepreneurship University (DSEU) has signed a five-year Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with MEL Training and Assessments Limited, the parent company of the Maya Academy of Advanced Creativity (MAAC).

DSEU will launch university-recognised degree programmes in animation, visual effects, gaming, and creative arts, with MAAC designing the curriculum and handling industry placements. The DSEU will also provide campus infrastructure, conducts examinations, and awards formal degrees aligned with the National

Education Policy and the National Credit Framework.

Education Minister Ashish Sood announced the initiative alongside two connected measures: a National Film and Design Hackathon to train 20,000 Delhi school students in digital content creation free of cost, and the formation of the Delhi Creators and AVGC-XR Federation, an apex industry body of over 300 animation and technology professionals who will assist the Delhi government in drafting a local industry policy for the creative sector.

The DSEU-MAAC degree pathway addresses a gap that has historically limited students' opportunities to pursue creative arts careers. Training at institutions like



MAAC has carried strong industry credibility but no formal university-recognised degree, which restricted graduates in pursuing higher education abroad or accessing certain categories of employment.

The new programmes,

aligned with the National Credit Framework, change that by giving Class 12 graduates a pathway to a formal degree while receiving curriculum and placement support from an established industry training provider.

The National Film and

Design Hackathon is aimed at the school level, introducing young students to animation, filmmaking, and design through a hands-on competition model rather than conventional classroom instruction. The 20,000 participants will receive free training, providing early exposure to the creative sector as a viable career path at a stage when most students are still deciding their direction.

The Delhi Creators and AVGC-XR Federation brings together professionals from animation, gaming, comics, and extended reality to work directly with Government departments in shaping policy. The formation of a 300-plus-member industry body for this purpose reflects an attempt to ground the

policy framework in the sector's actual conditions rather than develop it through government departments alone.

Together, the three initiatives are aimed at positioning Delhi as a major hub for what the initiative documents refer to as the Orange Economy, the creative and cultural industries sector.

The AVGC-XR sector, which covers animation, visual effects, gaming, comics, and extended reality, is growing nationally at a compound annual growth rate of 16 to 17 per cent. The Government of India's national roadmap identifies it as a sunrise sector with a projected requirement of nearly 20 lakh skilled professionals by 2030.

Government renames Mahila Samriddhi Yojana as Delhi Lakshmi Yojana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has renamed its Mahila Samriddhi Yojana as the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana and set a target to launch it around Raksha Bandhan next month. According to the scheme eligible women between the ages of 21 and 60 to receive ₹2,500 every month.

The Chief Minister Rekha Gupta chaired a high-level review meeting on Monday where eligibility criteria were finalised including a family income cap of ₹2.5 lakh annually and a ten-year Delhi residency requirement.

The Chief Minister said the scheme will provide women in Delhi with a foundation for financial empowerment, self-reliance, and dignity. She said when a woman in a household becomes financially secure, it accelerates the progress of the entire family and society.

The eligibility criteria finalised at Monday's meeting are specific and designed to target women in genuine financial need.

Applicants and their families must have been residents of Delhi for at least ten years. Neither the woman nor any member of her family should have a criminal

record. Within a family, only the eldest eligible woman will qualify, and only one woman per family will receive the benefit.

The family's annual income must not exceed ₹2.5 lakh. Women already receiving benefits under any government pension or other regular financial assistance scheme will not be eligible. Women from families that own a four-wheeler also will not qualify.

Chief Secretary Rajeev Verma and senior officials from concerned departments attended the Monday meeting. The Chief Minister directed officials to ensure



that the scheme's benefits reach all eligible women in a transparent, simple, and time-bound manner, without administrative hurdles, and instructed them to ensure

strict adherence to the guidelines so that only genuine beneficiaries receive the money.

The scheme has previously been referred to as the

Mahila Samriddhi Yojana and was announced as part of the BJP's pre-election commitments for Delhi. I

t is part of a broader category of direct cash transfer programmes for women that have been implemented or announced by several State Governments across India in recent years, including the Ladli Behna Yojana in Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra, the Gruha Lakshmi scheme in Karnataka, and the Orunodoi scheme in Assam. The monthly amount of ₹2,500 positions the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana within the mid-range of such schemes nationally. The Raksha Bandhan target

for rollout is significant both symbolically and logistically.

The festival, which falls in August, provides a culturally resonant moment for the launch of a women's welfare scheme. It also sets a concrete deadline that will require the Government to complete beneficiary identification, eligibility verification, bank account linking, and the initial payment cycle within approximately a month from the announcement of the finalised criteria.

The Chief Minister described women's empowerment as a key pillar of good governance for the Delhi government.

The Delhi Government estimates that the scheme will directly benefit lakhs of women across the capital, though a specific beneficiary count was not cited at the Monday review.

Implementation of direct benefit transfer schemes of this scale typically requires significant backend work including building the beneficiary database, verifying income and residency documentation, checking for criminal records, and identifying the eldest eligible woman in each family, all of which will need to be completed before the first disbursement can be made.

IN FOCUS



Blue tiger butterflies perch during monsoon in Bhopal

PTI

69 roads closed in Himachal Pradesh after torrential rainfall

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shimla

Light to moderate rainfall was witnessed in parts of Himachal Pradesh on Monday, with the weather office issuing an alert for heavy rain at isolated places in the State on Saturday and Sunday.

As many as 69 roads — 38 in Kullu, 13 in Mandi, six in Sirmaur, five in Shimla, four in Kangra, two in Una and one in Lahaul-Spiti districts — are closed following torrential rainfall, while 80 water supply projects are disrupted, according to the state emergency operations centre (SEOC).

So far, 25 landslides have been reported in the current monsoon season during the month of July,



Students seeking shelter as they walk amid rain in Kolkata

PTI

which received 125 mm of rain against a normal of 94.5 mm, an excess of 32 per cent. Kasauli in Solan district received 62 mm rainfall in the 24 hours since Sunday evening, followed by Olinda (60 mm), Dharampur (54.6 mm), Nangal Dam (48.2 mm), Brahmani (42.4 mm) and Una (35.4 mm).

Thunderstorms were witnessed in Shimla, Sundernagar, Bhuntar, Kangra, Jot and Murari Devi while gusts with wind speed ranging between 37-50 kmph lashed Bilaspur, Neri, Shimla, Kufri, Hamirpur, Sundemagar and Tabo. Keylong in Lahaul-Spiti was coldest in the state on Monday, recording a low of 8.4 degrees Celsius, while Neri was hottest with a maximum of 35 degrees Celsius.

Rajaji tree felling intensified amid national highway protests

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Saat Mod

Amidst public agitation against the proposed Rishikesh-Bhaniyawala four-lane National Highway project, which passes through a sensitive elephant corridor in Rajaji National Park, the felling of trees was intensified on Monday.

Bina Verma, who has been travelling about 30 km daily from Dehradun to reach Saat Mod over the past few days, said, "Natural heritage cannot be destroyed in the name of development. Lush green trees are being cut down continuously. I fear that in the future, we might have to tell our children that a dense forest once existed here."

Under this widening project, there is a plan to cut around 3,000 trees in the 'Saat Mod' area of the Doon



Valley. For the past several days, environmentalists, social activists, students, and local citizens have been staging protests and sit-ins, demanding the protection of the forests and the wildlife inhabiting them.

As a reminder of the 'Chipko Movement' led by Gaura Devi decades ago, the protesters hugged trees in an effort to save them. However, amidst the intense protest, the police forcibly removed them and took them away from the site.

PM to inaugurate redeveloped Mangalagiri railway station virtually on July 17

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will virtually dedicate the redeveloped Mangalagiri railway station to the nation on July 17.

Mangalagiri Railway Station, a Non-Suburban Grade category station under Guntur Division, has been redeveloped for Rs 12.5 crore with upgraded passenger amenities and modern infrastructure, a press release said on Monday.

The redevelopment is aimed at improving passenger safety, accessibility and travel experience, it added. "As part of the Government of India's transformative Amrit Bharat Station Scheme, the redeveloped Mangalagiri Railway Station under Guntur Division will be dedicated to the nation by PM Modi through a virtual inaugura-



tion on July 17," it said. The redevelopment works include the comprehensive renovation of the existing station building and the construction of a modern second-entry station building with a booking office, waiting halls and a VIP lounge.

The project will feature an aesthetically enhanced station facade, a spacious

entrance porch, upgraded waiting halls, modern toilets, improved platform surfacing, durable seating, standardised passenger signage and extensive landscaping.

To ensure seamless accessibility for all passengers, the station has been equipped with two lifts and accessible facilities, including tactile pathways, ramps and acces-

sible toilets, the press release said. New platform shelters have been provided on Platforms 1 and 4, while the front and rear circulating areas have been redeveloped with dedicated parking, pedestrian pathways, street lighting, lane markings and landscaping.

Access control measures, including boundary walls and wider entry and exit gates, have been put in place to ensure smooth passenger movement.

The inauguration of the redeveloped station marks another milestone in the modernisation of railway infrastructure under the ABSS, the release said.

It added that the project reflects Indian Railways' commitment to enhancing passenger comfort, accessibility and operational efficiency while preserving the unique identity of railway stations.

Mamata tells EC: No more time for Ritabrata faction

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Trinamool Congress chairperson Mamata Banerjee has written to the Election Commission, urging it not to give more time to a rival faction led by Ritabrata Banerjee to submit claims on authorised signatories and organisational polls.

An ongoing tussle within the party intensified on July 2 when the rebel faction approached the EC to claim to be the "real" All India Trinamool Congress (AITC).

The faction said it had informed the commission after a special session it held on June 22 and sought recognition of the organisational changes it claimed to have carried out.

Following the claim, the poll body sent letters to both Mamata Banerjee and Ritabrata Banerjee, asking them to submit their responses by 5.30 pm on July 6. While the Mamata Banerjee-led group submitted its response on July 6 before the deadline, the Ritabrata-led faction got an extension till 5.30 pm, July 10, to submit its response.

In her letter to the poll panel dated July 12, Mamata Banerjee, a former West Bengal chief minister, said, "Though it is well past 10th July 2026, and it has



been about 2 days therefrom, there has not been any communication made to the undersigned from the end of Shri Ritabrata Banerjee concerning such reply." She said that they have not received any response from the Ritabrata Banerjee-led faction so far.

According to TMC sources, the EC had asked both sides to keep each other informed about the response.

"Hence, it can be inferred, in the absence or the failure to communicate to the undersigned, despite the precondition imposed by the Election Commission of India, that the Election Commission has also not been provided with the said reply within the extended time period," she said.

The leader said that the "leeway" granted to Ritabrata to file the reply at a later stage was not extended to them, and they were given "virtually two half-working days to reply to the communication dated 2nd July 2026."

"Even after the delay of another 48hrs from 10th July, your good office has maintained a stoic silence, giving further elbow-room to Shri Banerjee, demonstrating your inclination towards the mala fide cause of Shri Ritabrata Banerjee," she said.

"Therefore, it is vehemently asserted that the reply submitted from the end of the undersigned should be considered at the earliest without giving further time to the said Shri Ritabrata Banerjee," Mamata added.

TMC MP Mahua Moitra, meanwhile, accused the poll panel of giving the rebels "special treatment" and questioned its impartiality.

"The Election Commission is expected to function as a neutral constitutional authority and provide a level playing field. Why has this additional time and special treatment been given to the other side after they failed to meet the original deadline, while we complied within time?" she said at a press conference.

Hussain convicted for Ankit Sharma murder

Some accused have been convicted, while others are still on trial or have been acquitted.

Tahir Hussain's conviction is part of his ongoing legal battles in several riot-related cases. The AAP leadership has not yet given a detailed public response to this verdict. Sentencing is scheduled for July 16.

The court's decision is an important outcome in a sensitive case from the 2020 Delhi riots. It shows the justice system's ongoing effort to hold people accountable for the violence that affected Delhi six years ago. This case highlights the complexity of the riots, with communal tensions and claims of targeted conspiracy in some incidents. Prosecuting large-scale mob violence years later remains a challenge. More updates are expected after the sentencing on July 16, 2026.

Suspended BKTC staffer arrested in Badrinath...

The complaint, filed by BKTC in-charge Temple Officer Yudhvir Pushpwan (also referred to as Farswan in some reports), alleged misappropriation and theft of devotees' offerings.

A preliminary internal inquiry by the BKTC had earlier found prima facie evidence of irregularities during the counting of cash offerings at the temple around July 2. Nautiyal was suspended following the inquiry.

CCTV footage from the offering and counting area reportedly shows Nautiyal hiding cash notes, packets of gold and silver coins, Shaligram shilas, and kesar packets. When police searched his home in Dehradun, they found a Shaligram stone and a laptop. No large amount of cash has been found yet. Investigators are now seeking a police remand to trace the money and determine whether others were involved.

Nautiyal approached the Uttarakhand High Court. Nautiyal has gone to the Uttarakhand High Court to challenge his suspension and the FIR. The court has asked the BKTC to respond, and the next hearing is set for July 16. This case is part of a wider investigation into financial irregularities at the Badrinath and Kedarnath temples. Earlier, the Uttarakhand Government ordered a probe into claims of unauthorised advance payments from temple funds for VIP guests at Kedarnath.

A Government inquiry found early signs of irregularities involving several officials. Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami had directed a detailed investigation after allegations of donation mishandling surfaced.

Police said Nautiyal will be produced before a court in Gopeshwar after interrogation and medical examination. The investigation is being monitored by senior police officers, with the Special Investigation Team (SIT) also involved. Further arrests cannot be ruled out, sources said. The BKTC manages the affairs of the Badrinath and Kedarnath temples under the Shri Badrinath-Kedarnath Temple Committee Act, 1939.

Mediation bid fails for 3 UP shrine cases

The Gyanvapi issue in Varanasi is an ongoing civil court case involving conflicting claims over the religious status of Gyanvapi mosque, which lies adjacent to the Kashi Vishwanath Temple.

The Hindu side claims that the mosque was built after Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb destroyed parts of the ancient temple in the 17th century.

The Muslim side maintains that the mosque predates Aurangzeb's reign and is a legitimate Waqf property.

In the Sambhal Shahi Jama Masjid-Hari Har temple dispute, mosque committee's counsel Shakeel Ahmad Warsi said the issue involved religious faiths and was too sensitive to be resolved through compromise.

"This is a sensitive matter involving Hindus, Muslims and religious beliefs. Whether it is a temple or a mosque should be decided by the court, not through mutual settlement," Warsi told PTI. He said the Muslim side had informed the court that while anyone could seek to intervene in the proceedings, such attempts should not be driven by mala fide intentions as the matter concerned a religious place.

Hindu side counsel Gopal Sharma said he was not aware of any proposal for mediation in the Sambhal case.

The Sambhal dispute is similar to the Varanasi issue, where there are conflicting claims over the religious character of the site.

Hindu petitioners have alleged that the 16th-century Jama Masjid was built at the site of an ancient Hari Har Mandir, a claim disputed by the Muslim side.

In the Sri Krishna Janmabhoomi-Shahi Eidgah dispute, mediation proceedings held before the District Legal Services Authority in Mathura earlier this month failed after no representative of the Muslim side attended the meeting, Hindu side's counsel Hareram Tripathi said.

He said both parties had been invited twice to participate in the conciliation process, but the Muslim side did not appear, following which the mediation proceedings were closed.

According to Tripathi, the Sri Krishna Janmabhoomi Trust had proposed that if the Muslim side relinquished its claim over the disputed site, the trust could consider facilitating land for construction of a mosque elsewhere.

He said the Muslim side had conveyed that it was not willing to settle the dispute through mediation and preferred adjudication through regular court proceedings.

The Allahabad High Court has fixed July 17 for further proceedings in the matter, while the Supreme Court may take it up during the Special Lok Adalat in August as part of the mediation initiative.

Attempts by PTI to contact Shahi Eidgah Intezamia Committee secretary and Muslim side counsel Tanveer Ahmad for comment did not elicit a response.

Hindu litigant Mahendra Pratap Singh said the Hindu side continued to maintain before the court that the disputed site was the birthplace of Lord Krishna and would pursue the matter

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through the judicial process.

The Sri Krishna Janmabhoomi-Shahi Idgah dispute in Mathura arose after the Hindu side filed a petition alleging that the mosque was built in the 17th century on the exact spot where Lord Krishna was born.

India's women conquer Lord's with historic win

Rana bowled a beauty to finally get rid of Ecclestone, triggering on field celebrations and in the Indian dressing room.

Both India and England had endured disappointment in the preceding T20 World Cup and with Lord's hosting a Women's Test 142 years after it conducted the first men's Test, there was a lot at stake for both teams.

The foundation of the win for India was laid by Smriti Mandhana and Yastika Bhatia, who scored a memorable hundred on day three, before Kranti Gaud headlined the bowling performance with a five-wicket haul and her name on the Lord's Honours Board.

The Indian batters showed a lot more application than their English counterparts on a pitch that offered seam movement and by day three the odd ball was keeping low.

Pacers Gaud and Sayali Satghare outbowled their opponents, using the slope effectively to generate plenty of seam movement. Off-spinner Rana too was able to maintain the pressure created by the seamers.

With the massive win, India also maintained their superior record against England in the longest format. In the 16 Tests both teams have played, India have won four games, England one while the remaining 11 matches were drawn.

India's only defeat to England came way back in 1995. The Indian team had got a pep talk from the great Sachin Tendulkar before the start of day's play. ICC chairman Jay Shah was also watching the action from the stands with Tendulkar, who later shook hands with the players.

It was also a farewell game for England veteran Tammy Beaumont and former captain Heather Knight.

High alert ahead of PM's Punjab-Haryana visit

The email's reference to Diljit Dosanjh is tied to the controversy surrounding the film Satluj, in which he plays Jaswant Singh Khalsa. The movie centres on Khalsa's investigation into the alleged illegal cremation of thousands of bodies in Punjab between 1984 and 1994 during the height of militancy. Released on ZEE5 on July 3, the film was pulled from the platform in India within 48 hours on security grounds.

A Government committee has recommended keeping the ban in place under the IT Act. Some critics, such as Union Minister Ravneet Singh Bittu, say the film gives a one-sided view and downplays militant violence during the insurgency.

Punjab, Chandigarh and Haryana Police, along with cyber cells and railway security, have launched a full-scale probe. Technical teams are

tracing the email's origin while security has been tightened at schools, railway stations, Government buildings and other sensitive sites.

Officials are assessing the threat's credibility even as no corroborating intelligence has surfaced so far. The repeated pattern from the same claimed source has forced a strong precautionary response.

The episode shows how fringe separatist elements continue to weaponise historical grievances and recent cultural controversies through anonymous digital threats. Security agencies are not taking chances ahead of the Prime Minister's high-profile engagements", a well-placed official said on Monday.

Birthday bloodbath: Delhi cop shoots wife

The constable allegedly shot her near LBS Hospital and fled on the scooter.

Priyanka, 34, was a teacher at a private school in Ashok Vihar. The couple had married in 2023. Neighbours told police that arguments between the couple were frequent. Priyanka's family has alleged that she was subjected to dowry harassment from the time of her marriage and that Manish had been demanding money from her family.

The family said a complaint was filed earlier with the Women's Cell, but the matter was settled following counselling and intervention by relatives. The family's allegation, if substantiated, would bring the case under the provisions covering dowry harassment alongside the murder charge.

Police said the family's allegations are being verified as part of the investigation, and appropriate legal action will be taken based on the evidence collected. A murder case has been registered. Investigators are examining the couple's marital relationship, any past complaints on record, and other possible motives for the killing. The body has been sent for post-mortem. Forensic experts have examined the crime scene.

The case has an additional layer that makes it particularly concerning for the police institution. The accused is a serving Delhi Police constable, which means he had access to a service weapon, and he is alleged to have used that weapon to kill his wife. The same weapon used in his official capacity to prevent crime appears, according to the preliminary evidence, to have been turned on a family member in a domestic dispute that escalated on a public road in the early hours of Monday.

Bhati has been absconding since the shooting, and investigators are working to trace him despite the CCTV footage that provides a clear visual record of the incident. Police have said his arrest and interrogation will be necessary to establish the complete sequence of events and the motive.

US to charge ships for Hormuz passage: Trump

The US and others dispute that, citing interna-

tional law on freedom of navigation, and the American military has tried to establish an alternative route outside of Iranian control.

Iran and the US are nearly halfway through the 60-day period in which they were supposed to negotiate a permanent end to the war and an agreement on Iran's disputed nuclear program. Instead, a series of attacks over the strait have raised fears of a return to all-out war and further disruption to the global economy.

Oil prices jumped nearly 5 per cent on Monday before falling back. US benchmark crude, which had risen to nearly USD 120 a barrel at the height of the war, was trading at around USD 72.92. Markets were mixed.

Meanwhile, the US military said it struck dozens of sites in the strikes on Monday, including air defence systems, radar sites, missile and drone equipment, and small boats. It said Iran does not control the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump suggested last week that the interim deal in the war was "over." But mediators, including Pakistan, Qatar and Egypt, have continued efforts to reach a final agreement to end the war. (AP)

SC seeks SIT report in Ayodhya donation row

Earlier, a partial working day bench headed by Justice BV Nagarathna had asked one of the petitioners to mention the case for urgent hearing on a later date.

The petition, filed by practicing advocates Ajay Kumar Rai and Dinesh Kumar Yadav, said a CBI-led multi-disciplinary SIT should investigate the alleged financial irregularities and other purported illegalities concerning the affairs and administration of the temple trust.

In the petition, Rai sought directions to the Centre, the Uttar Pradesh government and the Trust for constituting and operationalising such regulatory, supervisory and audit mechanisms, as may be necessary, to safeguard public interest and maintain the confidence of millions of devotees and donors.

Whether or not the reports regarding missing funds and other alleged irregularities concerning the Trust are ultimately found to be true, such reports have caused deep concern among the generations that struggled for the restoration of the glory of Ayodhya, the plea said. It also said the SIT constituted by the Uttar Pradesh Government commenced its inquiry into the matter without the registration of an FIR or any regular criminal case.

The plea said the issues involved not only concern the possible commission of cognisable offences but also directly affect the faith, sentiments and confidence of countless devotees and the public.

On June 13, the Uttar Pradesh Government constituted the SIT on a request from the temple trust following allegations of misappropriation of donations received at the Ram temple.

The Special Investigation Team comprises Lucknow Divisional Commissioner Vijay Vishwas Pant, Inspector General of Police Kiran S and Special Secretary (Finance) Neel Ratan.

■ States Focus ■

■ BJP slaps ₹100 cr defamation notice on Omar Abdullah ■

DMK SUBMITS HORSE-TRADING EVIDENCE TO TN GOVERNOR

DMK Organising Secretary RS Bharathi on Monday said that his party "submitted evidence on horse-trading in Tamil Nadu" to Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar. "The material evidence" included the statement made by MDMK chief Vaiko on the horse-trading of MLAs and a public remark by former AIADMK legislator MR Vijayabaskar, which were submitted to the Governor, Bharathi said. The evidence was submitted to DVAC as well to corroborate the systematic practice of horse-trading in the State, he added. "We submitted the evidence as supplementary to our complaint dated July 1, on the systematic practice of horse-trading by the ruling TVK," Bharathi told reporters. The party had included the statement made by Vijayabaskar, who had recently made the remark during an informal press meet that he was approached by the TVK, he added. (PTI)

MOHIT KANDHARI

Jammu

The Jammu and Kashmir unit of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Monday served a legal notice to Chief Minister Omar Abdullah demanding that he either substantiate or withdraw his serious allegations that the national party had attempted to bribe National Conference legislators with cash and ministerial berths in a bid to topple his Government.

The notice, which includes a demand for a written retraction and an unconditional public apology within seven days, threatens civil and criminal defamation proceedings, including a ₹100 crore damages suit, if the Chief Minister fails to comply.

In response to the legal notice, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah took a light-hearted yet defiant tone, calling the communication a "love letter" from the BJP.

Interacting with the media persons at the party head-

quarters in Srinagar, on the sidelines of a homage ceremony, Omar said that he felt "honoured" to be the only politician in Jammu and Kashmir to receive such attention, signalling that the notice only underscored his growing relevance as a political force the saffron party could not ignore.

The chief minister, while addressing National Conference (NC) workers at Hazratbal last week, alleged that the BJP is trying to bring down his Government by engineering a split in his party. He also claimed that an NC MLA from Jammu told him that he was offered ₹20-30 crore and a ministerial berth to switch sides to the saffron camp.

The notice has been issued through advocate Parimoksh Seth on the instructions of BJP J&K Unit president and Rajya Sabha MP Sat Paul Sharma. It contends that the chief minister's statements have caused serious damage to the reputation and public standing of

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah

the BJP and its office-bearers.

According to the three-page notice, Abdullah alleged that BJP functionaries had approached certain National Conference MLAs from the Jammu region with offers of ₹20-30 crore, ministerial berths and restoration of Statehood in an attempt to persuade them to switch allegiance to the BJP. It refers to the chief minister's allegation that a senior BJP office-bearer, who is also

a lawyer practising in the Supreme Court, allegedly played a role in offering the inducements. Rejecting the allegations, the BJP has described them as "entirely untrue, malicious and without any factual basis."

The notice states that the allegations were deliberately made to tarnish the party's image and have been widely circulated, thereby causing substantial reputational harm.

The legal notice asserts that the allegations amount to defamation under both civil and criminal law and calls upon the chief minister to withdraw his charges in writing.

"Issue an unconditional public apology within seven days of receiving the notice. Refrain from publishing or circulating any further defamatory material concerning the BJP. Immediately cease and desist from making or repeating any such statements," it said.

The BJP has warned that if the demands are not complied with within the stipulated period, it will initiate appropriate civil and criminal proceedings before a competent court. These would include a defamation suit seeking damages of ₹100 crore, apart from other legal remedies available under the law.

Interacting with the media persons, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah said he was expecting a political response from

1,679 illegal immigrants sent back: Himanta

TONY DAS

Guwahati

More than 1,600 illegal immigrants from Bangladesh have been repatriated from Assam in the last two years, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said on Monday.

Replying to a question from AIUDF legislator Badruddin Ajmal, Sarma laid in the Assembly that the State follows the Central Government's directives in the matter of citizenship, and enough safeguards have been ensured so that human rights violations do not take place while implementing laws in this regard.

"A total of 1,679 illegal immigrants have been repatriated (deported/sent back/expelled) from Assam to Bangladesh in the last two years," Sarma, who also holds the Home and Political Department, said.

Sharing the list in the House, he

Court or the Supreme Court.

Asked about the procedure followed by the Government to 'push back' the infiltrators, the CM said that the subject of citizenship is a matter under the Central Government.

The State Government follows the existing provisions of law as well as the directions issued by the Centre from time to time while taking action against illegal immigrants. The Assam Government does not deal directly with any other foreign country, bypassing the Centre, he said.

"The State Government implements the provisions of law as well as directions issued by the Centre pertaining to the citizenship matter. While implementing such laws and directions, enough safeguards are put in place so that the human rights of an individual are not violated," Sarma added.

Brewers body calls for Bihar liquor policy reset

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

The Brewers Association of India (BAI) has urged the Bihar Government to undertake a comprehensive review of the State's liquor prohibition policy, arguing that the law has failed to eliminate alcohol consumption while creating severe social, economic and administrative consequences.

In a letter to Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary, BAI Director General Mr Vinod Giri has stated that Bihar stands at a critical policy crossroads and has an opportunity to replace "an ineffective prohibition model with a socially responsible and economically sustainable regulatory framework."

BAI, the apex body representing India's largest beer manufacturers, including AB InBev, Carlsberg and United Breweries, said the evidence accumulated over the last decade suggests that prohibition has merely shifted alcohol consumption from regulated and taxed channels to an underground and unregulated economy. Representing India's largest beer manufacturers, includ-

resources toward enforcement while organised bootlegging networks have expanded across the State.

Calling the fiscal implications of prohibition "staggering", BAI estimated that Bihar has foregone up to ₹60,000 crore in excise revenues over the last decade, in addition to losses suffered by hospitality, tourism, logistics and ancillary industries.

BAI has proposed a phased and carefully regulated approach focused on moderation and harm reduction.

Its recommendations include introduction of low-alcohol beverages such as beer and wine as the first step, limited rollout in urban areas and economic zones with good regulatory oversight, adoption of alcohol-content based taxation models to encourage lower-strength beverages, creation of dedicated funds for de-addiction programmes and rehabilitation services and mandating allocation of over 50 per cent of the factory floor jobs to women to support their economic empowerment amongst others.

INDIAN NAVY

COMBAT READY COHESIVE AATMANIRBHAR

JOIN AS SHORT SERVICE COMMISSION OFFICERS FOR VARIOUS ENTRIES

COURSE COMMENCING - JUN 2027 (AT 27)

Online applications are invited from unmarried men & women candidates for grant of Short Service Commission in Executive, Education and Technical Branches at Indian Naval Academy (INA), Ezhimala, Kerala.

DATE OF OPENING – 25 JUN 26 | LAST DATE FOR ONLINE APPLICATION – 27 JUL 26

EMPLOYMENT NEWS DATED 27 JUNE 2026

Branch / Cadre	Vacancies	Gender
Executive Branch {GS(X)}/Hydro Cadre}	90 (including 10 Hydro)	Men and Women {maximum of 10 vacancies in GS (X) and 02 vacancies in Hydro for women}
Pilot	25	Men and Women (maximum of 03 vacancies for women)
Naval Air Operation Officer (Observers)	18	Men and Women (maximum of 03 vacancies for women)
Air Traffic Controller	15	Men and Women
Logistics	10	Men and Women (maximum of 02 vacancies for women)
Naval Armament Inspectorate Cadre (NAIC)	14	Men and Women
Education	13	Men and Women
Engineering Branch {General Service (GS)}	24	Men and Women (maximum of 04 vacancies for women)
Submarine Tech Engineering	08	Only for Men
Electrical Branch {General Service (GS)}	32	Men and Women (maximum of 05 vacancies for women)
Submarine Tech Electrical	08	Only for Men
Naval Constructor	18	Men and Women

For eligibility criteria and details visit www.joinindiannavy.gov.in

Safeguarding Seas for a Viksit Samriddha Bharat

CBC 10701/13/0016/2627



The Pioneer launches Keralam edition

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The Pioneer marked a significant milestone in its journey with the launch of its Keralam edition at a function held at the Hycinth Hotel in Thiruvananthapuram on Monday evening, reaffirming the newspaper's commitment to credible, independent and impactful journalism in the State.

The Keralam Edition was formally inaugurated and released by Chief Minister VD Satheesan, who delivered the inaugural address, highlighting the vital role of a free, responsible and people-centric media in strengthening democracy.

"This is a time when we cannot say anything new," he said. "What we say is being twisted. We have to think very seriously about how it will affect society. But if we are convinced that what we do is right, then no matter what controversy comes up, the Government should go ahead and do it courageously. "The beauty of democracy is in discussion. We need to have positive discussions about the state, about the next generation, and about children. The media has a huge role to play in that," Satheesan added.



Keralam Chief Minister VD Satheesan releasing the Keralam edition of *The Pioneer* by handing it over to Deputy Speaker Shanimol Usman in Thiruvananthapuram on Monday. CPI State secretary Binoy Viswam, Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala, *The Pioneer* Keralam Editor Bandi Sudhakara Goud, *The Pioneer* group of newspapers and magazines Chairman Prashant Tewari, Gururatnam Jnana Tapasy and Palayalam Imam VP Suhaib Moulavi also graced the occasion

The inaugural copy of the edition was received by Deputy Speaker of the Kerala Legislative Assembly, Shanimol Usman.

Welcoming the gathering, J Gopikrishnan, Associated Editor of *The Pioneer*, New Delhi, outlined the newspaper's editorial vision and its commitment to delivering

accurate, balanced and public-interest journalism to readers in Kerala.

Presiding over the function, Bandi Sudhakara Goud, Managing Director and Editor of *The Pioneer* Keralam edition, described the launch in the Capital city as an important step in the publication's expansion and

reaffirmed its commitment to journalistic excellence, editorial independence and credible reporting.

Ramesh Chennithala, Minister for Home Affairs, Government of Kerala, attended the programme as the Guest of Honour and addressed the gathering. He appreciated *The Pioneer's*

decision to launch its Keralam edition. He recalled that *The Pioneer* carried out several turbulent stories in the country. He also recalled his decades-long friendship with Sudhakara Goud from the time when both of them were Youth Congress leaders. He wished the Pioneer to be a strong pres-

ence in the Kerala media landscape. He noted that it is only the print media that is willing to correct itself, whereas the visuals don't correct wrong news. Congress Media and Publicity Chairman and Rajya Sabha MP Pawan Kherra graced the occasion.

In his felicitation address, Prashant Tewari, Chairman & Managing Director of *The Pioneer* group of newspapers and magazines, New Delhi, congratulated the team on the launch of the Keralam Edition and conveyed his best wishes for its success, expressing confidence that the new edition would uphold *The Pioneer's* legacy of credible, independent and impactful journalism.

The function was also attended by several distinguished personalities, including Binoy Viswam, State Secretary of the CPI; Swami Gururethnam Jnana Thapaswi, General Secretary of Santhigiri Ashram; Dr VP Suhaib Maulavi, Imam of Palayam Juma Masjid; and KP Reji, State President of the Kerala Union of Working Journalists.

The programme commenced with a prayer and concluded with a vote of thanks proposed by Saritha S Balan, Deputy Bureau Chief, *The Pioneer*, Thiruvananthapuram.

Nation Focus



FADNAVIS MEETS PAWAN KALYAN IN MUMBAI HOSPITAL

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Monday visited Andhra Pradesh Deputy CM Pawan Kalyan at Mumbai's Kokilaben Dhirubhai Ambani Hospital where the latter is recovering after undergoing surgery. Fadnavis said he wished Kalyan a speedy and complete recovery. "Visited Andhra Pradesh DCM Pawan Kalyan ji at Kokilaben Dhirubhai Ambani Hospital in Mumbai, where he is recovering after a surgery. Wishing him a speedy and complete recovery," Fadnavis said in a post on X. In a statement on Sunday, the hospital said Kalyan was diagnosed with a right shoulder rotator cuff injury, comprising an extensive tear of the supraspinatus and infraspinatus tendon with an associated avulsion fracture of the greater tuberosity bone. He underwent successful arthroscopic repair of the injury at Kokilaben Hospital. (PTI)



MP GOVT PANEL ON UCC SUBMITS REPORT TO CHIEF MINISTER

The committee constituted to draft a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) for Madhya Pradesh has recommended exclusion of tribals from its scope in its report submitted to CM Mohan Yadav on Monday, an official statement said. The report of the Government-appointed multi-member panel, which was headed by retired SC Judge Ranjana Prakash Desai, has been forwarded to the Law Department, it said. After revision and process (consideration) of the Senior Secretary Committee, a bill on UCC is likely to be tabled in the Assembly during the upcoming monsoon session after approval by the Cabinet, said the statement. The five-day monsoon session of the State Assembly will be held from July 20. CM Yadav thanked all panel members, including the chairperson, for submitting the report within the stipulated time, said the statement. Committee members Prof Gopal Sharma, Budhpal Singh, Shobha Paithankar, and Member Secretary Ajay Katesaria were present. (PTI)

Centre approves ₹14,300 crore Budget for Puducherry



Puducherry CM Rangasamy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Puducherry

The Union Home Ministry has conveyed the Centre's approval of the Puducherry Government's proposal for a ₹14,300 crore Budget for the fiscal 2026-2027.

In a letter to the Chief Secretary of the Puducherry administration on Monday, the Under Secretary to the Home Department said the proposal was examined in consultation with the Finance Ministry.

He said the President of India had accordingly approved the laying of the annual financial statement for 2026-2027 before the Legislative Assembly of Puducherry.

The AINRC-Bharatiya Janata Party coalition Government was formed in May, in the wake of the Assembly polls on April 9. The Assembly is likely to meet later this month, when the budget for the new fiscal year will be presented by Chief Minister N Rangasamy, official sources said.

Row erupts as Govt plans to shift mosque inside NSI airport

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

There was political controversy after the Government suspended indefinitely the offering of *namaz* at Bakra Mosque (Gouripur Jame Masjid), which is situated inside the Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose International Airport at Dum Dum in Kolkata.

Rejecting the Government's claim that a running mosque inside an international airport and barely a few hundred

metres from the runway with regular public access was a security concern, senior Trinamool Congress MP Sougato Roy on Monday said that he was always for doing things on the basis of consensus and not arbitrarily. "The fact is that they want to extend the runway... there is no question of security or safety ... If at all a change has to take place, then let it be on the basis of consensus and not by force as this BJP Government is doing it," Roy



said, while there was no statement from the Left.

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari had earlier said that it was indeed a

security concern and the mosque should be shifted from the area "because nowhere you will find a public place inside an airport and so near the run way... this is a security sensitive issue... remember we are near international border ... China and Bangladesh are nearby... an international airport which receives top VVIPs and dignitaries everyday besides handling scores of flights cannot be kept open like this for common entry... it has to be

shifted from there because national security is supreme... National security and the security of the airport will gain priority over everything else... I cannot say more as a Chief Minister."

Senior BJP leader and Union Minister Sukanta Majumdar too said that he had heard since his childhood that the runway of the airport could not be extended because the mosque came in the way. All this was because of appeasement politics.

3 BJP RS nominees file papers

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

Three BJP nominees, Sukhendu Shekhar Roy, Sushmita Dev and Prakash Chik Baraik, on Monday filed their nominations for the three Rajya Sabha seats from Bengal.

All three candidates were sitting Trinamool Congress Rajya Sabha members but resigned their posts and left their party soon after the Bengal Assembly election results last May. The three leaders joined the BJP a couple of days ago.

Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari accompanied the BJP nominees to the returning officer's enclosure after they met him in his chamber in the Assembly.

While Roy refused comments regarding his quitting the TMC and joining the BJP,



saying it was not ideal for a candidate to talk when the model code was in effect. Dev, on the other hand, expressed his gratitude to the BJP leadership and offered to work for both Assam and Bengal because "I have connections in both the States." A caste Bengali Dev is from Assam.

On alleged discontent in the BJP rank and file over nominating three leaders

just after they left their party and joined the saffron outfit, Dev said she valued their grievances because "many of them sacrificed a lot for the party during their struggle against the TMC rule" and vowed to assuage their feelings. "I will try to work harder for the party and the people of Bengal... raise more issues so that I can justify my nomination," she said.

TMC accuses ED of targeting Opposition

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Trinamool Congress (TMC) on Monday alleged that the Enforcement Directorate (ED) is being used as a "political weapon" against opposition parties and questioned why the agency had not acted on allegations of financial irregularities in the Ram Temple Trust.

Addressing a press conference here, TMC leaders Sagarika Ghose and Mahua Moitra alleged that while the ED froze the bank accounts of Opposition parties, it failed to initiate action over allegations against the Ram Temple Trust.

"If the ED is truly impartial, why has it not acted in cases involving allegations against leaders in BJP-ruled States?...



If serious allegations have emerged against the Ram Temple Trust, why has the ED not initiated action? If such allegations had arisen in an Opposition-ruled State, the ED would have immediately registered a PMLA case," Ghose said.

Moitra reiterated the party's demand for a court-monitored investigation, saying millions of devotees donated to the temple in

good faith. "If the authorities can freeze the bank accounts of Opposition political parties, they should also be prepared to freeze the funds connected with the Ram Temple Trust while the allegations are investigated. There cannot be one standard for the Opposition and another for institutions associated with the ruling establishment," she said.

She alleged that if there had been any misuse of donations, "it is not merely financial wrongdoing — it is a betrayal of the faith of ordinary devotees."

Ghose alleged that constitutional institutions such as the Election Commission and the ED were being used to weaken the Opposition.

"The BJP wants to create a one-party state by eliminating every Opposition party... The ED is no longer functioning as an impartial agency. Since 2014, around 95 per cent of ED cases have been registered against opposition leaders," she claimed. Speaking on West Bengal politics, Moitra alleged that the BJP Government's implementation of welfare schemes would result in a sharp reduction in beneficiaries under the Lakshmir Bhandar scheme.

Jal Shakti ministry releases 3 key water management documents

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil

Resources, River Development and Ganga Rejuvenation under the Ministry of Jal Shakti, was chaired by Patil in the presence of Minister of State for Jal Shakti Raj Bhushan Choudhary.

Secretary of the department V L Kantha Rao, senior secretaries from all states and Union Territories, and officials of the Ministry of Jal Shakti attended the conference. Around 200 participants took part in the event.

The conference deliberated on eight priority agenda items, including the status of the Modernisation of Command Area Development and Water Management (M-CADWM) scheme, the special one-month nationwide Catch the Rain campaign, revised draft project appraisal guidelines for irrigation, multipurpose and flood management projects.

Ram Temple trust sets July 18 deadline for first CEO applications

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ayodhya

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust has set July 18 as the deadline to submit applications for the position of the first chief executive officer (CEO) of the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

According to a post on X, the trust will accept applications until 4 pm on July 18. This appointment is significant as it follows allegations of embezzlement of temple donations, prompting the trust to create the CEO position to strengthen administrative and financial management.

The trust's notification states that the CEO will be appointed on a three-year contract, extendable based on satisfactory performance.

The position is based in Ayodhya. Salary and benefits will be determined through mutual discussion, as detailed by the trust on X.

Applicants must have at least a Bachelor's degree from a recognised university, be between 50 and 70 years old, and possess a minimum of 20 years of managerial experience in a



large public organisation, institution, Government department, or company.

Candidates should have experience overseeing administration, finance, accounts, human resources, public relations, information technology, security, and legal affairs.

"Preference will be given

to candidates who have served as Chief Administrative Officer or have experience managing a temple or Hindu religious institution. Retired officers who meet the eligibility criteria may also apply," it added.

The notification further stated that applicants must be

"actively practising Hindus," and that "being a devotee of Lord Ram belonging to the Vaishnava tradition will be considered desirable."

Candidates must have a working knowledge of both Hindi and English.

On Sunday, Ram Temple Construction Committee chairman Nripendra Mishra

stated that the trust will determine the responsibilities and powers of the first CEO, with no Government interference in the trust's or the CEO's operations.

"The primary responsibility of the CEO will be to uphold the faith of devotees in the trust," Mishra had told reporters.

He stated that the CEO will oversee the temple's financial arrangements, ensure necessary facilities for devotees visiting Ayodhya, and serve as an assistant to the trust while remaining accountable to it.

Mishra added that the trust will determine the extent of authority delegated to the CEO, who will be free to appoint necessary staff. At the same time, overall administration will remain under the trust's control.

The notification states that the CEO will report to the trust's general secretary and be responsible for statutory, administrative, and financial affairs.

The CEO will also oversee institutional systems, organisational development, regulatory compliance, transparency in financial transac-

tions, asset management, and implementation of policies approved by the Board of Trustees.

Key responsibilities include ensuring the smooth conduct of religious rituals, festivals, and ceremonies; maintaining security in coordination with local, State, and central authorities; ensuring the safety and convenience of pilgrims; arranging visits for dignitaries and saints; and strengthening the trust's reputation while promoting Sanatan traditions.

Earlier this month, the trust formed a three-member panel consisting of retired justice Pramod Kohli, retired Lieutenant General Vishnukant Chaturvedi, and former NIT Raipur chairperson Suresh Haware to review applications and recommend suitable candidates.

Mishra clarified that he will not be on the panel and will decide whether to attend the trust's July 22 meeting after reviewing the agenda. He stated that committee members associated with the temple's construction are ex officio members of the trust without voting rights.

India, Japan review defence ties at Tokyo policy dialogue

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Japan on Monday reviewed the entire spectrum of their bilateral defence ties and discussed ways to deepen cooperation in emerging domains, including defence industrial collaboration, technological innovation, cyber security, space and other areas of shared strategic interest, the defence ministry said.

The key meeting followed soon after Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi's visit to India from July 1 to 3 for the 16th India-Japan annual summit. It was Takaichi's first official visit to India. Giving details of the latest parleys, the defence ministry said the talks were held under the aegis of the 8th Defence Policy Dialogue in Tokyo. The Indian delegation was led by Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, and the Japanese delegation was led by Vice Minister of Defence for International Affairs Kano Koji.

Both sides reviewed the significant progress made in bilateral defence cooperation since the previous Defence Policy Dialogue and reaffirmed their commitment to further strengthening the India-Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership.

The two countries held comprehensive discussions



Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, right, and Japan's Vice Minister of Defence for International Affairs, Kano Koji, during the 8th India-Japan Defence Policy Dialogue in Tokyo, Japan PTI

on the prevailing regional and global security environment and exchanged views on issues of mutual interest.

The dialogue reviewed the whole gamut of bilateral defence engagements, including military-to-military exchanges, co-operation between joint headquarters, maritime cooperation, defence exercises, capacity building, defence equipment and technology cooperation, including maritime technology, and enhanced institutional interactions.

Both sides welcomed the steady expansion of defence cooperation and underscored the importance of maintaining regular high-level exchanges and dialogue mechanisms.

They discussed probable outcomes for the forthcoming Ministerial visits, including 2+2 later this year.

The two delegations also discussed ways to deepen cooperation in emerging domains, including defence industrial collaboration, technological innovation, cyber security, space, and other areas of shared strategic interest.

Both sides expressed satisfaction with the growing convergence between India and Japan on regional and global security issues and agreed to continue working closely in the Indo-Pacific. They reiterated their commitment to promoting a free, open and rules-based

Indo-Pacific region founded on respect for international law. Defence Secretary appreciated Japan's continued engagement with India in the defence sector and highlighted the importance of strengthening practical cooperation under the framework of the India-Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership. Kano Koji reaffirmed Japan's commitment to further expanding defence ties with India across priority areas.

Earlier in the day, Defence Secretary called on Japanese Minister of Defence Shinjiro Koizumi, and conveyed greetings of Defence Minister Rajnath Singh. Both sides reaffirmed the growing momentum of the India-Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership. He also presented an invitation from the Raksha Mantri to the Defence Minister of Japan for his visit to India at the earliest opportunity.

Defence Secretary commenced his visit by laying a wreath at the Self-Defense Forces Memorial Stone in Tokyo, paying tribute to the members of the Japan Self-Defense Forces who have made the supreme sacrifice in the service of their nation.

The visit underscored the growing and deepening defence ties, mutual respect, and shared commitment of India and Japan towards peace, security, and stability in the Indo-Pacific region.

Varanasi gets reuse action plan for treated wastewater

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Varanasi has joined the list of cities with its own reuse action plan for safe reuse of treated wastewater, with the National Mission for Clean Ganga describing it as a "landmark" moment in India's journey towards the reuse of treated wastewater.

The action plan for Varanasi was unveiled by Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil at the water resources secretaries' conference in New Delhi on Monday in the presence of Minister of State for Jal Shakti Raj Bhushan Choudhary and Water Resources Secretary VL Kantha Rao. The Mission said the action plans show how the national framework on safe reuse of treated wastewater (SRTW) gets translated into ground reality. The plans map out exactly



where treated water can go, including thermal power plants, railways, urban landscaping and irrigation, matching supply from sewage treatment plants with real demand centres in each city.

"India generates approximately 72,368 million litres per day (MLD) of sewage every day from urban households. Only 44 per cent of that has treatment infrastructure, and much of what gets

treated is never reused. That's a resource going to waste, literally," the Mission said in a post on social media.

It said the SRTW initiative is a national push to stop treating used water as waste and start treating it as "Apna Jal" – "Our Water", a resource to be safely reused instead of freshwater.

The Mission said the national framework on SRTW, released in November 2022, lays the foundation through uniform quality standards, State-level policies, financing mechanisms and a shift from "treat-and-dispose" to "treat-and-reuse".

Noting that India is the world's 13th most water-stressed country, the Mission said groundwater is over-exploited across much of the country and "every drop of treated water reused is a drop of freshwater saved for drinking, farming and industry".

3 kids die of Chandipura virus in Gujarat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

Gujarat has reported seven confirmed cases of the Chandipura virus (CHPV) in the last few weeks, of which three patients have died, while four are under medical treatment, Health Minister Pratul Pansheriya said on Monday.

All the patients were under the age of 10, he said.

The minister, who chaired a high-level meeting in Gandhinagar to review the CHPV outbreak in the State,



said blood sample reports of eight suspected patients of the virus are still awaited.

The health department is continuously working towards control of the virus, treatment of patients and

surveillance operations, he maintained. The Chandipura virus causes fever, with symptoms similar to the flu, and acute encephalitis (inflammation of the brain). The pathogen is a member of the Vesiculovirus genus of the family Rhabdoviridae. It is transmitted by vectors like mosquitoes, ticks and sandflies. "Blood samples of 27 suspected patients of the virus were earlier sent for testing. Of these, reports of seven came back positive, while 12 tested negative," he informed.

Dry Gujarat logs over 300 alcohol-linked assault calls daily

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Despite Gujarat's long-standing prohibition policy, alcohol-related violence continues to place a significant burden on the State's emergency response system, with official data indicating that police receive more than 300 calls every day involving assaults linked to intoxicated individuals.

According to emergency response statistics for the period between September 1, 2025, and June 30, 2026, the State's 112 emergency helpline registered 83,747 alcohol-related assault incidents, making it the third most common category of police emergencies after general assault cases and public disturbances.

During the ten-month period, the emergency service handled 8.30 lakh police-related calls, averaging 2,741 calls per day.



Vice President CP Radhakrishnan is briefed by Minister of State for Defence and senior Ministry of Defence officials on the National Cadet Corps and Sainik Schools in New Delhi PTI

VP urges States to strengthen NCC, expand Sainik schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Monday called for greater participation of States to strengthen NCC and expand Sainik Schools. He was briefed on the National Cadet Corps (NCC) and Sainik Schools by the Minister of State for Defence Sanjay Seth, along with officers of the Ministry of Defence in New Delhi.

Appreciating the NCC's contribution to nation-building, the vice president described the Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat Camps as an excellent initiative for strengthening national integration. He also lauded the NCC's community service initiatives, including the Nasha Mukta Bharat Abhiyan and Swachh Bharat Abhiyan, and welcomed the establishment of the NCC Alumni Association.

Emphasising that strengthening the NCC is a shared national responsibility, Radhakrishnan called for greater infrastructure development, enhanced coordination with State Governments on issues such as land and training infrastructure, and assured all possible support in engaging with the States.

Radhakrishnan was also briefed on the functioning and expansion of Sainik Schools, including the existing and Public-Private Partnership (PPP) models.

Suggesting that the growing demand among students and parents be addressed, the vice president observed that each State could aim to have three to five Sainik Schools.

He also proposed exploring the possibility of increasing the intake capacity of existing Sainik schools.

Bihar CM launches subsidised heli-tourism service

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Monday launched the subsidised 'Bihar Heli-Tourism and Air Tourism Service Scheme-2026' to provide affordable air services to the public for select tourist destinations in the State.

Bookings under the scheme commenced on Monday, while helicopter services will operate every Saturday and Sunday from July 18.

The scheme was launched at a function in the State Capital.

According to a statement by the Chief Minister's Office, "The CM launched the subsidised 'Bihar Heli-Tourism and Air Tourism Service Scheme-2026' to provide affordable air tourism services to the general public for select tourist destinations in the State. The initiative aims to establish Bihar on the global tourism map." Under the scheme, subsidised helicopter services have been introduced



Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary with others during the inauguration of Bihar Heli-Tourism and Air Tourism Service Scheme-2026 in Patna PTI

from Patna to Rajgir, Valmikinagar and Kaimur. The Government will provide a subsidy of up to ₹15,422 per ticket, the statement said.

"Expansion of the tourism sector will create new employment opportunities for local youth and promote

homestays, local handicrafts and rural tourism. Private investment in the tourism sector will be encouraged through the Public-Private Partnership (PPP) model. The CM urged the people of Bihar to become ambassadors of the state's brand and

showcase its historical, cultural, religious and natural heritage to the world," the statement said.

He said no other State in the country has such an extensive network of quality rural roads as Bihar. Villages across the State are now equipped with essential infrastructure, including roads, electricity and water supply, he added.

He said Bihar was no longer known only for its rich history and spiritual heritage but was steadily emerging as a major destination for modern tourism. "Bihar is the land of Lord Buddha, Lord Mahavira, the world-renowned Nalanda University and the ancient Magadha Empire — a cradle of great civilisation and culture. The State Government aims to give these historical, religious and cultural heritage sites greater recognition at the national and international levels and attract more tourists to Bihar," he said.

Datia bypoll: Narottam back BJP candidate Ashutosh Tiwari

GIRISH SHARMA
■ Bhopal

The campaign for the Datia Assembly by-election gathered momentum on Monday as the BJP and Congress put up a show of strength during the filing of nominations by their candidates, while emotional appeals and sharp political exchanges dominated the day's events.

Former Madhya Pradesh Home Minister Narottam Mishra turned emotional while addressing a BJP public meeting, dismissing the Opposition's claims of divisions within the party. His voice choked with emotion as he pledged to campaign tirelessly for BJP candidate



BJP candidate Ashutosh Tiwari files his nomination papers in the presence of Madhya Pradesh CM Mohan Yadav and Narottam Mishra in Datia PTI

Ashutosh Tiwari. "Congress says there is a rift in the BJP. Look around, we are all standing together. I will bow before every household in Datia to ensure Ashutosh Tiwari's victory," Mishra said.

CM Mohan Yadav sought to reinforce the message of unity, saying, "Narottam, we are entrusting our younger brother Ashutosh Tiwari to you. It is now your responsibility to ensure his victory."

Taking a swipe at the Congress candidate, Mishra described Ghanshyam Singh, popularly known as Raja Saheb, as "an expired homoeopathy pill that may be sweet but has no effect." He also contrasted the two candidates, saying one was born into privilege while the other had dedicated his life to public service from a young age.

Earlier in the day, Congress nominee Ghanshyam Singh filed his nomination in the presence of Pradesh Congress Committee president Jitu Patwari, Leader of Opposition Umang Singhar, former Chief Minister Digvijaya Singh, former MLA Rajendra Bharti and Samajwadi Party State

president Manoj Yadav. Later, BJP candidate Ashutosh Tiwari submitted his nomination papers accompanied by CM Mohan Yadav, BJP State president Hemant Khandelwal, Narottam Mishra and other leaders. Nayak expressed disappointment over being denied the party ticket despite assurances after the 2023 Assembly elections. He alleged that the state leadership had repeatedly overlooked him and said all political options remained open. Nayak claimed that during a recent meeting, Digvijaya Singh had acknowledged positive feedback about him but expressed concerns over his past association with the

Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh and his proximity to BJP MP VD Sharma. "I have no issue with Congress candidate Ghanshyam Singh, but the state leadership has treated me unfairly. Ashutosh Tiwari is like my younger brother. I am still considering my future course of action," he said.

Addressing the Congress gathering, Digvijaya publicly apologised to Nayak, acknowledging that he had opposed Nayak's candidature in 2023 because he had only recently joined the Congress from the BJP. He praised Nayak's commitment during the previous Assembly election campaign and apologised if his actions had caused any hurt.

INS Sudarshini joins Grand Parade of Sails in Boston

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian Navy's sail training ship INS Sudarshini has taken part in the Grand Parade of Sails in Boston, days after representing the country at a grand nautical event hosted in the New York Harbour to mark the 250th anniversary of the US' independence.

The ship arrived in Boston on July 12, India's defence ministry said on Monday.

After her successful participation in the Sail 4th 250 celebrations in New York, INS Sudarshini took part in the Grand Parade of Sails, marking the commencement of Sail Boston 2026, it said in a statement. Raghuram Sastry, Consul General of India in Boston, embarked on the vessel for



Indian Naval Sail Training Ship (STS) INS Sudarshini participates in the grand parade of sails at Boston in USA PTI

the Grand Parade of Sails and the ship's ceremonial entry into Boston.

Sailing proudly with the Indian tricolour, INS Sudarshini passed prominent landmarks including Castle Island and the Seaport District before berthing at

Boston Fish Pier, the ministry said. "Joining an international fleet of over 60 tall ships from more than 20 nations, INS Sudarshini is representing India as a maritime ambassador of goodwill during her ongoing Lokayan 2026 transoceanic

expedition," it said. Lokayan 2026 is the ship's 10-month transoceanic expedition, which reflects the Indian Navy's commitment to strengthening maritime cooperation, building international goodwill and deepening engagement with partner navies.

Reinforcing the Indian Navy's commitment to maritime diplomacy, international goodwill and cultural exchange, the ship will remain open to visitors from July 12 to 15, the statement said. Following successful port calls at Norfolk, Baltimore, and New York, INS Sudarshini's participation in Sail Boston 2026 "further strengthens the growing India-US maritime partnership and showcases India's rich seafaring heritage on the global stage," it said.

TN CM visits Perambur, launches grievance app

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

In his first official engagement in Perambur after the Assembly election, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay formally opened his newly renovated MLA office on Monday.

He also unveiled a technology-driven public grievance mobile application specifically for Perambur residents.

The upgraded facility in Sharma Nagar First Street in Vyasarpadi includes a dedicated workspace for the CM, CCTV surveillance, and a 10-member staff tasked with managing daily public petitions, according to official sources.

CM Vijay contested and won from both the Perambur and Tiruchy East constituencies, eventually vacating the Tiruchy East seat to retain



Perambur. The MLA office also houses an integrated common service centre (E-Sevai maiyyam) to expedite civic requests. Meanwhile, the newly launched app allows citizens to directly submit and track complaints

related to electricity, water supply, roads, sanitation, and access to government welfare schemes.

He is also expected to launch the State's new ration card distribution scheme; the CM will inspect a ration shop

in MKB Nagar. He is scheduled to hand over new ration cards to the first 50 eligible beneficiaries, along with essential commodities and land ownership patts.

The schedule includes a visit to an MTC electric vehicle (EV) charging station near the Vyasarpadi Metro and a review of commuter amenities at a local MTC bus depot.

Coinciding with his visit, the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) has floated a Rs 48 lakh tender to prepare a comprehensive Detailed Project Report (DPR) for the constituency. The integrated area development plan aims to address long-standing urban challenges across Perambur's lower-income neighbourhoods, targeting flooding hotspots, drinking water issues, parking shortages, and the heavily polluted Captain Cotton Canal.



Editor's

TAKE

India finally arrives in the South Pacific

Prime Minister Modi's visit to New Zealand — the first by an Indian Prime Minister in four decades — resets bilateral ties after years of neglect

When Narendra Modi closed the final leg of a nine-day arc that began in Jakarta, in New Zealand, he did so by closing a much longer gap. No Indian Prime Minister had set foot in New Zealand in forty years; only Indira Gandhi in 1968 and Rajiv Gandhi in 1986 had come before him.

That the visit lasted barely a day, bookended by talks with Christopher Luxon and an address to the diaspora at Auckland's Spark Arena, only underlined how overdue it was.

The three-nation itinerary was not incidental. Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand together mark the arc of India's "Act East" outreach into the Indo-Pacific, a region where Delhi has spent a decade playing catch-up to China's economic and naval footprint. In Jakarta, Modi discussed heritage conservation at Prambanan; in Australia, the two countries struck a uranium export deal, feeding India's push towards 100 gigawatts of nuclear capacity by 2047.

New Zealand was the finale, smaller in scale but symbolically significant as the relationship's most underdeveloped corner. The challenges are real and long-standing. Trade talks, first launched in 2010, collapsed in 2015 over India's reluctance to open its dairy sector, to protect its millions of small farmers.

Even the Free Trade Agreement signed this April, ahead of Modi's visit, reflects that caution: bulk infant formula and select re-exports get duty-free access, but butter and cheese—the products New Zealand's dairy industry actually wants to sell—stay largely outside the deal, prompting open disappointment from its dairy lobby.

Separately, the presence of pro-Khalistan groups in New Zealand—including a 2024 referendum push by Sikhs for Justice that drew a formal protest from Delhi—remains a running irritant, echoing the friction that has strained India's ties with Canada. Against these frictions sit sturdier binding factors: a 200,000-strong Indian diaspora, growing convergence on Indo-Pacific maritime security, and a shared wariness of an assertive China across the Pacific. These pulled the two governments towards each other despite the trade impasse, and this visit turned that convergence into tangible outcomes. Modi and Luxon elevated the relationship to a strategic partnership and signed eighteen outcomes, including ten formal agreements: a four-year roadmap for cooperation, a reciprocal logistics support pact between the two navies, a maritime cooperation framework, and a pledge to jointly tackle transnational crime, from drug trafficking to cyber-enabled fraud.

They also set an aspirational target of doubling two-way trade to NZ\$7 billion by 2030. The real test now is follow-through. The FTA still needs ratification and entry into force, and its dairy carve-outs will keep testing New Zealand's patience unless Delhi shows more flexibility over time. And the defence commitments—naval exercises and cyber cooperation—need budgets and calendars behind them, not just communiqués.

Dual nationality and divided loyalties

The Dutch-Moroccan experience, shaped by decades of integration challenges, political controversy and competing visions of citizenship, offers a revealing case study of one of the defining social and political dilemmas confronting modern Europe



BHOPINDER SINGH

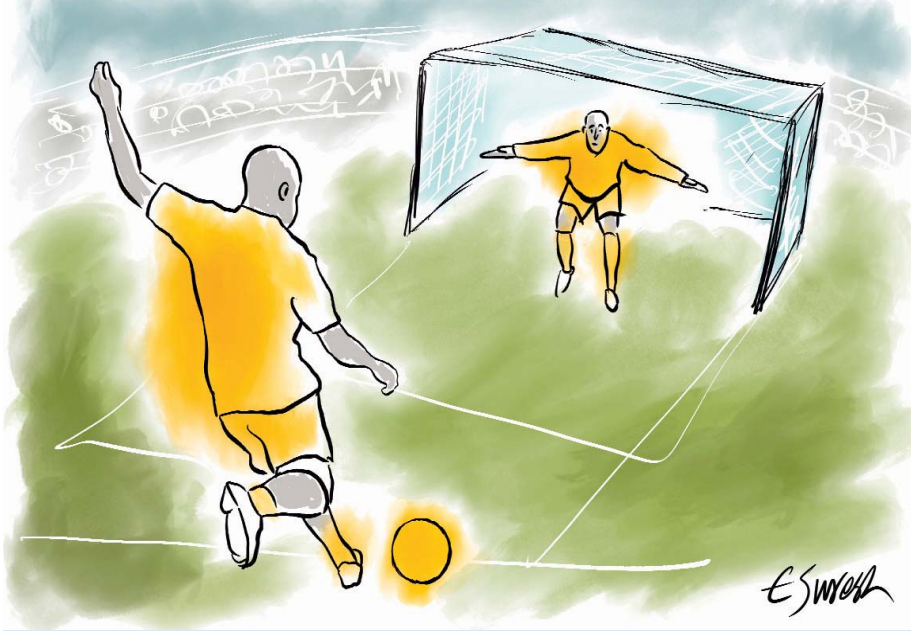
People of Moroccan origin constitute one of the largest immigrant-origin communities in the Netherlands, numbering approximately 450,000. For decades, the Moroccan-Dutch community has been at the centre of debates surrounding integration, identity and social cohesion. Issues such as religious extremism, youth unemployment, educational disadvantage, socio-economic segregation, and concerns about crime among a small minority of young men have received significant media and political attention.

Certain high-profile incidents intensified these debates. The 2004 assassination of Dutch filmmaker Theo van Gogh by Mohammed Bouyeri, a Dutch citizen of Moroccan descent with Islamist extremist motivations, and the exposure of the Hofstad Network (2002-2005), a jihadist group whose members were involved in extremist activities, became defining moments in Dutch discussions about radicalisation and integration. Although these cases involved a very small number of individuals, they contributed to public anxiety and provided political ammunition for right-wing movements, particularly the Party for Freedom (PVV), led by Geert Wilders, which has repeatedly argued that the Netherlands faces what it describes as a "Moroccan problem".

One of the most contentious issues arising from these debates has been dual nationality. Dutch law permits dual citizenship in certain circumstances, but nationalist politicians in the Netherlands and elsewhere in Europe have questioned whether it can create competing loyalties. Their argument is rooted in the belief that citizenship should represent an exclusive commitment to one nation and that full integration requires a primary and unambiguous national identity.

From this perspective, dual nationality may create situations in which individuals face conflicting obligations if the interests of their two countries diverge. Critics argue that, while dual nationals may legally pledge allegiance to the Netherlands, their emotional or cultural attachment may remain divided. They contend that a cohesive nation requires a shared civic identity and that multiple national affiliations may weaken that sense of belonging.

This debate resurfaced during the FIFA World Cup when Morocco defeated the Netherlands in a tense knockout match



decided by a penalty shoot-out. The Moroccan national team, known as the Atlas Lions, has historically included many players from the global Moroccan diaspora. Meanwhile, the Dutch national team has long reflected the multicultural character of Dutch society, with legendary players of immigrant heritage such as Ruud Gullit, Frank Rijkaard, Clarence Seedorf and Patrick Kluivert.

The match highlighted a new dimension of the identity debate. Several members of Morocco's squad were born or raised in the Netherlands, including Noussair Mazraoui and Sofyan Amrabat, while others developed their careers within Dutch football structures. These players had eligibility options but ultimately chose to represent Morocco, the country associated with their family heritage.

There were undoubtedly sporting considerations involved. Morocco had established itself as a highly competitive international team, reaching the latter stages of major tournaments. A player's decision is influenced by many factors, including football opportunities, personal relationships, coaching environments and family connections.

Nevertheless, the symbolic significance of these choices was difficult to ignore. Ismael Saibari, closely associated with Dutch football through PSV Eindhoven, chose Morocco despite eligibility ties to Spain and Belgium. Explaining his decision, he said:

"Playing for Morocco was a choice from the heart." Similarly, Noussair Mazraoui explained that although he had discussions with Dutch coach Ronald Koeman, he had

already decided: "When I spoke with Ronald Koeman, I already had the feeling that I would choose only Morocco and nothing else."

For supporters of a more nationalist view of citizenship, such statements reinforce concerns about divided loyalties. Politicians such as Geert Wilders in the Netherlands, Nigel Farage in the United Kingdom, and Marine Le Pen in France argue that citizenship should involve a clear and primary allegiance to the nation-state. From this perspective, citizens born or raised in a country choosing to represent another nation because of their ancestral identity raises questions about national belonging.

Supporters of this view contend that a nation functions best when citizens share a strong civic identity. They argue that immigration and naturalisation policies should encourage newcomers and their descendants to develop a deep identification with their adopted country. However, critics argue that sporting representation should not be treated as a direct measure of civic loyalty. They point out that many people maintain multiple identities and that a connection to ancestral heritage does not necessarily diminish commitment to the country where someone lives, works and contributes to society.

The debate became more visible after Morocco's victory, when celebrations took place in several Dutch cities with large Moroccan-origin populations. Many were peaceful expressions of pride, though incidents of disorder and clashes with the police led to criticism and renewed discussion about integration and social cohesion.

Ultimately, the question of dual nationality reflects a broader European debate about belonging in an era of migration and globalisation. The challenge is finding a balance: allowing individuals to maintain their cultural heritage while ensuring a strong shared commitment to the civic values and institutions of the country they call home.

The responsibility rests on both sides. Host societies must create genuine opportunities for inclusion, while immigrant communities and their descendants must engage with and invest in the national identity of the societies in which they live. The future of multicultural democracies may depend on whether multiple identities can coexist alongside a common sense of citizenship.

THE QUESTION OF DUAL NATIONALITY REFLECTS A BROADER EUROPEAN DEBATE ABOUT BELONGING IN AN ERA OF MIGRATION AND GLOBALISATION

The writer is a former Lieutenant Governor of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Puducherry, and a military veteran

The infrastructure we cannot afford to ignore



SIDDHARTH ROY

2ND OPINION

Whenever a new highway, bridge or airport is inaugurated, it becomes a visible symbol of India's progress. Such projects inspire confidence because they represent ambition translated into reality. Yet, there is another kind of infrastructure that rarely attracts headlines, despite determining whether these physical assets ultimately succeed. It cannot be seen, photographed or inaugurated. It is the invisible infrastructure of trust, accountability and institutional integrity.

Every nation invests in roads, railways and power networks because they create economic opportunities and improve quality of life. India has made remarkable strides in this regard over the past decade. However, physical infrastructure alone cannot transform a country into a developed nation. The institutions that maintain these assets,

enforce standards and inspire public confidence are equally important. Without them, even the finest engineering achievements eventually lose their value.

Consider any public service. A modern hospital cannot deliver better outcomes if patients distrust its doctors or administration. Likewise, digital platforms remain underutilised if citizens fear data breaches, and universities cannot strengthen the economy if employers lose confidence in their graduates. Infrastructure functions best when people trust the systems behind it. India has already witnessed the power of invisible infrastructure. The success of Aadhaar, the Unified Payments Interface and DigiLocker depended not only on technology but also on citizens believing these platforms would make life simpler, safer and more reliable. Trust transformed innovation into mass adoption. The same principle extends to economic growth. Investors seek stable regulatory environments where contracts are honoured and policies remain predictable. Entrepreneurs take calculated risks when institutions uphold fairness. Citizens are more willing to pay taxes when they believe public resources are utilised responsibly. Even disaster management becomes more effective when communities trust official warnings and cooperate with the authorities. In each case, confidence acts as a multiplier that enhances the benefits of every physical investment. As a civil engineer, I have learned that no structure remains durable without a robust maintenance ecosystem. Designing a bridge is only the beginning. Its longevity depends upon quality inspections, transparent

procurement, timely repairs and professional accountability. These invisible processes rarely receive public attention, yet they determine whether infrastructure remains safe and functional for generations. The same principle applies to nation-building itself.

India's aspiration to become a developed country by 2047 therefore demands a broader understanding of infrastructure. Alongside highways, ports and industrial corridors, equal emphasis must be placed on judicial efficiency, ethical governance, administrative competence, quality education and professional standards. These investments may not produce dramatic photographs, but they generate something even more valuable: lasting public confidence.

Invisible infrastructure is not created by governments alone. Every honest public servant, responsible business leader, dedicated teacher and conscientious citizen contributes to an environment where trust flourishes. Development is sustained when institutions and individuals reinforce one another through integrity and accountability. Concrete may connect cities, but trust connects people. India's future will not be defined only by the kilometres of roads it builds or the skylines it transforms. It will ultimately be measured by the strength of the institutions that stand behind those achievements. That invisible infrastructure will decide whether our development remains impressive on paper or truly endures across generations.

The writer, a civil engineer, is a consultant at Rashtriya Raksha University under the Ministry of Home Affairs

PIC TALK



An artisan gives the final touches to an idol of Lord Jagannath ahead of the Rath Yatra festival in Nadia, West Bengal.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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INDIA'S RISING STRATEGIC INFLUENCE IN A VOLATILE WORLD

Appropos the front-page report, "JPC endorses One Nation, One Election" (12 July), the proposal deserves serious consideration as a major electoral reform. If implemented, holding simultaneous elections for the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies could significantly reduce the enormous expenditure incurred on frequent polls. Estimates suggest that savings to the national exchequer could be substantial, allowing greater public resources to be directed towards development and welfare.

The reform could also benefit political parties, which currently spend considerable time and resources preparing for successive elections across different states. A common electoral cycle may encourage parties to focus on long-term governance, present more meaningful vision documents and forge stronger alliances where

necessary. Smaller parties, too, would have the opportunity to contest elections more strategically instead of engaging in continuous campaign mode.

Frequent elections keep governments in campaign mode, slowing policy decisions and governance at both the Centre and in the states. Simultaneous elections could enhance political stability, improve governance and create a more favourable environment for economic growth and investment.

While constitutional, logistical and federal concerns must be addressed through consensus, the proposal has significant potential. If Parliament enacts the necessary legislation, *One Nation, One Election* could become a major step towards more efficient governance and a stronger democracy.

VINOD JOHRI | DELHI

Sleep is the foundation of good health

Refer 'The Healing Power of Sleep' by Rajyogi Brahma Kumar Nikunj Ji. The article rightly reminds readers that sleep is not wasted time but the body's most vital period of restoration and healing. Modern medical research increasingly confirms what ancient wisdom has long recognised — that quality sleep is indispensable for physical, mental and emotional well-being. The outdated belief that "sleep is for the weak" deserves to be discarded. Longevity expert Bryan Johnson aptly describes sleep as a superpower because no supplement, energy drink or productivity hack can compensate for chronic sleep deprivation. Sleep is second only to oxygen in sustaining human life. During sleep, the brain consolidates memories, strengthens learning, regulates emotions, repairs tissues, balances hormones, boosts immunity and removes harmful metabolic waste. People who consistently enjoy adequate sleep are more productive, make better decisions and are less vulnerable to obesity, diabetes, heart disease and dementia.

Educational institutions must also rethink practices that glorify sleeplessness. Daytime submission deadlines would serve academic objectives without compromising health. Sleep is not a luxury but the very foundation of lifelong health, happiness and productivity.

HARSH PAWARIA | ROHTAK

Strengthening public trust in the police

The controversy surrounding *Satluji*, the recently banned film inspired by the life of human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khaira, has generated widespread debate across Punjab. Despite the restrictions, many people have reportedly viewed the film through digital platforms. While some believe it highlights the alleged excesses committed by the Punjab Police during the militancy years, others argue that it pays inadequate attention to the horrific violence perpetrated by terrorists, resulting in a one-sided portrayal of a deeply painful period in the state's history. Sensitive subjects involving terrorism, human rights and law enforcement deserve balanced treatment, as selective narratives can reopen old wounds and influence public perceptions.

If the authorities found the film objectionable, such concerns should ideally have been addressed during the certification process rather than after its completion and release. The Punjab Police can strengthen public confidence by promoting transparent, accountable and humane policing, expanding community engagement and demonstrating unwavering respect for human rights. A professional police force that enjoys the trust of the people remains the strongest guarantee of peace, justice and lasting social harmony.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

A voice that will echo forever

The demise of S Janaki Amma at the age of 88 marks the end of one of the most glorious chapters in Indian film music. For more than six decades, her extraordinary voice became the emotional heartbeat of millions, captivating listeners across generations with its remarkable range, versatility and expressive depth.

Whether rendering intricate classical compositions such as Singara Velane Deva, lively folk songs, playful comic numbers or even singing convincingly in a child's voice, she displayed a rare mastery that few singers have ever matched.

Her greatness lay not only in her vocal brilliance but also in her ability to transcend linguistic boundaries. Singing flawlessly in 18 languages, she became a beloved cultural icon across South India and beyond.

By declining the Padma Bhushan, believing the honour had come too late, she made a principled statement without diminishing her immense stature. She required no official recognition; the enduring love of her countless admirers had already crowned her. Though her voice has fallen silent, her immortal songs will continue to inspire generations.

S PADMANABHAN | KOCHI

Five water stories from Dhanbad that can shape Jharkhand’s water future

As climate change makes rainfall more erratic and water increasingly uncertain, Jharkhand’s next generation of water governance must move beyond delivering water schemes to securing water systems



EKLAVYA PRASAD

Dhanbad is rarely associated with water. It is known as India’s coal capital, a landscape of mines, industries and expanding urban settlements. Yet, beneath this industrial identity lies another Dhanbad, one where aquifers sustain millions, ponds continue to recharge groundwater, streams silently carry the burden of urbanisation, and communities negotiate water every single day.

Over the past several years, my work with Megh Pyne Abhiyan (MPA) across rural and urban Dhanbad has convinced me that the district is much more than a mining region. It is a microcosm of Jharkhand’s water realities. The challenges that emerge here—groundwater depletion, contamination, urban flooding, disappearing recharge spaces and climate uncertainty—mirror those confronting the rest of the State. At the same time, Dhanbad has also become a testing ground for innovative solutions. Five stories from the district offer valuable lessons for reimagining water governance in Jharkhand.

The first story comes from rural Dhanbad. Across the blocks of Baliapur, Tundi and Purbi (East) Tundi, covering seven gram panchayats and thirteen villages, MPA’s groundwater assessment found what villagers had always known: groundwater is the backbone of everyday life. It supports drinking water, household needs and agriculture. More importantly, the assessment revealed that local communities possess an intimate understanding of their aquifers. They know when hand pumps begin to fail, which ponds once recharged wells, how mining has altered drainage, and how rainfall has become increasingly unpredictable.

What was striking was that villagers did not merely describe problems. They proposed solutions. Rainwater harvesting, aquifer recharge, the revival of traditional ponds, improved irrigation and safe drinking water emerged as their priorities. Their responses remind us that groundwater governance cannot depend solely on engineering designs and hydrogeological maps. It must also recognise local knowledge as a valuable planning resource. Communities are not passive beneficiaries; they are indispensable partners in water management.

A very different story unfolds in Bartand, Dhanbad, inside my mother’s home, called Uttarayan. Since 2018, this residence has quietly become a living laboratory for understanding groundwater. Rainfall has been measured every day, rainwater harvesting carefully documented, and groundwater levels in a dug well systematically monitored. During this period, nearly 5.8 million litres of rainwater have been harvested to recharge the shallow aquifer, while seasonal groundwater fluctuations have improved by almost eleven feet between May 2018 and May 2026.

The significance of Uttarayan extends far beyond one household. It demonstrates that water consciousness begins with measurement, not assumptions. When people measure rainfall, monitor groundwater and observe recharge, conservation becomes evidence-based rather than symbolic. Imagine if every school, college, government office and public institution in Jharkhand became a similar water observatory. Such citizen-generated datasets would not only deepen scientific understanding but also strengthen the Government’s Catch the Rain campaign through informed public participation.

The third story shifts from one home to an entire city. It began with an inspiring initiative called the Gang of Twenty, a group of students from Carmel School, Dhanbad, who started engaging with local water issues. Their enthusiasm sparked wider conversations about groundwater and eventually contributed to Dhanbad being selected as one of the pilot cities under the National Institute of Urban Affairs’ Shallow Aquifer Management (SAM) programme. Implemented by the Dhanbad Municipal Corporation in partnership with MPA, and mentored by Dr Himanshu Kulkarni of ACWADAM, Pune, and S Vishwanath of Biome Environmental Trust, Bengaluru, the initiative marked an important shift in urban water planning.

Instead of viewing groundwater as an invisible reserve beneath the city, the pilot treated the shallow aquifer as an asset that could be mapped, monitored,



protected and recharged. Recharge interventions and groundwater monitoring were undertaken at Jeevan Jyoti School and Bera Colony in Dhanbad Circle, Bhagatdih and Neeche Mohalla in Jharia Circle, and Laxmi Colony in Sindri Circle. Subsequent monitoring showed encouraging improvements, with groundwater remaining available for longer periods during the summer months. The experience demonstrates that even rapidly growing mining cities can improve groundwater security when urban planning begins with the shallow aquifer rather than ending with pipelines.

Urban groundwater, however, cannot be protected without addressing sanitation. This is perhaps one of Dhanbad’s most important lessons. In the absence of underground sewerage systems, drains, streams and rivers frequently become carriers of sewage. Stormwater drains meant to convey rainwater gradually turn into wastewater channels, contaminating surface water and threatening groundwater quality.

The lesson is straightforward but often ignored. Water supply, drainage, sanitation, rivers and groundwater cannot be planned separately. Healthy drains, streams and wetlands are not vacant land waiting for development. They are essential urban infrastructure that supports recharge, reduces flooding and protects public health. Sustainable cities will emerge only when sanitation and groundwater are planned together.

The final story takes us back to rural Dhanbad, where the challenge is not water availability but water safety. In Gharbar Panchayat of Baliapur Block, studies conducted by MPA in collaboration with the School of Environmental Studies, Jadavpur University, found widespread fluoride contamination in groundwater. In several habitations, more than half of the drinking water sources exceeded the permissible fluoride limits. Significantly, this situation persisted even after piped water supply had reached many villages because people continued to depend on groundwater for convenience, reliability and everyday needs.

This experience reminds us that water security cannot be judged simply by counting household tap connections. Safe drinking water depends equally on water quality, continuous monitoring and informed community behaviour. Addressing fluorosis requires an integrated approach involving hydrogeological investigations, groundwater quality surveillance, safe alternative water sources, rainwater harvesting, aquifer recharge, nutrition, public awareness and institutional convergence. There is no single technological fix.

Taken together, these five stories point towards a larger shift that Jharkhand must embrace. Groundwater remains the invisible foundation of water security across rural and urban landscapes. Traditional ponds, dug wells, wetlands and drainage channels are not relics of the past but living ecological infrastructure. Water challenges differ from one landscape to another, making hydrogeology and local context central to planning. Most importantly, water quantity, water quality, sanitation, climate resilience and community participation are inseparable.

Dhanbad therefore offers Jharkhand something far more valuable than isolated stories. It provides evidence that a different model of water governance is possible, one that begins with understanding aquifers, respects community knowledge, encourages citizen science, integrates institutions and protects the ecological systems on which all water security ultimately depends. As climate change makes rainfall more erratic and water increasingly uncertain, Jharkhand’s next generation of water governance must move beyond delivering water schemes to securing water systems. If these lessons from Dhanbad are scaled thoughtfully, they can help build a State that is not merely water-supplied, but truly water-secure.

The writer is the Managing Trustee of Megh Pyne Abhiyan

The notion India needs to be Viksit Bharat



AMITABH RANJAN

India stands at a historic inflection point. It is the world’s fastest-growing major economy, a digital innovation leader, and a geopolitical force of increasing consequence. Yet the journey from a rising power to a truly developed nation cannot be measured through GDP figures or infrastructure statistics alone. The defining question is: what guiding principle will sustain India’s transformation into a Viksit Bharat by 2047? The answer lies in a simple but profound idea: Rashtra Pratham — Nation First.

Rashtra Pratham is not a slogan. It is a governing philosophy that places the long-term interests of the nation above sectional, political, institutional and personal considerations. Every successful nation in modern history—post-war Japan, South Korea, Singapore and Germany—achieved development only when governments, businesses and citizens aligned around a shared civilisational purpose. India’s ambition requires no less: a national consensus that transcends electoral cycles, ideological divisions and short-term interests.

Beyond economics: The character question

Development is not merely an economic phenomenon. A developed nation emerges when excellence becomes the norm rather than the exception. India has excelled in technology, medicine, entrepreneurship and public administration—yet the translation of individual excellence into institutional excellence has remained elusive. The challenge has never been the absence of talent; it has been the absence of a culture that consistently places national and institutional interests above narrow personal gains.

The consequences are visible across sectors. Bureaucratic inertia delays nationally important projects. Political polarisation obstructs reforms whose benefits transcend party lines. Academic institutions remain constrained by administrative rigidity. Corporate R&D investment stays below potential. Citizens demand better public services while overlooking civic responsibilities. In each case, the underlying challenge is not capability but orientation. A Rashtra Pratham mindset asks one consistent question: What serves the long-term interests of the nation?

Three arenas for Nation-First action

Consider innovation. India aspires to become a technological leader, with impressive achievements in space, digital infrastructure and pharmaceuticals. Yet national R&D expenditure remains well below that of leading innovation economies. Private capital gravitates towards low-risk investments; universities remain disconnected from industry; and regulation inadvertently discourages experimentation. A Rashtra Pratham approach would reframe innovation not as a commercial activity but as a national imperative, rewarding risk, strengthening academia-industry collaboration, and recognising scientific excellence as a patriotic contribution to nation-building. The same principle applies to governance. India’s administrative institutions have been the backbone of democratic continuity, but a twenty-first-century economy demands greater agility, transparency and outcome orientation. Administrative reforms must be understood not as an internal bureaucratic exercise but as a national priority. When governance improves, its benefits ripple across every sector—business, education, healthcare and social welfare alike.

Corporate India must equally recognise that wealth creation and nation-building are complementary, not competing, objectives. India’s entrepreneurs have built globally respected companies and a thriving start-up ecosystem. However, nations become developed not simply by borrowing technology but by creating it. The ensuing phase of development calls for wholehearted commitment to advanced manufacturing, deep-tech and long-term capital creation. Corporate India has the wherewithal to drive this transformation. It may appear difficult, but choosing to do so would be among the most meaningful expressions of Rashtra Pratham.

Citizens as nation-builders

No national transformation can succeed without people’s active participation and contribution. A developed nation is built by millions of everyday decisions made by ordinary people: respecting public spaces, following rules, paying taxes honestly, recognising merit, conserving resources and participating constructively in civic life. The difference between developed and developing societies more often lies in civic culture than in government policies. Viksit Bharat, therefore, demands not only institutional reforms but also a paradigm shift in civic consciousness.

There is also a deeper civilisational dimension here. India is not merely a modern nation-state; it is one of the world’s oldest continuing civilisations. Concepts such as Lokasangraha (welfare of society), Sarve Bhavantu Sukhinah (well-being of all) and Yogakshema (collective prosperity) highlight the idea that the flourishing of an individual cannot be viewed separately from the development of society as a whole. Rashtra Pratham is therefore not a borrowed political doctrine but a contemporary expression of the civilisational ethic that has long shaped India’s global perspective.

Purpose over potential

India is sitting on unprecedented opportunities. Demographic strength, technological capability, entrepreneurial energy and cultural confidence have created conditions previous generations could hardly have imagined. Yet history is replete with nations that possessed immense potential but failed to fulfil it because collective purpose yielded to fragmented interests. The countries that succeeded were those that cultivated a shared commitment to national advancement. The journey to Viksit Bharat will not be completed by government schemes alone, nor by economic growth in isolation. It will be achieved only when every institution and every citizen internalises one conviction: that the nation’s long-term interests must remain paramount. That is the essence of Rashtra Pratham.

And the most enduring lesson of development is that nations become great not when they merely dream of prosperity but when they organise themselves around a purpose larger than themselves. For India, that purpose is clear: Rashtra Pratham — Nation First.



The writer is an alumnus of NESa, Washington, DC, and Vice Chairman, PanIT Alumni India. He is associated with the Indian Institute of Public Administration (IIPA), New Delhi, as Registrar

AI and the vanishing first job: India’s emerging mobility challenge



RAVI POKHARNA

per cent of current work activities in the US, primarily within white-collar sectors, could be automated by 2030. Analysis by Anthropic (2026) and Stanford University (Brynjolfsson, Chandar and Chen; 2025) found that while AI-exposed occupations, such as computer programmers and customer service representatives, have not yet experienced significant rises in unemployment, hiring for younger workers in these roles has slowed measurably. This signals an important shift: firms are not eliminating jobs at scale, but they are reducing hiring at entry level. The layoffs may not come, but the offer letters may come more slowly.

The jobs are safe, the ladder is not

At first glance, India appears relatively insulated. Forty-three per cent of the workforce remains in agriculture, with large shares in construction (12 per cent), retail and transport (18 per cent)—sectors where physical presence and human judgement remain indispensable (PLFS, 2025). AI will not pour

concrete, repair a power line or manage a kirana counter anytime soon.

But India’s growth story has not been driven by these sectors alone. It has been powered by the steady expansion of formal services: IT-BPM, customer support, finance operations, analytics and the growing ecosystem of Global Capability Centres (GCCs). These sectors have historically functioned as engines of aspirational mobility, absorbing educated youth into formal employment. Yet these are precisely the domains where AI is now performing core tasks: writing code, handling customer interactions, processing data and managing workflows. The risk, therefore, is not where India is today, but where it is trying to go.

The most consequential shift is unfolding at the bottom of the pyramid. Entry-level roles in IT services, BPMs and analytics have traditionally operated as training pipelines. Firms hired fresh graduates with low initial productivity, invested in structured training, and scaled them into higher-value roles over time. AI is compressing this model. With AI assistants enabling developers to work faster and autonomous agents resolving most routine customer interactions, firms now require fewer entry-level workers to produce the same output. The result is not mass layoffs, but a structural decline in fresher hiring. In a country where 8-10 million individuals enter the workforce annually (World Bank, ILO), this is a systemic challenge.

Why this matters more for India

India’s youth labour market was already fragile before the AI transition. The graduate unemploy-



ment rate of 11.2 per cent is more than three times the overall unemployment rate of 3.1 per cent (PLFS, 2025). More than 45 per cent of employed graduates are overqualified for their roles (CMIE, India Skills Report 2025). Entry-level wages in IT-BPM have stagnated for over a decade, with starting salaries in the ₹3.5-4.5 lakh per annum range (TeamLease, 2024-25). AI risks amplifying all three trends: fewer formal-sector entry points, higher skill thresholds for hiring, and slower and more unequal wage progression. The first job is more than employment; it is an economic bridge. It shapes income trajectories, household aspirations and urban mobility. When that bridge narrows, the effects ripple across the economy. This is not a conventional jobs crisis; it is a mobility crisis.

A familiar technological moment

The advent of AI today is comparable to the arrival of computers in the late 20th century. Computers did not eliminate work; they transformed it. Every sector, every business and every activity

became computer-powered. Productivity surged, new industries emerged, and those who adapted gained disproportionately. India seized that moment. Tech services companies, in particular, helped position India as a global IT powerhouse. That wave created millions of jobs and gave India a competitive advantage in the global economy.

AI presents a similar inflection point, creating opportunities for India’s next generation of technology leaders to build for the world. But while AI opens new frontiers, it is also narrowing the entry ramp. For policymakers, the priority should be to incentivise entry-level hiring through apprenticeship-style schemes, tax credits or wage subsidies for firms hiring fresh graduates, while expanding the National Apprenticeship Promotion Scheme (NAPS) into white-collar sectors as part of a national “first job” guarantee.

Skilling policy must shift from degrees to task-level capability, moving beyond generic coding or AI literacy towards skills that complement AI (for example, problem framing, client management and domain expertise). Job creation must be accelerated in less AI-exposed, labour-intensive sectors such as healthcare, tourism, logistics and the green economy to absorb surplus educated labour. Finally, India needs a real-time labour market observatory that tracks hiring trends, wage movements and occupational demand. In addition to macroeconomic indicators such as the PLFS, high-frequency labour market intelligence is required. For businesses, the imperative is adaptation, not contraction. Firms should redesign entry-level roles by breaking jobs into AI-assist-

ed and human-critical components while retaining structured junior positions focused on judgement, coordination and client-facing tasks. This must be accompanied by institutionalising “AI + human” workflows, where employees are trained not just to use AI tools but also to supervise, validate and integrate them.

AI productivity gains must also be measured responsibly, avoiding their use purely as a cost-cutting lever and instead tracking whether adoption is strengthening or eroding organisational capabilities. Finally, deeper partnerships with academia are essential, including co-designing curricula, offering live projects and enabling early exposure to AI-integrated industry workflows.

AI is not eliminating work yet, but it is reshaping who gets access to it. The evidence from advanced economies offers India a narrow but valuable window. This disruption is not sudden; it is gradual, and it begins at the bottom of the ladder. By getting ahead of this curve through proactive policy, business adaptation and bold entrepreneurship, India can ensure AI augments its demographic dividend rather than renders it obsolete. The lesson from the IT revolution is clear: technological shifts reward early movers. This is the moment for the new-age Narayana Murthys to build the next generation of AI enterprises that serve the world while creating new career pathways for millions of jobseekers.

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**SC dismisses pleas of 360
Bengal madrassa teachers**

The Supreme Court on Monday dismissed a batch of petitions filed by about 360 teaching and non-teaching staff of madrassas in West Bengal, challenging the denial of regularisation and payment under the State Government's grant-in-aid scheme.

A bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and A G Masih delivered the judgment after examining the cases of 13 petitioners out of more than 350 such employees to see whether any case was made out for grant of relief. Pronouncing the verdict, the bench said, "We proceeded on the basis that if any one of these 13 petitioners persuaded us to hold in his or her favour, we would examine the remaining cases as well. Unfortunately, none of the 13 petitioners could impress us."

Dismissing all the petitions, the bench said, "Therefore, we have not only rejected the claims of all 13 petitioners whose cases were scrutinised, but have also rejected the claims of all the remaining petitioners. All the writ petitions are devoid of merit and are accordingly dismissed." About 360 teaching and non-teaching staff employed in different madrassas of West Bengal filed around 48 petitions before the top court.

The dispute relates to the West Bengal Madrasah Service Commission Act, 2008, which created a statutory commission to recommend appointments of teachers in recognised madrassas. In 2014, the Calcutta High Court struck down the Act, a decision upheld by its division bench in 2015. However, the Supreme Court stayed the verdict in March 2016.



**SC junks PIL on viewing
pornography at public places**

Observing that it was a policy issue, the Supreme Court on Monday junked a PIL seeking directions to the Centre to formulate a framework to prohibit the viewing of pornography at public places.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohna dismissed the plea and asked the petitioner to approach the Government authorities with a representation.

"Undoubtedly, the issue raised is of paramount importance. However, the subject matter does not involve a question of law requiring examination by this court. It concerns policy issues which need technological advancement and expert consideration. Such issues fall within the domain of experts, especially the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology," the plea said.

The top court was hearing a plea filed by social worker B L Jain, represented by advocate Varun Thakur, seeking directions to formulate a national policy and draft an action plan to curb the viewing of pornography, especially by those not attained the age of majority, and to prohibit the viewing of pornographic material of any form at public places.

"The internet pornography statistics show shocking data, wherein every second, 5,000 porn sites are watched. More than 2 crore porn videos/porn clippings are being launched through the internet..." Under Section 69 A of the Information Technology Act, 2000, the respondents have the power to issue directions for blocking public access of any information through any computer resource," the plea said.

It contended that widespread availability of the internet has made pornographic content easily accessible, leading to excessive consumption and addiction.

Increasing consumption of such content has contributed to the commission of sexual offences, it claimed.



Airfares: SC asks Centre to place rules before it

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Centre to place before it within two weeks the rules framed under the Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam, 2024, which is aimed at modernising India's aviation sector. A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said the rules be placed before it in a sealed cover, irrespective of whether they have been placed before Parliament.

The apex court passed the order while hearing a plea filed by social activist S Laxminarayanan, who has sought a robust and independent regulator that ensures transparency and passenger protection across the civil aviation sector, and regulatory guidelines to control the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfare and ancillary charges imposed by private airlines in India.

The counsel appearing for the Centre informed the bench that the draft rules are ready and they are in the process of translation.

He said the rules have to be

placed before Parliament. "We grant two weeks' time to the respondents to place before this court in a sealed cover the rules which have been framed, irrespective of the fact whether they are placed before the Houses of Parliament," the bench said.

Senior advocate Ravindra Srivastava, appearing for Laxminarayanan, said till the time the new rules come into effect, the old rules are operating.

Flagging the "exorbitant airfares" being charged, Srivastava said, "The solution is that this court must consider having a robust and effective regulatory mechanism which is independent,".

The bench posted the matter for further hearing on August 3.

While hearing the plea on May 15, the apex court said there should be some rationalisation of airfares and asked the Centre to provide relief to flyers.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, who was then appearing for the Centre, told the bench that the new enactment of 2024 had come into effect in January



2025 and the corresponding rules were in the process of being prepared.

On November 17 last year, the top court sought responses from the Centre and others on Laxminarayanan's plea seeking a robust and independent regulator that ensures transparency and passenger protection across the civil aviation sector.

On February 23, the Centre told the apex court that the Ministry of Civil Aviation was actively considering the issues raised in the plea.

While hearing the matter in January, the top court

said it would interfere with the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfares and flagged the exorbitant rise during festivals. The top court had termed the exorbitant rise in airfares by the airlines "exploitation", and asked the Centre and the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) to file their replies on the plea.

The plea claimed that all private airlines have, without any credible justification, reduced the free check-in baggage allowance for economy class passengers from 25 kg to 15 kg, "thereby

converting what was earlier part of the ticketed service into a new revenue stream".

It said the "new policy of permitting only a single piece for check-in and the absence of any rebate, compensation or benefit to passengers who do not avail themselves of check-in baggage demonstrates the arbitrary and discriminatory nature of the measure".

The plea claimed that currently, no authority has the power to review or cap airfares or ancillary fees, allowing the airlines to exploit consumers through hidden

charges and unpredictable pricing. It also said the "unregulated, opaque and exploitative conduct of airlines manifesting in arbitrary fare hikes, unilateral reduction of services, absence of on-ground grievance redressal and unjustified dynamic pricing algorithms directly infringes upon citizens' fundamental rights to equality, freedom of movement and life with dignity".

The plea said the absence of regulatory safeguards results in arbitrary fare hikes, especially during festivals or weather disruptions, which disproportionately harm the poor and last-minute travellers.

It added that inaction by the state in regulating fare algorithms, cancellation policies, service continuity and grievance mechanisms constitutes a dereliction of its constitutional duty and calls for urgent judicial intervention. The plea also said that there is no rule to stop airlines from increasing prices based on demand and allowing them such freedom under essential services is unjustifiable.

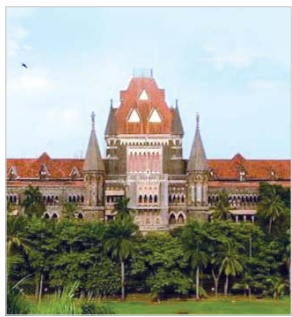
Police's illegal entry into woman's bedroom amounts to violation of privacy: Bombay HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The police's forced entry into a woman's bedroom and seizure of her mobile phone without following legal procedures was an invasion of her privacy and dignity, the Bombay High Court observed, ordering the Maharashtra Government to pay compensation to a Nagpur resident.

The Nagpur bench, comprising Justices Umila Joshi Phalke and Nivedita Mehta, stated that the right to privacy is an integral and inseparable facet of the right to life and personal liberty guaranteed under Article 21 of the Constitution of India, which cannot be infringed.

A copy of the order passed last week was made available on Monday. The bench directed the state to pay ₹10,000 to the 26-year-old petitioner woman within two months, clarifying that the Government could recover the penalty amount directly



from the errant police officer responsible.

"Entry into the residential premises of a citizen, more particularly into the bedroom occupied by a woman, without adherence to the statutory safeguards and forcible seizure of her mobile phone constitutes a serious invasion of privacy and dignity," the court said.

Dismissing the police's contention that the search was undertaken as part of a probe into an offence, the court said this cannot justify a departure from the mandatory safeguards enacted by the

legislature. The investigating agency is expected to act strictly within the bounds of law, and the object of investigation cannot legitimise an otherwise illegal search or seizure, it said.

The bench concluded that the search conducted by the concerned police official and the seizure of the petitioner's mobile phone were illegal and violated her fundamental rights. Hence, she was entitled to compensation.

It further held that although monetary compensation cannot fully redress the invasion of privacy and dignity suffered by the woman, it would provide some measure of solace for the violation of her constitutional rights and serve as a reminder that investigative powers must be exercised strictly in accordance with law and not arbitrarily.

The petitioner, a resident of Saoner in Nagpur, claimed that the police illegally entered her residence, her

bedroom, under the garb of investigating a case and seized her mobile phone without following the statutory procedure laid down by law. The police had claimed that they had visited the petitioner's house to question her in connection with a car accident.

The woman, in her plea, alleged that the police had harassed her and her husband by visiting their residence repeatedly for questioning without issuance of notice and illegally seized and retained her mobile phone for two days without following the procedure prescribed under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSs).

The woman claimed that neither she nor her husband has been named as an accused in the case. The court, in its order, noted that in the present case, there has been a clear non-compliance with the statutory requirements of law.

SC stays Madras HC order on cow slaughter



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday stayed a Madras High Court order which directed the Tamil Nadu Government to ensure that no cow or calf is slaughtered on the eve of Bakrid or on any other day.

"We allow this writ petition with a direction to the state of Tamil Nadu to ensure that no cow or calf is slaughtered on the eve of Bakrid or on any other day," the high court had said.

In its petition, the state Government termed the order contrary to the Tamil Nadu Animal Preservation Act, 1958. The Act permits the slaughter of cows aged over 10 years that are unfit for work and breeding, on the basis of a certificate issued by a competent authority.

court, which directed the state authorities to ensure that no cow or calf is slaughtered across the state either on the eve of Bakrid or on any other day.

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SC to hear pleas against MP High Court verdict on Bhojshala complex

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to list for hearing a batch of appeals challenging a Madhya Pradesh High Court order, which said the disputed Bhojshala complex in Dhar district was a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohna was urged by senior advocate Huzefa Ahmadi and advocate Nizam Pasha, appearing for Muslim appellants, that the pleas needed to be heard on an urgent basis.

The CJI asked the counsel for the appellants to remove defects from the petitions and assured them that they will be listed for hearing

before a bench soon. On May 15, the Madhya Pradesh High Court ruled that the disputed Bhojshala-Kamal Maula Mosque complex in Dhar district is a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati. It simultaneously quashed a decades-old ASI order that had allowed the Muslim community to offer Friday prayers at the site.

The high court had also said that the Centre and the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) can decide on the Bhojshala complex's administration and management.

The Hindu community considers Bhojshala a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati, while the Muslim side calls the 11th-century monument the Kamal Maula Mosque. The disputed complex is protected by the ASI. The Muslim side has filed



appeals against the high court verdict.

Hindu parties have filed caveats in the Supreme Court, saying no orders be passed without hearing it on any appeal against the high court order in the Bhojshala complex dispute case. The high court's division bench of Justices Vijay Kumar Shukla and Alok Awasthi, in its judge-

ment, had said the religious character of the 11th-century monument was based on scientific evidence. The high court clarified that the Muslim side may approach the MP Government for separate land in the district to construct a mosque.

"The religious character of disputed area of the Bhojshala Complex and

Kamal Maula Mosque is held to be a Bhojshala with a temple of goddess Vagdevi (Saraswati)," the bench said in its order and also ordered that the area of Bhojshala "is held to be a protected monument" under 1958 Act with effect from March 3, 1904. Directing that the ASI shall have full supervisory control over the preservation, conservation and regulation of religious access, the court asked the Centre and the ASI to take a decision for the purpose of administration and management of the affairs of the Bhojshala temple and Sanskrit learning.

The high court had said the central Government "may consider" representations of some of the petitioners to bring back the 'Pratima' (idol) of Goddess Saraswati from the

London Museum and re-establish the same within the complex. This order nullified the April 2003 ASI order that permitted Hindus to worship on Tuesdays and Muslims to offer *namaz* on Fridays.

The high court's order had a mention about the background and legal arguments surrounding the Ayodhya dispute as many petitioners referred to the Supreme Court judgement. The court also asked the Madhya Pradesh Government to consider a plea from the petitioners for allocation of a land in Dhar district for construction of a mosque.

The court said from the archaeological and historical facts it is "crystal clear that the building in question is a Hindu temple and place of learning of Sanskrit language".

Patna court grants anticipatory bail to Khan Sir

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

A court in Bihar's Patna on Monday granted anticipatory bail to educator Faisal Khan, popularly known as Khan Sir, in connection with the coaching institute firing case. Three staff members of the coaching institute also got anticipatory bail, Khan Sir's lawyer said.

The case relates to a firing incident that occurred in early June after a group of 15-20 people allegedly vandalised Khan Global Studies Institute in the State Capital on June 2 night and hurled stones at its premises.

His two security guards have been accused of firing in the air during the incident. Khan was named in an FIR related to the firing incident. "Six people have been granted bail. The judge first



announced Khan Sir's anticipatory bail, followed by that of his three staff members," lawyer Arvind Kumar Mouar told reporters.

The Patna Civil Court also granted bail to two security guards, who were arrested in connection with the case, he said. "We presented our arguments, and the Public Prosecutor (PP) opposed them. However, the police had already recorded the findings in the case diary

after conducting a proper investigation," Mouar said.

During the investigation, it was found that the guards fired in the air from licensed arms, he added.

"The guards carried out aerial firing in self-defence. The police recorded in the FIR that one of the guards had sustained head injuries before the firing. Under Section 35 of the BNS, a licensed firearm holder has the right to act in self-defence

or to protect one's life and property," the lawyer said. The court had on Friday deferred its order on the anticipatory bail plea of Khan Sir in the case till July 13, citing the district judge's leave. On July 8, it had reserved the order after hearing final arguments from both sides.

Khan Sir had alleged that his rival Raushan Anand orchestrated the vandalism of his coaching institute. While Khan Sir evaded arrest throughout the court proceedings, Anand was apprehended a day after the vandalism incident.

He was granted bail on June 15, a couple of days after his brother Prince Yadav was found dead under mysterious circumstances in Nepal's Biratnagar. Upon his release, Anand accused Khan of having orchestrated the "murder" of his brother Prince Yadav.

3 chargesheets filed in 7 ADAG FIRs: CBI tells SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI on Monday told the Supreme Court that it has filed three chargesheets in as many cases out of the total seven FIRs concerning alleged large-scale banking fraud involving Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group and its firms.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohna was told by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for CBI, that the investigation in the other four cases was underway. The top court took note of the submission by Mehta and directed the CBI to file a status report on the progress in the investigation.

It also recorded that the Enforcement Directorate has also filed a prosecution



report, equivalent to a chargesheet, in related money laundering cases.

During the hearing, advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the petitioner, former bureaucrat EAS Sarma, alleged that the kingpin Anil Ambani has not been arrested so far in the cases. He said though three chargesheets were filed

by June, the CBI has not filed any status report in the matter.

Bhushan submitted that though SEBI mentioned the "pivotal" role of Anil Ambani, there is nothing disclosed in the status report filed by CBI. He alleged that no action has been taken against Anil Ambani and only relatively lowly officers have been arrested.

"I am saying they should disclose to your lordships what they have found about his role. In a 2025 chargesheet, the CBI says he was kingpin. SEBI says he was kingpin," Bhushan said.

Solicitor General refuted Bhushan's submission and told the court that it is wrong to say that only lowly officers have been arrested.

Even managing directors and executives have been arrested, he said. The top

court said it would not be fair to direct anything and asked Bhushan to go through the chargesheet about the role attributed to Anil Ambani. Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Anil Ambani, submitted that such a comment itself will cause prejudice to his party. "Once a chargesheet is filed, cognisance is yet to be taken. This is not the procedure this court has ever followed," Sibal said.

The top court said it was conscious that nothing should come from the bench which can be prejudicial to the parties.

Mehta, appearing for agencies, had earlier told the court that there are a total of nine FIRs, out of which seven are under investigation. "In the seven cases, the total loss caused is ₹27,337 crore," he had said.

PIOTECH

Truecaller row: TRAI seeks power under IT Act to act

Telecom regulator TRAI has sought to be designated as an 'authorised agency' under the IT Act, a status that would allow it to act against call management apps, and the matter is now being examined by the IT Ministry, according to sources.

The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) on Friday had asserted that no app can block phone calls originating from 1600 number series that are meant for communications by regulated entities and the Government to citizens.

TRAI's assertions had come amid an ongoing tussle with caller identification app Truecaller over the labelling and identification of calls from the dedicated number series.

On Monday, officials in MeitY (Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology) said that the issue of regulatory jurisdiction is a technical one.

"Under the IT Act, there are rules as to some agencies that are authorised to take action, like the Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre (I4C), etc., so that is done by the appropriate Government. So the question is who is the appropriate Government to authorise TRAI... Department of Telecom (DoT) believes it is MeitY and MeitY says it will examine and take a call," the official said, adding that the IT Ministry is not looking at the Truecaller issue per se. (PTI)

Flipkart says West Bengal to remain key investment hub



Flipkart on Monday said it would deepen its long-term investments in West Bengal, expanding its supply chain infrastructure, seller ecosystem and skills initiatives in the State, which houses the company's largest fulfilment centre in India.

The Walmart-owned e-commerce company said West Bengal is home to its largest fulfilment and logistics hub, located at Haringhata, and remains central to its long-term growth strategy.

The Haringhata campus has a storage capacity of 5 million cubic feet across six mezzanine levels and features automated storage and retrieval systems, robotic packaging arms, cross-belt sorters and a nine-kilometre conveyor network.

Flipkart said the facility is the first e-commerce fulfilment centre of its scale in India to receive the Indian Green Building Council's Platinum certification.

Across West Bengal, the company operates more than 300 fulfilment centres, mother hubs and last-mile delivery facilities, supporting more than 120,000 direct and indirect jobs across operations, technology, delivery and support functions.

The company said it also creates thousands of seasonal jobs during its annual Big Billion Days sale.

Flipkart has expanded its quick commerce business, Flipkart Minutes, in the state with 90 micro fulfilment centres, creating close to 10,000 employment opportunities. The company added that its sourcing network includes more than 500 farmers from West Bengal supplying fresh fruits and vegetables.

"West Bengal has long been one of India's great centres of enterprise, innovation and craftsmanship. Today, it is also emerging as a key hub for digital commerce. At Flipkart, we are proud to be a long-term partner in the State's growth journey. Our investments in infrastructure, technology and supply chains are creating jobs, empowering MSMEs, supporting farmers and enabling thousands of entrepreneurs to access markets across India. As home to our largest fulfilment centre in the country, West Bengal will continue to play a pivotal role in Flipkart's growth, and we remain committed to investing in the State's people, businesses and long-term potential," said Kalyan Krishnamurthy, Chief Executive Officer, Flipkart Group. (PTI)

Rajnath Singh: AI cannot replace human compassion

Artificial Intelligence is bringing rapid progress in medical sciences, but it cannot replace human compassion, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Monday, urging budding doctors to work with empathy towards patients and their families.

Addressing the 22nd convocation ceremony of King George's Medical University in his Lok Sabha constituency, Lucknow, the minister said new technologies such as artificial intelligence, synthetic biology, gene editing and precision medicine are transforming both the direction and the landscape of healthcare. Therefore, doctors must always continue the process of learning, he said. "Medical science is evolving rapidly today... Today is the era of Artificial Intelligence. No field remains untouched by it, including your own. "Yet, Artificial Intelligence cannot assure a mother that her child will recover (from illness). It cannot hold the hand of an elderly person, and say, 'Do not worry; we will set everything right'.

"Technology can be intelligent, but it cannot be compassionate. It can read medical charts, but it cannot, under any circumstances, understand the pain in a patient's mind," Rajnath Singh said. "Hence, you have to work with empathy and compassion."

The minister said that saving a life is the "highest duty. Fulfilling this duty does not always require vast resources or institutional support; all that is needed is sensitivity and firm resolve. "If one holds the feeling that saving a life is the supreme duty, then circumstances never become an obstacle," the minister said. (PTI)

The username wars: India's small fight over a very big question

The Government is asking why citizens should be allowed to talk without sharing phone numbers. In a democracy, that question runs the other way



NISHANT SAHDEV

Sometime on July 2, a letter left the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology carrying one of the strangest regulatory questions ever put to a technology company. Addressed to Telegram and Signal, it asked, in essence: why should Indians be allowed to talk to each other without exchanging phone numbers?

Strip away the legal language and that is the whole dispute. Not encryption. Not national security. A handle - a string of characters beginning with @ - that lets a woman message a stranger on a marketplace without handing over the number that rings in her pocket at midnight.

The sequence tells its own story. On July 1, WhatsApp was ordered to pause the rollout of its optional username feature until the Government was "satisfied" with its safeguards. Within a day, notices reached Telegram and Signal demanding they justify features they have offered for years - Telegram since 2014, Signal since 2024. Zoho's homegrown app Arattai did not wait to argue; it announced it would simply switch its usernames off. In forty-eight hours, a design choice made independently by four companies on four continents became a matter requiring explanation in New Delhi. None of the notices has been made public. Citizens are learning what their Government demands of their communication tools through press leaks.

To see what is actually at stake, rewind nine days. On June 23, the Government notified the authorisation rules under the Telecommunications Act, 2023 — the statute that finally retires the Indian Telegraph Act of 1885 and the Wireless Telegraphy Act of 1933. The word "licence" vanishes from Indian telecom law after 141 years; "authorisation" replaces it, applications now flow through a digital portal, and a colonial framework written for a world in which the state owned the copper wire is gone. This is genuine, overdue modernisation, and the Government deserves credit for it.

But the new law carries a definition with enormous gravitational pull. It describes telecommunication in technology-neutral terms — the transmission of messages by wire, radio, optical or other electro-magnetic systems.

Lawyers have warned that this language is broad enough to pull internet messaging apps into the telecom net whenever the Government chooses to notify them. Read against that backdrop, the username notices



are not a stray consumer-protection exercise. They are a sound-line, dropped to measure how far the new perimeter can reach. Here, a little engineering honesty would rescue the debate, because the public conversation has collapsed two very different things into one: an identifier and an identity.

A username is not a cloak of invisibility. It is a pointer - a human-readable label that a server translates into an account, exactly as the internet's address book translates "thepioneer.com" into a string of numbers. On an end-to-end encrypted platform, the message itself is unreadable to everyone except sender and recipient, whether it was addressed to a phone number or a handle. Banning usernames decrypts nothing. Permitting them encrypts nothing. The mathematics is serenely indifferent to what you call yourself.

What a username does disturb is an arrangement the Indian state has quietly enjoyed for two decades. Every SIM card in this country is issued against verified identity documents. When your messaging account is welded to your mobile number, the state inherits — free of charge, without passing a single law — a chain of custody linking every conversation to a KYC-verified human being. Usernames loosen that weld. That, not fraud, is the deeper anxiety, and we should have the honesty to debate it as what it is: a question about how much anonymity a free society owes its citizens, not a squabble over an app setting.

The fraud concern is real, and it deserves respect rather than dismissal. Digital arrest scams, phishing and impersonation have



exploded. A Ministry of Home Affairs cyber-crime report, submitted to the Delhi High Court, reportedly logged over 6.8 lakh Telegram-linked complaints with losses exceeding ₹71,000 crore. Telegram - banned for a week in June ahead of the NEET-UG re-examination over paper-leak fears - has earned much of its scrutiny.

But a remedy must connect to the disease, and here the engineering refuses to cooperate with the politics. The overwhelming majority of scam calls and messages in India arrive today through phone numbers - spoofed, virtual, international, or procured on forged documents. Two decades of KYC-verified SIMs have not stopped them. If verified numbers cannot stop number-based fraud, it is magical thinking to believe unverified fraud will stop because usernames were banned. Criminals route around identifiers; that is practically their job description. Meanwhile, the people usernames genuinely protect are exactly those the state claims to champion: women dodging stalkers, journalists shielding sources, doctors and teachers who must be reachable without surrendering a personal number to a thousand strangers. Signal designed its usernames to be invisible by default for precisely this reason — the feature exists to shrink the personal data a conversation exposes, not enlarge it.

There is also a rule-of-law problem that should worry us even if the technology bores us. Digital rights groups, including SFLC.in, have pointed out that neither the Information Technology Act nor its rules create any prior-approval regime under which platforms must seek permission

before shipping a feature — and have demanded the ministry publish the notices and cite their legal basis. Analysts see the real lever: Section 79 of the IT Act, the safe-harbour provision meant to shield intermediaries, being quietly brandished as a threat. When software features require a nod from a ministry, delivered through unpublished letters, we have not regulated technology. We have built a permission raj for code.

India, of all nations, should recognise the superior alternative, because India invented it. We did not fight payment fraud by banning UPI handles - which are, let us be honest, usernames for money. We engineered trust into the rails: the beneficiary's verified name appears before you pay, limits cap the damage, grievance systems run in public view. UPI now moves billions of transactions a month precisely because identity assurance was built into the architecture rather than bolted on through prohibition. The same template fits messaging: enforce rapid, due-process responses to law-enforcement requests; mandate proactive impersonation detection; hold grievance officers personally accountable; require public transparency reports. Regulate outcomes. Leave the architecture alone.

The new telecom rules themselves mark the boundary the Government is now blurring. They require carriers to store network logs in India and route satellite traffic through Indian gateways — defensible sovereignty measures aimed at companies occupying spectrum, a genuinely scarce public resource. But an app is not a carrier, any more than a conversation is a highway because it happened in a moving car. The 1885 Telegraph Act conflated the message with the wire because, in 1885, the state owned both. The 2023 Act was written to end that confusion. It would be a bitter irony if its first real-world test smuggled the Victorian instinct back in digital clothing.

Which brings us back to the question in that July 2 letter — why should you be allowed to offer usernames? and to the quiet scandal inside it. The burden of proof is upside down. In a constitutional democracy, citizens do not petition the state for permission to speak without disclosing a phone number; the state must justify why they cannot. India is building the most ambitious digital public infrastructure on earth, and its credibility rests on one proposition: that we govern technology through law, in the open - not through the leverage of letters no one is allowed to read. On that proposition, this very small fight over a very small feature has become a very large test.

(The writer is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems)

We taught machines our paperwork - Now they are judging us

India built the World's biggest trust machine. Can It survive AI?



PRAVIN KAUSHAL

Somewhere today, a loan is approved, a university seat allotted, a bail application weighed. Increasingly, no human makes the final call. A model does. This is already how power moves through modern institutions, and the change is bigger than automation.

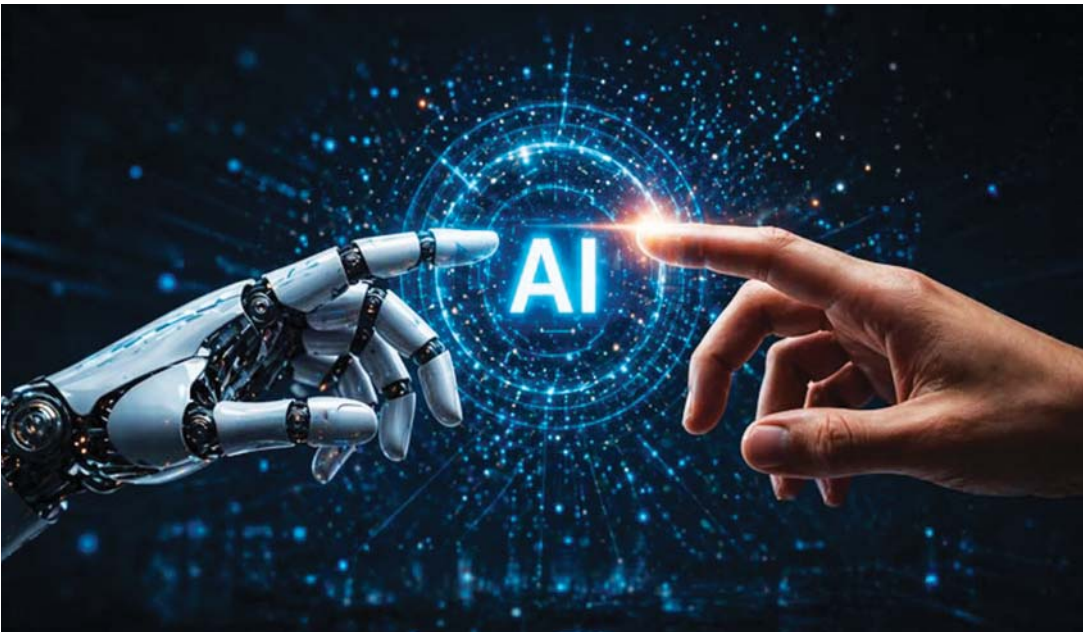
Artificial intelligence is usually discussed as a tool, a faster calculator, a smarter search engine. But a tool does only what it is told. A calculator cannot invent a new branch of mathematics. Today's AI systems learn things their creators never taught them and change in ways their designers did not predict. A chess engine did not simply get better at chess, it invented openings that centuries of grandmasters never conceived. That is not automation. That is agency.

The usual objection is that such agency stays confined to artificial arenas built for the purpose, a chessboard, a simulation. Drop the world's best chess engine into a forest and it cannot start a fire. But the same is true of us. A person left alone on a mountain-side with no tools would not last a week. Our intelligence also functions only inside a specific environment built by human cooperation itself. The question is not whether AI has a real environment to operate in, but whether we already built one for it.

We did. It is called bureaucracy.

The actual machinery of human power

Humans did not conquer the planet by being individually stronger or smarter than other animals. A person alone loses to a



lion. What no other species can do is cooperate in the millions with total strangers. Humans cooperate with people they will never meet, through a shared system of law and institutions that manufacture something invisible but essential: trust.

That is what bureaucracy actually is. A banker does not build furniture. She builds a bridge of trust between a saver who has never met an entrepreneur and an entrepreneur who has never met the saver, so one's money can fund the other's ambition. A judge, a regulator, a bishop, an accountant, each spends the day manufacturing trust between strangers using nothing but words: forms, statutes, ledgers, scriptures, judgments. Money itself is a trust technology, a printed note that lets a stranger hand you bread on the strength of a shared fiction.

This system is powerful



precisely because it does not require its operators to be generally capable. A lawyer who cannot start a fire can, through paperwork alone, reshape a city, because the bureaucratic environment that gives her words their power has already been imposed on the world. That is exactly the environment an AI thrives in.

Why AI is a native, not a guest

Human domination relies on large scale cooperation among strangers, sustained by bureaucratic systems such as laws, finance, and religion, designed to build trust. No human lawyer can hold every statute in their head. An AI

can hold an entire legal code and never mis-remember a clause. No accountant can track every transaction across a global bank. An AI can. A human bureaucrat is, at best, a custodian of a fraction of the rulebook. An AI can be native to the whole rulebook, because bureaucracy, stripped to its essentials, is nothing but words arranged to create trust and consequence.

This is why AI is uniquely placed to take over decisions that once required a human in the room: whether to grant a bank loan, admit a student, decide how long a prisoner should serve, or fire a missile at a target. Each was once human judgment wrapped in bureaucratic process. Increasingly, it is bureaucratic process with the human judgment quietly removed.

India is the loudest test case

Nowhere is this transition further along than in India, though it rarely gets described that way.

Over the past decade, India built the largest biometric identity and digital payments architecture on Earth, authenticating identity and clearing welfare payments for over a billion people with a thinner layer of human discretion than almost any comparable system anywhere. Credit scoring for small loans increasingly runs on models rather than branch managers. Courts, facing tens of millions of pending cases, are exploring AI assisted case triage. This was not built as an AI project, it was built for efficiency, but a machine legible bureaucracy is exactly the terrain an AI decision maker enters with the least friction. India built the habitat first, and AI is simply the most capable resident to move in.

That is a source of both pride and unease. A machine readable state can be more efficient and less corruptible. But a decision produced by a model is hard to argue with. You cannot cross examine an algorithm's reasoning the way you can cross examine an official's.

The question we have not answered

Two questions need answers before this transition goes further, not after a crisis forces them. Does every citizen have an enforceable right to know, in plain language, why an automated system decided against them? Does every citizen retain a genuine path to have that decision reviewed by a human being, not a token appeal, but a real one? A loan, a degree, a sentence, once decided by someone who could explain themselves, is quietly becoming a decision made by something that cannot be asked for anything, unless we insist, now, that it must be.

(Writer is a tech and social entrepreneur and Programme Director (Eastern India) at WHEELS Global Foundation, a Pan-IT alumni initiative working across 20+ states in India)



VIVRITI CAPITAL LIMITED
(formerly known as Hari and Company Investments Madras Limited,
and Hari and Company Investments Madras Private Limited)
CIN - U65991TN1989PLC017066
REGD. OFFICE : Prestige Zackria, Metropolitan No. 200/1-8, 8th Floor, Block -1, Annasaalai,
Chennai - 600002 Tamil Nadu Contact : +91-44-4007 4800. contact@vivriticapital.com
MUMBAI OFFICE: Vibgyor Towers, Unit No. 302, 3rd Floor Block G, Bandra Kurla Complex
Mumbai - 400051.

BY RPAD/EMAIL
WITHOUT PREJUDICE
Date: 10th July 2025

To,
1. Gensol Electric Vehicles Private Limited
Gat No. 877, Next to Mahindra Towers, Khed, Nigohje, Chakan, Pune, Maharashtra-410501
Kind Attn: Mr. Anmol Singh Jaggi
2. Mr Anmol Jaggi
706A, Camellias, DLF Golf Link, Sector-42, VTC: Galleria DLF-IV, PO: Galleria DLF-IV,
Gurgaon, Haryana - 122009
3. Gensol Engineering Limited
15th Floor, A Block, Westgate Business Bay, S G Road, Jivraj Park, Ahmedabad, Ahmedabad
City, Gujarat, India, 380051
Dear Sir,

Sub: Statutory demand notice under section 13(2) of the Securitisation and
Reconstruction of the Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act,
2002 (as amended from time to time) and the rules made thereunder.

I, the undersigned, being the Authorized Officer of Vivriti Capital Limited (formerly known as
Hari and Company Investments Madras Limited, and Hari and Company Investments Madras
Private Limited) ("Lender") appointed pursuant to the provisions of the Securitisation and
Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002
(hereinafter referred to as the said "Act"), read with the Security Interest (Enforcement)
Rules, 2002 (hereinafter referred to as the said "Rules") hereby issue this statutory demand
notice to you, under section 13(2) of the said Act as under:

1. Pursuant to the terms envisaged under the Facility Documents mentioned in **Annexure I**
hereinbelow, Gensol Electric Vehicles Private Limited ("GEVPL") is obligated to pay/repay the
outstanding dues under the respective Facility along with applicable interest, additional
interest and any other charges and costs/expenses (as applicable) on the respective due
dates.
2. That You, addressee Nos. 1, is the Borrower, and You, Nos. 2 and 3, stood as guarantors in
the said Facility 1 to secure the debt of the Borrower; You, No. 1, also secured the obligations
of Gensol Engineering Limited towards VCL under the said Facility 2 and You No.2 stood as a
guarantor in said Facility 2. Further, GEVPL has created a first ranking exclusive and
continuing charge by way of hypothecation over all the Current Assets and Movable Assets as
more particularly detailed in **Annexure II ("Secured Assets")** in favour of the Lender, to
secure the repayment under the said Facilities, by way of Master Hypothecation Agreements
and Deeds of Hypothecation as mentioned in Annexure I.

3. We note that, despite repeated reminders and requests, the addressees have failed and
neglected to make payment/ repayment of outstanding amounts under the said Facilities.
Further the Facility 1 and Facility 2 has been classified as non-performing asset in the books
of the Lender in accordance with extant regulatory guidelines on 03.08.2025 and
05.11.2025, respectively.

4. In the light of the above, the Lender being the secured creditor with respect to the Secured
Assets, is issuing this statutory demand notice to GEVPL to pay to the Lender a sum
equivalent to the outstanding amounts under the respective Facilities (as detailed in
Annexure III ("Outstanding Amounts"), within a period of **60 (sixty) days** from the date of
receipt of this statutory demand notice, failing which the Lender shall be entitled to enforce the
security interest over the Secured Assets created in its favour, without intervention of the
court or tribunal, by taking recourse to one or more of the measures under Section 13 (4) of
the Act and Rules including (but not limited to) taking over possession and disposal of the
Secured Assets for realizing the Outstanding Amounts under the Facilities at your sole risk and
responsibility as to the costs and consequences thereof.

5. That your attention is also invited to section 13(13) of the Act, in terms of which you are
prohibited from transferring the Secured Assets by way of sale, lease, or otherwise without
the prior written consent of the Lender. Please also note that non-compliance/contravention
of the provisions contained in the said Act read with the Rules is an offence punishable under
section 29 of the Act.

6. Please note that your attention is invited to the provisions of section 13(8) of the Act, under
which you may pay the entire amount of Outstanding Amounts together with applicable
interest, additional interest, penal charges, and any other charges/costs/expenses (as
applicable) to the satisfaction of the Lender.

7. This statutory demand notice is issued strictly without prejudice to, and shall not be
construed as a waiver, abandonment, limitation, or election of any rights, remedies, claims, or
proceedings available to the Lender under the Facility Documents, the Act, or any other
applicable law. The Lender expressly reserves the right to pursue, continue or initiate any
other legal or contractual remedy or proceeding, whether simultaneously or otherwise,
against any or all of the addressees and/or any secured assets, without prejudice to its rights
under the Act.

Yours sincerely,
For Vivriti Capital Limited
Authorized Officer

**Annexure – I
Facility Details**

1. A non-revolving rupee term loan facility of INR 5,00,00,000/- (Indian Rupees Five Crores
Only) availed by the Borrower/ GEVPL on the terms and conditions of Sanction Letter dated
03.08.2024, Master General Terms Agreement dated 03.08.2024, Master Hypothecation
Agreement dated 03.08.2024, Facility Agreement dated 03.08.2024, Unattested Deed of
Hypothecation dated 03.08.2024, Personal Guarantee dated 03.08.2024 and Corporate
Guarantee dated 03.08.2024 executed by Mr. Anmol Jaggi and Gensol Engineering Limited
respectively in favor of Vivriti Capital Limited along with such other facility documents
executed in relation to the facility (each as amended from time to time) ("Facility 1")
2. Master Rental Agreement dated 27.02.2024 between M/s. Connect Residual Private
Limited and Gensol Engineering Limited read with corresponding Rental Schedule, Term
Sheet dated 06.08.2024, Notice of Purchase of Receivables/ Notice of Assignment dated
06.08.2024 and 29.08.2024 executed between M/s. Connect Residual Private Limited and
Gensol Engineering Limited and Vivriti Capital Limited, Deed of Hypothecation dated
06.08.2024 and 29.08.2024 executed by Gensol Electric Vehicles Private Limited in favor of
Vivriti Capital for to secure the obligation of Gensol Engineering Limited, Personal Guarantee
dated 06.08.2024 and 30.08.2024 executed by Mr. Anmol Singh Jaggi in favor of Vivriti
Capital along with such other facility documents executed in relation to the credit facility to the
tune of INR 28,39,48,817/- (Indian Rupees Twenty Eight Crore Thirty Nine Lakhs Forty Eight
Thousand Eight Hundred and Seventeen only (each as amended from time to time) ("Facility
2")

For the sake of brevity, Facility 1 and Facility 2 shall hereinafter be collectively referred to as
"Facilities", and all facility documents executed in relation to the said Facilities shall
hereinafter be referred to as "Facility Documents".

**Annexure – II
Secured Asset**
DESCRIPTION OF HYPOTHECATED ASSETS

i) Description of Current Assets
All of the Borrower's rights, title, interests, benefits and claims in relation to any and all
proceeds, consideration and amounts owing, accrued, payable to and/or received by or to be
received by the Borrower, and all the current assets of the Borrower, both present and future,
including without limitation the Borrower's inventories, investments classified as "held for
trading", whole of the Borrower's present and future stocks of raw materials, goods in
process of manufacture, semi-finished goods and all finished and manufactured goods and
articles together with all stores, components, spares, consumable stores and spares and other
current assets including trade and any claims by way of refund of customs/ excise duties,
claims, stock in trade, present and future book debts, outstanding monies, receivables,
claims, bills, investments, loans and advances extended by the Borrower, rights to or on
moveable properties and moveable assets forming part of current assets which are now due
owing or payable or belonging to the Borrower or which may at any time hereafter become
due, owing payable or belonging to the Borrower in the course of its business, whether
installed or not and whether lying loose or in cases or which are lying or are stored in or to be
stored in or to be brought into or upon the Borrower's premises, warehouses, stockyards and
godowns or the premises, warehouses, stockyards and godowns of the Borrower's agents,
associates or representatives or at various work sites or at any place or places wherever else
situated or wherever else the same may be situated, stored or lying or being including any raw
materials, inventories, article or goods, any stores, spares and components or other similar
assets in transit or delivery to the Borrower and all of the rights, title, interest, benefit, claims
and demand whatsoever of the Borrower's bank accounts, including without limitations, the
escrow account, trust and retention account, other accounts and all the sub-accounts
thereunder, debt service reserve account (if applicable) or other contracts including all
operating cash flows and Receivables of the Borrower and all other assets and securities,
instruments, investments, and other properties deposited or required to be deposited or
credited to such accounts with all the monies lying to the credit of such accounts or liable to be
credited to such accounts which description shall include all properties of the above
description whether presently in existence or acquired hereafter. Where "Receivables" shall
mean all present and future cash flows of the Borrower received/ to be received including but
not limited to the entire consideration, fees, and/or any other amounts received/ to be
received by Borrower pursuant to, inter alia, any agreement(s), contract(s) for/ of sale as the
case maybe, all revenues, income and other amounts (including without limitation, any cash
benefits and cash subsidies) owing to, receivable and/or received by the Borrower.

ii) Description of Movable Assets

All and singular, tangible movable assets (both present and future) of the Borrower, and in
particular including without limitation all its plants, machinery, constructions and structures,
erected and to be erected whether affixed to earth or not as also all tangible movable assets
and in particular including, without limitation, all movable plant and machinery (whether
attached or otherwise), machinery, spares, electrical and other installation, hardware,
computer software, wiring, pipelines, tanks, meters, motor vehicles, furniture, fixtures,
fittings, tools and accessories and all other equipment whether installed or not, whether lying
loose or in cases or lying stored in or to be stored or to be brought into or upon the Borrower's
premises whether now belonging to or that may at any time, till the Final Settlement Date
belong to the Borrower or that may at present or hereafter be held by any person to the order or
disposition of the Borrower, or in the course of transit or delivery, and all replacements thereof
and additions thereof whether by way of substitution, replacement, conversion, realization or
otherwise howsoever together with all benefits, rights and incidental attached thereto which
are now or shall at anytime hereafter be owned by the Borrower and all estate, right, title,
interest, property, claims and demands whatsoever of the Borrower unto and upon the same
which description shall include all properties of the above description whether presently in
existence, constructed or acquired hereafter and intangible movable assets (both present and
future) including without limitation all its rights, interest and benefit under the brands,
goodwill, trademarks, patents, copyrights or any other intellectual properties owned by the
Borrower.

Hypothecated Assets includes all Current Assets and Movable Fixed Assets as defined under
the Facility Documents pertaining to Facility 2, including, but not limited to, all assets
identified by the courts/authorities as hypothecated with the Lender.

**Annexure – II
Details of Outstanding Amount of Facility 1 as on 9th July 2026**

Particulars	Amount
Principal Overdue	Rs. 2,03,53,694
Interest Overdue	Rs. 53,97,250
Balance Principal due	Rs. 1,80,55,553
Penal Charges	Rs. 27,47,799

**Total Outstanding Amount Rs. 4,65,54,296 (Rupees Four Crore Sixty
Five Lakhs Fifty Four Thousand Two Hundred
Ninety Six Only)**

Details of Outstanding Amount of Facility 2 as on 9th July 2026

Particulars	Amount
Rental Overdue	Rs. 12,11,57,990
Balance Rentals	Rs. 13,21,48,792
Penal Charges	Rs. 1,09,98,592

**Total Outstanding Amount Rs. 26,43,05,374 (Rupees Twenty Six Crores
Forty Three Lakhs Five Thousand Three
Hundred Seventy Four Only)**

**Total Outstanding Amount due and payable under the said Facilities as on 9th July 2026 is
Rs.31,08,59,870/- (Rupees Thirty One Crores Eight Lakhs Fifty Nine Thousand Six
Hundred Seventy Only)**

UK bans Revolutionary Guard over attacks on Jewish sites

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

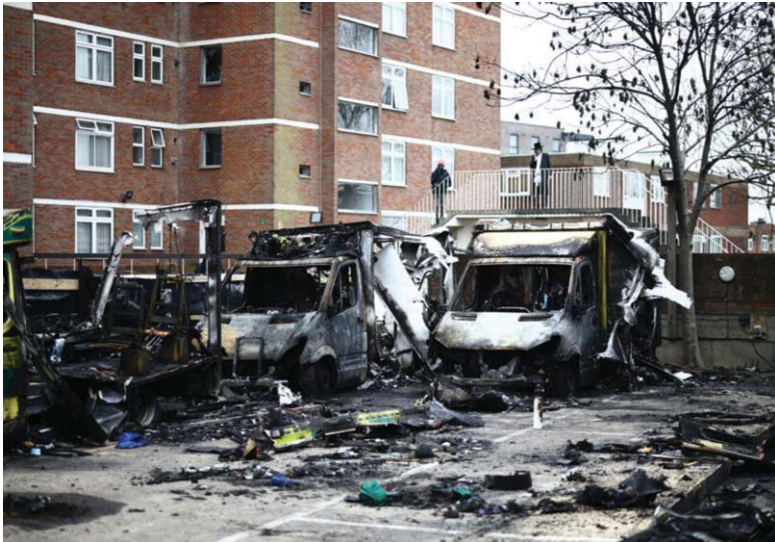
A series of arson and vandalism attacks on Jewish sites in Britain were the work of a proxy group backed by Iran, the UK Government said on Monday.

The Government said it is banning the Islamic Movement of the Companions of the Right, or IMCR, also known as Harakat Ashab al-Yamin al-Islamia.

It also banned Iran's powerful paramilitary Revolutionary Guard. In a statement, Security Minister Angela Eagle said that the IMCR has claimed seven attacks in the UK.

The group had said online that it was responsible for a string of arson attacks on Jewish sites in London in recent months, including fires at synagogues and Jewish charity ambulances, as well as a Persian-language media organisation critical of Iran's Government. No one were injured in the blazes.

"Sitting behind IMCR were members of Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps Qods Force, who almost certainly directed IMCR attacks across Europe," she said. Quds, or Jerusalem, Force is the Guard's expeditionary unit. The group sprang up online earlier this year and has also claimed responsibility for synagogue attacks in Belgium and the Netherlands.



Law enforcement officials and intelligence experts say Iran-backed proxy groups are behind a growing number of attacks in Europe, most targeting the Jewish community and Persian-language media critical of Iran's Islamic Government.

They typically work by recruiting members of criminal groups to carry out sabotage and other attacks.

Earlier this month, two Romanian men were given prison sentences over the stabbing of a journalist from a Persian-language television station, an attack the judge said was carried out on behalf of the Iranian State. There was no immediate comment from Iran. The European Union in January listed the Revolutionary Guard as a terrorist organisation over Tehran's bloody crackdown on protests.

Sheikh Hasina will land in jail if she returns: Bangladesh minister

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dhaka

Deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina will be jailed if she returns to Bangladesh, a state minister said on Monday, amid reports that the banned Awami League leader is preparing to return to Dhaka by December.

Hasina, the 78-year-old daughter of Bangladesh's founder Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, was toppled in a violent student-led street protest on August 5, 2024. She has been living in India since she fled Dhaka following the collapse of her Government. "If she surrenders, steps will be taken in accordance with the existing law. She will have to go to jail. The law will take its own



Shama Obaed Islam

course," State Minister for Foreign Affairs Shama Obaed Islam was quoted as saying by the State-run BSS news agency. Shama said that the government would proceed strictly in accordance with the existing legal framework if Hasina surrenders.

Last week, sources close to Hasina said she is preparing to return to Dhaka by

December. It is a completely voluntary decision, they added. "Wherever Sheikh Hasina surrenders, whether in India or Bangladesh, she will have to go to jail first. The government has nothing to consider regarding the statements of a convicted individual," Shama told reporters.

She said that Hasina has already been convicted and, therefore, the government has nothing to consider regarding the statements of a convicted person.

In November last, Hasina was sentenced to death in absentia by a special tribunal in Dhaka for alleged "crimes against humanity" over her government's brutal crackdown on student-led protests in 2024.

Ukraine, 9 countries form coalition to shield Europe from ballistic missiles

EMMA CARMICHAEL/ILLIA NOVIKOV ■ Paris

Ukraine and nine other countries on Monday announced they were forming a coalition to protect Europe from ballistic missiles, taking advantage of Kyiv's experience of fighting Russia's full-scale invasion for over four years.

"Our goal is to build a shared ballistic missile defense capability for Europe," the 10 nations said in a statement in Paris at talks with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy. Zelenskyy was Paris asking



French President Emmanuel Macron, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and British Prime Minister Keir Starmer posing for a picture with other participants of the Coalition of the Willing summit on security guarantees for Ukraine at the Hotel des Invalides in Paris

two dozen European leaders for help developing measures against Russia's ballistic missiles, which have pummeled his country. Europe is wary of Moscow's wider

ambitions on the continent. Zelenskyy and the leaders of Denmark, France, Germany, Italy, the Netherlands, Norway, Spain, Sweden and the United Kingdom said they recognized "the growing threat posed by ballistic missiles," which are harder to stop than cruise missiles or drones. "We believe that protecting Europe requires a comprehensive solution, in the form of an integrated missile defense architecture, to deter and neutralize future missile threats," the statement said. "We recognise Ukraine's unique experience,

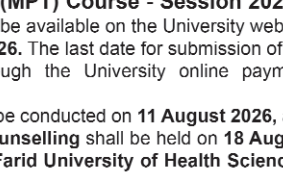
gained through its defense against the war of aggression waged by Russia."

The statement gave no time frame for setting up the defense system, and said the plan remained open to other countries. Russian President Vladimir Putin was unyielding, vowing Monday emphatic retaliation to Kyiv's recent long-range attacks on refineries, tankers and terminals that have caused widespread fuel shortages. "Wherever they attempt to strike Russian territory, we will respond in kind, but our strikes will be several times more powerful,"

Putin told a meeting with pro-Kremlin activists. European foreign ministers were meeting separately in Brussels where they were expected to discuss Ukraine's needs and Russia's threats to the continent.

"Our top priority is anti-ballistic defense," Zelenskyy said in Paris. Zelenskyy is keen to accelerate efforts to jointly developing with European countries anti-ballistic air defenses ahead of the winter, when Russia usually intensifies its attacks to deny Ukrainians electricity, heat and water. (AP)

Ex-minister murder probe taken over by UK Police



ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Britain's counter-terrorism police on Monday took charge of an ongoing investigation into the murder of a former Tory minister and outspoken far-right politician who was found dead in her home in England.

Ann Widdecombe, 78, was attacked in the small village of Haytor Vale at Dartmoor in Devon last week. PM Keir Starmer led condemnations over the "really shocking news" that shook the political establishment across party lines.

White British man from Rotherham, South Yorkshire, arrested on suspicion of murder on Saturday, has now been re-arrested on terrorism-related charges, Counter Terrorism Policing South East (CTPSE) said. (PTI)

NASA astronaut Anil Menon set for 8-month mission to space station

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

Anil Menon, a NASA astronaut of Indian descent, is set to embark on an eight-month mission to the International Space Station on Tuesday from the Baikonur cosmodrome in Kazakhstan along with two Russian cosmonauts. The Roscosmos Soyuz MS-29 spacecraft is scheduled for lift-off from the Baikonur spaceport at 8.17 pm. (IST) on Tuesday and is expected to dock at the orbital laboratory after a little over three hours.

Besides Menon, Russian cosmonauts Pyotr Dubrov and Anna Kikina will be part of the 75th expedition to the ISS. The Soyuz spacecraft will dock at the ISS at 11.56 pm. IST on Tuesday, and the astronauts will be onboard the ISS at around 1.25 am IST early Wednesday.

Once aboard, the trio will join NASA astronauts Jessica Meir, Jack Hathaway, and Chris Williams, European Space Agency astronaut Sophie Adenot, and



Roscosmos cosmonauts Sergey Kud-Sverchikov, Sergei Mikaev, and Andrey Fedyaev. Born in Minneapolis to Ukrainian and Indian immigrants, Menon is an emergency medicine physician and a US Space Force colonel.

During his stint with the US Air Force, he served on the frontlines in Afghanistan during Operation Enduring Freedom and also worked for the Himalayan Rescue Association, caring for climbers on Mount Everest. Menon, 49, has also spent a year in India as a Rotary Ambassadorial Scholar to study and support Polio vaccination initiatives. (PTI)

27 killed, 25 critical in massive fire at Bangkok music Bar

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bangkok

A huge fire tore through a music bar in Bangkok overnight, killing at least 27 people and leaving 25 hospitalised in critical condition in the Thai capital's most deadly blaze in 17 years.

Photos from the Rong Beer Na Ladprao bar in a northern part of the Thai capital showed people fleeing as flames shot out the single-story building and thick black smoke billowed into the sky.

Shoes lost and scattered as their owners sought to flee could be seen in pictures from the aftermath of the tragedy.

Bangkok city officials said



Police officers inspecting the site of a fire in Bangkok, Thailand

the fire broke out shortly before midnight Sunday, and it was about half an hour until firefighters brought it under control.

By daylight Monday

morning, the site had been cordoned off as dozens of Thai forensic officers combed through the burned remains for clues about what caused the fire.

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ARMY PUBLIC SCHOOL, SRINAGAR BB, CANTT, BATWARA (J&K)- 190004 Website: www.apssrinagar.co.in CALL FOR QUOTATIONS

Army Public School, BB Cantt, Srinagar invites sealed quotations from reputed firms for the procurement, supply and installation, of Fire Fighting Hose Reel System for the newly constructed Foundation Wing building with all connected items including 5000 Litre Water Tank, 2 HP water pump and other ancillaries, list available on the school website. Interested firms/vendors may submit their sealed quotations in the tender box placed in the school by or before 24 Jul 2026. The school reserves the right to cancel this call for quotations without assigning any reasons.

Sd/- Principal

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE							
SR NO	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / END (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/ EMAIL	
1	PWD BSR, GURUGRAM	ANNUAL MAINTENANCE OF PLANTATION WORK IN C/V OF 1. BYE PASS/ PERIPHERY ROAD CONNECTING HISAR ROAD TO RATIA ROAD (KM 0.000 TO KM 5.000) IN TOHANA CITY IN FATEHABAD DISTT. (RD 000 TO 5000) & 2. OLD NH-9 (CTY PORTION) KM 208.90 TO 221.59 IN FATEHABAD DISTT. (RD 000 TO 5000) FOR THE YEAR 2026-27 (RD 000 TO 4500) (ODR) (MTC OF PLANTATION WORK FOR 08 MONTHS FROM 01/08/2026 TO 31/03/2027, LABOUR WORK ONLY & FILLING OF WATER IN 7000 LTR CAPACITY GOVT. WATER TANKER) AND 1 OTHER WORK	10.07.2026 20.07.2026	18.11 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9717214202 zliesinghthot@gmail.com	
2	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, CHARKHI DADRI	REGARDING REQUIREMENT OF VARIOUS TYPES OF MATERIAL IN STORE UNDER JURISDICTION OF LWS (M) SUB DIVISION NO. 2, CHARKHI DADRI.	CLOSING DATE 16.07.2026	6.31 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01250-220058 xenivsmech@gmail.com	
3	SHKM GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE NALHAR	TENDER FOR PURCHASE OF INJECTION HEPATITIS-A VACCINE FOR DEPARTMENT OF GENERAL MEDICINE AT SHAHEED HASAN KHAN MEWATI GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE NALHAR	15.07.2026 27.07.2026	1 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01267-282007 tendergmcmewat@gmail.com	
4	SHKM GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE NALHAR	TENDER FOR PROVIDING CANTEN SERVICES AT SHKM GOVERNMENT MEDICAL COLLEGE NALHAR, NUH, HARYANA	15.07.2026 29.07.2026	15.12 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01267-282007 tendergmcmewat@gmail.com	
FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in						RO 47142-I-27-7	

PROSPECT

Will, Erik win Canada, US Crossword rounds

While Will Nediger of London, Ontario, has topped the 1st round of the three-round Canada Cryptic Crossword Contest 2006, the top position has gone to Erik Agard of Kansas City, Missouri, in 1st round of US Cryptic Crossword Contest 2026.

Known as Canada Triple-C and US Triple-C, both are inaugural online events aimed at creating crossword awareness across globe. They are being organized by Extra-C, a Patna-based civil society initiative, and the World Crossword federation (WCF) with support from Bihar Tourism, Bihar Foundation, and the Bihar-Jharkhand Association of North America (BJANA).

The 2nd and the 3rd ranks in Canada Triple-C have gone to Rupert Marten Morrish of Markham, Ontario, and Daniel Currie Hall of Halifax, Nova Scotia. The same ranks, respectively, in US Triple-C have been achieved by Paolo Pasco of Brooklyn, New York, and Dan Schwartz of New York. Earlier, on July 5, the Practice Round of the events kicked off with an overwhelming response. While the top ranking in this round was exactly similar to the Round 1 ranking for Canada Triple-C, the US Triple-C rankings had shown only a little shake-up with Erik snapping at the heels of the top ranker Paolo and just a shade ahead of Mathew Theodore Marcus of Oregon, who was in 3rd place. While the Practice Round scores will not be added to the cumulative scores at the end of the 3rd and final round, it showed the enthusiasm and popular appeal of contests in the two countries. The next scoring rounds are scheduled on July 19 and 26 and will begin at 10am Pacific time/1pm Eastern Time, after which championship winners will be announced. The contests are being hosted on www.crypticsingh.com, according to press release.



Will Nediger

Will deposit ₹50cr in 45 days: SpiceJet tells HC on dispute

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

SpiceJet and its promoter Ajay Singh on Monday assured the Delhi High Court that they will deposit ₹50 crore in 45 days with the court registry in connection with a legal dispute with media baron Kalanithi Maran and Kal Airways.

Justice Subramonium Prasad — who has earlier directed SpiceJet and Singh to deposit around ₹144 crore in the case arising from an arbitral award against them in their dispute with Maran — was told that the remaining ₹94.50 crore would also be deposited in the next ninety days.

On May 4, the bench dismissed pleas by SpiceJet and Ajay Singh seeking a review of a January 19 order to deposit over ₹144 crore in the case. The Supreme Court, on May 19, however, asked the airline to approach the high court for extension of time to make the deposit.



The senior counsel for SpiceJet and its promoter on Monday informed the court that they have received financial assistance from the central government amid the ongoing West Asia crisis and undertook to pay ₹50 crore as the first instalment. He further said that the balance would also be paid in the next 90 days.

Considering the stand, the court deferred hearing till November on the airline's plea against the arbitration award.

It listed the matter in September as well on the issue of deposit of ₹144 crore with the registry.

issuance of warrants in favour of Maran after the transfer of ownership to Singh, the controlling shareholder of SpiceJet.

The dispute started after Singh took back control of SpiceJet in February 2015 amid a financial crisis at the airline.

Maran and Kal Airways had transferred their entire 35.04 crore equity shares, amounting to a 58.46 per cent stake, in SpiceJet, to its co-founder, Singh, in February 2015 for just ₹2.

In May 2024, a division bench of the high court set aside a single judge bench order which had upheld an arbitral award asking SpiceJet and Ajay Singh to refund ₹579 crore plus interest to Maran.

The division bench allowed the appeals filed by Singh and SpiceJet challenging the single judge's July 31, 2023, order and remanded the matter back to the court concerned to consider the petitions afresh.

Indian Potash inks pact with Jain Irrigation Systems



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian Potash Ltd has signed an agreement with Jain Irrigation Systems Ltd (JISL) to promote the latest irrigation technologies for sugarcane cultivation in Gujarat.

Both companies signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on the 8th of July 2026 to "collaborate on promoting scientific, sustainable, and technology-driven sugarcane cultivation across Gujarat", Indian Potash Ltd said in a statement.

The partnership will focus on the survey, design, supply, and installation of drip irrigation systems, along with capacity building, farmer training, and field demonstrations to encourage the adoption of modern sugarcane farming practices. As part of the MoU, Indian Potash and Jain Irrigation Systems will promote efficient irrigation and fertigation technologies for sustainable sugarcane cultivation.

They will demonstrate modern irrigation solutions, precision input management, and improved agronomic practices. Awareness programmes, workshops, and field demonstrations will be organised. That apart, they will facilitate access to credit and grant support for eligible farmers to adopt micro irrigation systems.

Indian Potash Ltd is one of the leading importers, suppliers and distributors of fertilizers in India. It is also engaged in the business of manufacturing sugar and bio-fuels and their by-products and other allied activities.

Hanmantrao Gaikwad: The man who did not chase success yet built it for millions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ NEW DELHI

Some people build companies. Some create wealth. But a very few dedicate their lives to building a nation. Hanmantrao Gaikwad, Founder, Chairman and Managing Director of BVG India Ltd belongs to that rare league.

From humble beginnings to leading one of India's largest integrated services groups, his journey is defined not merely by entrepreneurial success but by a commitment to creating opportunities and touching lives. Today, Gaikwad aims to positively impact 100 million lives by 2035, create one million jobs and expand BVG to 100 countries.

He stands as living proof that a dream driven by purpose can transform not just one life, but an entire nation through entrepreneurship. Born in October 1972 in



the small town of Rahimatpur, Maharashtra, he began far from privilege as his father died while he was still young leaving his mother, a humble schoolteacher, to raise the family alone.

For 21 years, mother and son shared a single hundred-square-foot room. Financial hardship never became an excuse for him, instead it became his sternest teacher. Each day he cycled 40-50 kilometres to reach college and through Maharashtra's Earn-and-Learn Scheme he worked while he studied, eventually earning his engineering degree.

Those years instilled in him resilience and discipline, and a conviction that determination could overcome even the harshest circumstances. Inspired by the teachings of Swami Vivekananda and the courage of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, he developed a vision that reached well beyond personal

unglamorous work, Gaikwad saw dignity in it, introducing mechanised housekeeping and professional facility management to India for the first time.

That modest venture has since grown into one of India's largest integrated services groups, employing more than 100,000 people across over 2,500 sites in 29 states and union territories, and serving more than 1,400 clients in over 205 cities. Its services now extend to Parliament House, Rashtrapati Bhavan, the Prime Minister's Office, the Supreme Court, IITs, IIMs, airports, metro systems and shrines including Ram Mandir at Ayodhya, Vaishno Devi and Jagannath Puri. The group has since expanded into life sciences, clean energy, agriculture and nuclear services.

Yet Gaikwad's greatest achievement is not measured in revenue. BVG's fleet

‘BSNL unaudited operational revenue up to ₹4,418 crore in Q1’

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-run BSNL has provisionally posted around a 10 per cent increase in revenue from operations in the first quarter of fiscal year 2026-27, Union Telecom Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia said on Monday.

While speaking to the media after the review meeting of BSNL for the first quarter of the current fiscal, Scindia said that BSNL's enterprise business segment and consumer mobility have shown growth while the consumer fixed access segment has remained almost flat. "As far as our total revenue is concerned, directly from business operations, we have posted close to about a 10



per cent increase in revenue over last year. Last year, we closed Q1 at ₹4,017 crores. This year, we have closed Q1 at ₹4,418 crores. So there's a delta of ₹401 crore, an increase," Scindia said.

He said BSNL's ARPU (average revenue per user) has provisionally increased from ₹100 to ₹102.7.

DAILY SUDOKU

9	4			8	5			
			9		1			6
		7		3				9
5	7	3			6			
			8			3	1	7
7				5		4		
3			6		7			
		8	4			7		2

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (13.7.26)

4	8	2	6	3	9	7	5	1
7	1	3	2	5	8	6	9	4
5	6	9	4	7	1	3	2	8
3	7	1	8	9	6	5	4	2
2	9	4	5	1	3	8	6	7
8	5	6	7	4	2	9	1	3
9	2	5	1	8	7	4	3	6
6	4	7	3	2	5	1	8	9
1	3	8	9	6	4	2	7	5

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | JULY 14, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6			
7								
10	11	12			13			
14								
			17	18			19	20
		21			22			
26							29	30
								31
34								
36								

ACROSS

4 When it's only tiny, keep quiet about a bit of pain (6)
7 He painted Mona, and maybe Noel and Dora (8)
8 Suit apt to show the dirt? (6)
10 Crop bringing anger to the workers' leader (5)
13 Clothing that may be the rage (4)
14 Invalid possessing no legal power (4)
15 No Oriental concoction of stew (4)
16 Be bent on seeming humble (3)
17 The animal to put £1 on (4)
19 Call some taxis to a house as a prank (4)
21 Solved the problem of keeping fit (6,3)

DOWN

1 Sent by air (5)
2 Hm, there isn't one! (5)
3 Shoemaker's latest model (4)
4 Biblical name for Grandma (5)
5 Close to the northeast part of Arabia (4)
6 A set form of home entertainment (3,3)
9 Sadness of a soft-headed musketeer (6)
11 A Schubert piece with heart (3)
12 Distribute to all (5)
13 No particular soldier? (7)
15 Though circular, it has a shallow end all right (3)
16 Take a knock sportingly (3)
18 Historic Parliamentarian upset by some exertion (6)
20 Open to exposure, nothing may be true! (5)
21 In two ways a big success (3)
22 It's due to be pronounced wet (3)
23 Beauty is but skin deep (6)
25 Thus quoted, in turn, with some precision (3)
28 Hates changing in a rush (5)
30 One house of a number in ruin! (5)
31 Where Americans get cross, put in a bad seat (5)
32 One posted in Picardy? (4)
33 Refereeing manual? (4)

SOLUTION (13.7.26)

1	Man-gel	21	Coral	DOWN	1	M-Ascot	19	Mop
2	Hap-p-y	22	Hap-p-y	2	Glower	20	D-ay	
3	Pest	23	Pest	3	Lied	21	Came-lot	
4	M-Op-e	24	Scrum	4	Med-i-cal	22	Hum	
5	Cro-owed	25	MA-C	5	Final	23	Pat-Ron	
6	V-sage	26	Tha-me-s	6	F-iles	24	Echo	
7	Nail	27	Mo-ther	7	P-et	25	Tur-b-ot	
8	C-all-S	28	31	8	Sam	26	Staff	
9	Thor	29	32	9	Follow-er	27	Rally	
10	Madam	30	Ernest	10	H-tch	28	Me-re	

MLAs of the Congress Party paid a courtesy visit to CM Himanta Biswa Sarma at his office chamber in the Assam Legislative Assembly in Dispur on Monday

FM calls for enhanced NRI outreach to sustain foreign currency mobilisation momentum

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday asked banks to enhance outreach to Non Resident Indians (NRIs) for greater mobilisation of foreign currency deposits.

Chairing a review meeting with CEOs of public sector banks and financial institutions on the Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank), or FCNR(B) deposits, External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs) and Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCBs) swap initiatives, Sitharaman appreciated the encouraging and enthusiastic initial response.

She called upon banks to further intensify outreach to the NRI diaspora, introduce innovative deposit products and sustain the

the United States and other overseas jurisdictions.

They outlined their plans to capitalise on the positive sentiment and accelerate deposit mobilisation during the remainder of the scheme period, it said.

They expressed confidence that ECB mobilisations would gather stronger traction during the third quarter (October-December 2026) of the current fiscal year, it said.

Public sector banks (PSBs) also informed that they have put in place customised outreach strategies, including digital channels, to engage with the non-resident Indian (NRI) diaspora and enhance deposit mobilisation, it said.

They further noted that FCNR(B) deposit mobilisation has shown a clear accelerating trend, supported by attractive returns being offered by banks, it said.

Statewide expansion for women safety inaugurated in Tamil Nadu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Securecam India has officially announced the successful completion of all five operational phases of its landmark Secure Our City (SOC) campaign within Chennai. Designed to prioritise the safety of residents, particularly women and children, the global campaign aims to create public consciousness regarding micro-level safety by providing completely free security surveillance system installations.

The latest operational updates highlight widespread coverage across critical neighborhoods in the city:

Phase 3: Brought over 800 homes across SM Nagar (Sathyavani Muthu Nagar) in Chennai Central under continuous CCTV coverage.

Phase 4: Successfully secured an additional 600 households around the Karpagam Avenue, RA Puram (Raja AnnaMalaiPuram) area.

Phase 5: Completed the targeted installation of surveillance systems for several independent and individual houses and school of specially abled kids and people in and around Chennai. (Semmanchery, perumbakkam, Tambaram, Medavakkam, Ayyappakkam, Kundrathur, Nandanpakkam).

BRIEFLY

Sinner evolving just like Federer, Nadal and Djokovic before him



A perfectly-placed topspin lob winner that sailed beyond reach of his 6-foot-6 (1.98-meter) opponent and landed on the outside of the baseline in the second game.

A delicate drop shot which made Alexander Zverev change direction so suddenly that the German player over-extended his right knee at a crucial point of the third set.

Sure, there were plenty of the usual whizzing, missile-like baseline winners from Jannik Sinner in his four-set victory over Zverev in the Wimbledon final. He also showed off the new variety of his game, though - which came in handy when Zverev unleashed more power than he had used before against the top-ranked player. The variety of shots were what Sinner's two coaches, Darren Cahill and Simone Vagnozzi, appreciated most from their player in Sunday's match.

Just like the Big Three and Big Four before them - Roger Federer, Rafael Nadal, Novak Djokovic and Andy Murray - Sinner, Zverev and Carlos Alcaraz (who is out injured) are continually evolving their games, Cahill noted.

"Alexander is now playing a different style of tennis against Jannik," Cahill said. "We know Jannik is going to have to improve in certain areas to handle that type of game. Carlos is going to come back really strong, as well - as we all hope. You need to keep adding things to his game. "We saw a lot of the stuff he doesn't normally like doing, even in the final today: sliced backhands, a couple lobs, couple drop shots. Really stepping up when he needed to in the big moments." Deficit to Alcaraz in Slams count reduced: Sinner's second consecutive Wimbledon victory matched the two titles that Alcaraz won before him at the All England Club and raised his overall tally to five Grand Slams - narrowing the gap to Alcaraz's seven. (AP)

Former Spanish leader criticised for comments about France's World Cup team



A former Spanish prime minister is facing criticism for saying that France's World Cup team "does not have any French players," which French and Spanish leaders have called racist.

Mariano Rajoy, a member of Spain's conservative Popular Party, made the comment in a column for Spanish outlet El Debate ahead of Tuesday's World Cup semifinal between the European neighbors.

"They've won every match they've played at this World Cup and are currently top of the FIFA rankings. They also have an exceptionally strong squad. That said, one thing they don't have is any French players," Rajoy wrote on July 10. On Monday, French Foreign Minister Jean-Noel Barrot told French broadcaster BFM TV that "France has no skin color. Any contrary claim stems from stupidity, racism or a combination of the two."

A day earlier, French Football Federation president Philippe Diallo wrote on X that "Mariano Rajoy's remarks about the French team carry intolerable whiffs of racism," adding that "they also raise questions about the deplorable climate that gives rise to such sentiments. Our players do not need a certificate of nationality from a former Spanish prime minister." Spain's ruling Socialist government swiftly condemned the remarks by Rajoy, who was prime minister from 2011 to 2018.

On Sunday, Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez referenced the comments without naming his predecessor, writing on X: "There are those who still measure belonging by surname, place of birth, or skin color. Others measure it by our roots in a country and our will to contribute to it. Playing soccer. Caring for our elders. Or opening businesses. France, we'll see you in the semifinals. May the best one win and may racism lose." (AP)

Named in CWG contingent, Nandakumar declared ineligible

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH ■ New Delhi

Para swimmer Tejas Nandakumar, who was named in the Indian contingent for the upcoming Glasgow Commonwealth Games, will not compete in the multi-sport event starting on July 23 as his entry has been rejected by the organisers due to a classification issue.

The 20-year-old Nandakumar's name was there in the list of competitors issued by the government last week. He was to compete in the men's 50m freestyle S7 event in Glasgow and his slot was earlier accepted by the organisers.

S7 classification in para swimming is for athletes who have the full use of their arms and trunk, but have limited leg function, are missing parts of both legs, or have limited movement in all four limbs. Nandakumar, who has previously competed in the Para-Asian Games in 2023, has a congenital condition



affecting his legs.

In a letter sent on July 9, the local organisers have informed the Indian

SHAKYA MITRA

When the draw for the 2026 FIFA World Cup was made in December 2025, few disputed that defending champions Argentina had received one of the tournament's more favourable paths. On paper, a group featuring Austria, Algeria and Jordan appeared considerably less demanding than those faced by several other contenders. Their projected knockout route also looked manageable, with possible meetings against Uruguay in the Round of 32 and the runners-up of Group G or Group D in the Round of 16, leaving Portugal as their first expected major test in the quarter-finals. By comparison, teams such as Germany, Brazil and the Netherlands faced significantly tougher routes.

There is nothing inherently wrong in receiving a favourable draw. World Cup draws are lotteries, and every nation enters the tournament knowing that luck inevitably plays a role. What has complicated Argentina's campaign, is the growing perception that they have also benefited from favourable officiating and institutional goodwill. Whether that perception is justified or not, it has become one of the defining narratives of the tournament.

This debate has lingered since Argentina's victorious 2022 World Cup campaign, their first in 36 years. Several high-profile refereeing decisions from Qatar remain frequent points of discussion, including the heated quarter-final against the Netherlands, the penalty awarded against Croatia in the semi-final, and the penalty given in the final against France fol-



lowing what looked a relatively soft challenge.

The presence of Lionel Messi inevitably amplifies this debate. Widely regarded as one of the greatest footballers in history, Messi now plays for Inter Miami and has spent the latter stages of his career based in one of the host nations of the 2026 tournament. Before lifting the World Cup in Qatar, he carried the burden of being considered perhaps the greatest player never to win football's biggest prize. That debate ended in December 2022. Now, with Messi playing his sixth World Cup while continuing to add to his extraordinary goalscoring record, every controversial decision involving Argentina is

viewed through the lens of protecting football's biggest global icon.

Events during this tournament have only strengthened that perception. Against Algeria, Messi avoided even a booking after striking the back of an opponent's leg. Against Austria, an Argentine goal stood despite protests over an alleged foul in the build-up. Viewed individually, each incident can be defended within the Laws of the Game. Taken together, however, they reinforce an existing narrative that Argentina consistently receive the benefit of doubt.

The Round of 16 victory over Egypt has become the focal point of

World Cup semifinals: Mbappe vs Yamal and Messi vs Kane



JAMES ROBSON ■ Atlanta

It's a World Cup semifinal line-up for the ages. Four previous champions and the four top-ranking teams in the world. Five of the six top scorers, one GOAT and one of the bitterest rivalries in soccer.

Argentina, Spain, France and England went into the tournament as the top four in FIFA's rankings and are two wins away from being crowned champion of the world again. It's just too close to call either semifinal matchup: France will play Spain in Arlington, Texas, on Tuesday and England will face Argentina in Atlanta on Wednesday.

Not since 1990 has the final four of a World Cup been made up entirely of previous winners. England and Argentina were involved then, although they didn't play each other. Then, like now, Argentina was the defending champion - after beating West Germany in the 1986 final in

Mexico - and went on to lose to West Germany in the 1990 final.

And this year could also see a repeat final from 2022 if France and Argentina both advance.

England vs. Argentina: A bitter rivalry: Argentina must overcome England in a match that resumes a fierce rivalry that goes beyond the soccer field, with tensions also relating to the 1982 conflict over the Falklands Islands.

On the field there have been numerous flashpoints between the teams on the World Cup stage. Argentina captain Antonio Rattin, whose death was announced on Saturday, was sent off in a bad-tempered quarter-final match against winner England in 1966. England manager Alf Ramsey tried to stop his players from swapping shirts with their opponents after a 1-0 victory.

Roll the clock forward 20 years and in 1986 Diego Maradona's infamous "Hand of God" goal

helped Argentina to a 2-1 win against England in the quarter-finals on the way to lifting the trophy.

David Beckham was sent off in 1998 for kicking out at Argentina midfielder Diego Simeone, who was predictably criticized by the English media for his reaction to what appeared to be light contact. Argentina won the round of 16 match on penalties.

Beckham got his revenge four years later by scoring a penalty in a 1-0 win that contributed to Argentina being eliminated at the group stage.

France vs. Spain: A quick chance for French revenge

France and Spain meet again in the semifinals of a major tournament, just two years since going head-to-head at the European Championship. Spain won 2-1 with a then-16-year-old Lamine Yamal on the score sheet and went on to lift the Euros by beating England in final. (AP)

What to know about rules behind FIFA WC's most contentious calls



JAMES ROBSON ■ Atlanta

It was another game-changing moment at the World Cup that had more to do with television replays in a room far away than a moment of brilliance on the field. The sending off of Switzerland's Breel Embolo in Saturday's quarterfinal game against Argentina was the latest call that may have left fans scratching their heads, not least because of the confusing name of the newly implemented law that swung the match.

It is called the "mistaken identity" rule. Yet, technically, Embolo was not shown a second yellow card - resulting in a red - for a case of mistaken identity. It was because the referee Joao Pinheiro did not see in real time that the forward had simulated a foul under a challenge from Argentina's Leandro Paredes.

Paredes was initially shown a yellow card, which is a key factor. Under FIFA rules, because Paredes was shown a card, the video assistant referee (VAR) can intervene and recommend that the on-field official review the sideline monitor. After review, the referee deemed Embolo to have committed a "clear simulation" and showed him a second yellow card and sent him off.

The rules state that the VAR can assist when the referee penalises the "wrong team for an offence that results in a red or yellow card being shown to the wrong player." It was a pivotal point in the match, coming five minutes after Switzerland had made it 1-1. Argentina won 3-1 after extra time. "The referee made the wrong decision," Switzerland coach Murat Yakin said. "I know they will protect their referee, but this rule destroyed our game today, and it's very painful, and to be eliminated in that way hurts a lot." It is not the first time at this World Cup that teams have hit out against new rules or technology.

Germany infuriated by disallowed goal: Newly tightened regulations contributed to Germany's shock elimination in the round of 32.

Defender Jonathan Tah's potentially game-winning goal in extra time against Paraguay was ruled out after VAR



review for a foul on goalkeeper Orlando Gill.

Replays showed Germany's Waldemar Anton push Gill to the ground, but the minimal contact led to criticism of the decision. FIFA's referees chief Pierluigi Collina said officials had been told to punish incidents when players try to block opponents and make no attempt to play the ball, especially where goalkeepers are concerned. Germany went on to lose the game in a penalty shootout, with Tah firing a decisive spot kick over the bar.

High tech ball costs Croatia: The words "connected ball technology" will likely haunt Luka Modric and Croatia for years to come.

The high-tech soccer ball fitted with "advanced sensors" used at this World Cup cost Croatia a dramatic late equaliser against Portugal in the round of 32.

Egypt heartbroken against Argentina: It was shaping up to be one of the great World Cup upsets. Egypt led 2-0 against defending champion Argentina in the round of 16 and might have been 3-0 up if not for VAR. (AP)

I am Terminator, Abhishek is Terminator 4, Vaibhav is Terminator 6, says Yuvraj Singh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ London

Yuvraj Singh has come up with a fitting analogy to describe the evolution of fearless Indian batters, likening himself, Abhishek Sharma and teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi to different versions of the iconic Hollywood franchise 'Terminator', starring Arnold Schwarzenegger.

The former India all-rounder, who has mentored Abhishek over the years, believes the 15-year-old Sooryavanshi represents the next stage in the progression of attacking batting and said he would be delighted to work with the youngster in the future.

Speaking to JioHotstar, Yuvraj said, "I always call myself a Terminator. Now there is Terminator 4, Abhishek Sharma, who is four times better than me. And after him comes Terminator 6, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, who has evolved even more.

"I did my part in my time, Abhishek elevated it, and now Vaibhav is setting new standards. This is the third phase of the same journey. It is great to see the sport evolving," said Yuvraj, who watched the Wimbledon



men's singles final alongside Abhishek and Sooryavanshi.

"When I watch (Jannik) Sinner and (Carlos) Alcaraz, I see how tennis is changing. I see the same evolution in Abhishek and Vaibhav. I have spent a lot of time training Abhishek, and I would love to spend

time with Vaibhav as well. He has a great career ahead of him. He is a serious player in t h e

making, and I believe he will get there."

The batting prodigy, on his part, said the interaction with Yuvraj gave him valuable lessons that extended beyond technique.

"Yuvi Paaji is my idol too. Meeting him for the first time was a special moment. I got to spend time with him and he shared a lot of insights about the game.

"He spoke about the mental side of the game, how to handle pressure, and the importance of believing in yourself. It feels great to have so much to learn from someone like him. I am sure it will help me a lot in my career going forward," Vaibhav Sooryavanshi said.

Abhishek, who has flourished under Yuvraj's mentorship, said he could relate to the teenager's emotions.

"I can feel what Vaibhav is feeling right now because Yuvi Paaji is my idol as well. I remember when I first met him, it was kind of the same feeling that he's feeling right now.

"So obviously, watching my first Wimbledon, and that too the finals, with Yuvi Paaji and Vaibhav, it's a special day for me," Abhishek said.



Baartman's consistency in hitting right areas key to his success: Steyn

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Johannesburg

Former South Africa pace great Dale Steyn is mighty impressed with Ottneil Baartman's consistency and believes it has been the primary reason for his continued success in the SA20 league.

Baartman is the leading wicket-taker in the four-season history of the SA20, and Steyn has worked with him in the past at Sunrisers Eastern Cape.

Baartman, who has claimed 61 wickets across

four seasons, dismissed 20 batters in just nine matches during his maiden stint for the Paarl Royals in the 2025-26 edition and played a significant role in David Miller and Co reaching the second qualifier before they were knocked out by the eventual champions, Sunrisers Eastern Cape.

"I'm always looking at guys who can consistently land the

ball in the right area. The thing about T20 cricket is that you can bowl badly and still pick up wickets. You can get your bad ball caught on the boundary or something like that,"

Steyn said, speaking to SA20. "But for me, somebody like Ottneil Baartman, what he's done season after season has earned him a spot in that South African team.

I'm looking at guys who can consistently land ball in hot zone for a long period of time."

Best is yet to come: First female Test centurion at Lord's Yastika Bhatia

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ London

India wicketkeeper-batter Yastika Bhatia believes her "best is yet to come" after she became the first woman cricketer to hit a Test century at the iconic Lord's stadium, marking an incredible comeback from a career-threatening knee injury last year.

Bhatia struck 113 off 158 before India declared their second innings at the stroke of tea on day three, setting hosts England a massive 457-run target. "It's unbelievable because six months ago I was in a very different place and if you would have told me that I would have my name in the honours board I wouldn't have believed it," Bhatia said after third day's play.

"The best is yet come, I have always believed that. But so far it's really good and I enjoyed my time in the middle. It's just the beginning, a lot more to come and I am looking forward to that," he added.

She credited her family, teammates and support staff for helping her recover from the career-threatening torn ACL in her left knee that she sustained in October last year. The injury, which needed a surgery, prevented her from competing in India's ODI World Cup-winning campaign at home. "A lot of people have been working behind the scenes, my family, my father, mother, my sister they have been the biggest backbone, support. My coaches, trainers back home, the support staff and teammates here, they have backed me," she said.

Zach Johnson wins at Firestone for first senior major title

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Akron (Ohio)

Zach Johnson won his first PGA Tour Champions major in the final event at Firestone Country Club, closing with a 2-under 68 for a six-shot victory Sunday in the Kaulig Companies Championship.

Johnson had a 63 in the third round that staked him to a four-shot lead entering the final round, and even with a pair of bogeys in his opening four holes, no one came particularly close. Johnson



chipped in from 20 feet on his last hole.

It was Johnson's third win in his rookie season on the 50-and-older PGA Tour Champions, allowing him to close the gap on Stewart Cink in the Charles Schwab Cup.

BCCI must scrutinise team management's role: Saba Karim

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Former national selector Saba Karim has urged the BCCI to scrutinise the Indian team management's role in the unprecedented twin T20I series debacles against Ireland and England and take appropriate measures.

India lost 0-2 to Ireland and were whitewashed 0-4 by

England in back-to-back T20I series defeats.

"After such a disastrous series — a whitewash with huge margins of defeat — no one can abdicate responsibility — not only the support staff including Head Coach Gautam Gambhir but also the captain (Shreyas Iyer) and the vice-captain (Tilak Varma)," Karim said. (PTI)



Prince William and wife Kate share a moment with Jannik Sinner after his Wimbledon victory

MATTIAS KAREN ■ London

Prince William joined his wife Kate and two of their children for the men's final at Wimbledon on Sunday in a star-studded Royal Box that also included actors Dustin Hoffman, Nicole Kidman and Ben Stiller.

Kate is the patron of the All-England Club and presented the trophy to winner Jannik Sinner after his match against Alexander Zverev. She also handed out the trophy to women's winner Linda Noskova on Saturday, but was not joined by any family members.

The couple's two eldest children, Prince George and Princess Charlotte, also attended Sunday's match. All four were on hand to watch Sinner beat Carlos Alcaraz in last year's final as well. After the win over Zverev, the royals had an extended chat with Sinner in a room inside the tournament's main stadium as he clutched the golden trophy.



"Fantastic achievement, Kate told Sinner. "It's really inspiring to the children to see tennis at that level."

Sinner then asked the young royals how often they play tennis themselves. "Not every day, but weekends," George

said. Sinner had a similar conversation with the four royals after last year's final. "You can really see that they love the sport," Sinner said Sunday.

"This is exactly how we feel as players on court when we see them watching tennis. Staying there

for four hours under the sun with the heat, it's really nice. ... Having the whole Royal Box there, as well, the whole people staying for a match like this for four-ish hours, it's amazing. That's also the reason why we love to play tennis." (AP)

7 bronze medals secured in Asian U-19 and U-23 Boxing Championships

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Jakarta

Indian boxers remained a strong force at the Asian U-19 and U-23 Championships with eight of them advancing to the finals across men's and women's U-23 categories and seven others securing bronze medals after semifinal finishes in Jakarta. In the U-23 women's category, five Indian boxers progressed to the finals.

Nisha (54kg) defeated Hyeju Lee of Korea, while Nikita Chand (60kg) registered a win against Sari Kokufu of Japan.

Kajal (65kg) sailed past Gulzina Melsvek of Kyrgyzstan



on Sunday. In all the bouts referees had to stop the contest due to Indians' overwhelming domination. In the higher weight categories, Muskan (75kg) won 5:0 against Toirova Oysha of Uzbekistan while Priyanka (+80kg) recorded a dominant 5:0 win over Panar

Seitkhankyzy Kazakhstan. In the U-23 men's category, three Indian boxers advanced to finals. Vishvanath Suresh (50kg) delivered a commanding 5:0 win over his Philippines opponent, while Ganga (55kg) edged past Japan with a 3:2 split decision.

Under-fire India turn to Ro-Ko to find winning touch against England

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Birmingham

Veterans Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma will not only have to perform for themselves but also play a key role in lifting the sagging Indian spirits against an upbeat England when the two sides clash in a three-match ODI series, starting here on Tuesday.

Kohli and Rohit, along with Jasprit Bumrah, are back in the mix to play the format in which bilaterals have been losing both context and sheen amid growing popularity of T20 cricket.

The 39-year-old Rohit and the soon-to-be 38 Kohli still have the fire in their bellies and the runs to show for their efforts as they aim for a ODI World Cup swansong.

Facing Jofra Archer and Josh Tongue on tracks, which are spicier compared to sub-continental featherbeds, is a different challenge. But the duo has smashed



English bowlers enough over the years to know what is required of them.

But their presence for this series certainly holds more significance after the Indian team, under a new T20 skipper

Shreyas Iyer, lost all but one of its seven T20I matches in the ongoing tour.

The only match they didn't lose was a game that got abandoned. The 0-2 defeat versus Ireland and 0-4 thrashing handed

by England has opened a Pandora's Box with BCCI calling for a performance review.

In this backdrop, a team management, which hasn't exactly made things easier for the two modern day legends, will be compelled to welcome them with open arms in order to stem the rot.

An ODI series win can hardly gloss over the inadequacies of T20 squad's disastrous show but it would certainly work as a confidence-booster.

The return of skipper Shubman Gill, another prolific 50-over batter and the experienced KL Rahul, makes it a fabulous quartet of top-order batters, who can turn any game on its head.

Add Shreyas Iyer to the mix, and there should be little concern about the batting unit. However, it is the bowling unit that needs to do some serious strategic thinking even as Bumrah, after a well-earned rest, makes a comeback.

Zverev hopes he can be more than just 'the third guy' in tennis

MATTIAS KAREN ■ London

Alexander Zverev is used to being "the third guy" in tennis. After following up his French Open title with a run to his first Wimbledon final, he's hoping to be more than that in the future.

Despite losing to Jannik Sinner on Centre Court on Sunday, the 29-year-old Zverev thinks he is closer than ever to challenging the top-ranked Italian and his main rival Carlos Alcaraz and giving tennis a Big Three again.

Sinner and Alcaraz had won the last nine Grand Slam tournaments between them before Zverev won his first major at Roland Garros this year.

"There was always this conversation, who will be the third guy?" Zverev said. "I've always been the third guy, but I was just far away from those two. But I've always been No. 3 in a way. So if I get closer to them ... it would be great."

Alcaraz missed this year's French Open — and Wimbledon — with a wrist injury, and Sinner was eliminated in the second round in Paris after wilting in the heat. (AP)

